

# Hogwarts, 1347

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# 1      The Gatehouse and the          Glint of Copper

The cobblestones of London in the year of our Lord 1347 were slick with a persistent, greasy film, smelling of woodsmoke, tidal Thames mud and thousands of different animals — some confined to cages, others tethered to posts, and still others wandering freely. The ceaseless din of the city was a tapestry of sounds: the clatter of cart wheels, the gruff cries of street vendors hawking their goods, and the resonant clang of the blacksmith's hammer. Looming in the distance, a defiant, hulking mass of grey stone and timber, was the great London Bridge.

It was more than just a crossing; it was a street in itself, laden with tall, crooked houses, shops spilling over with goods, and the Chapel of St. Thomas on its central pier, its foundations plunged deep into the choppy, brown water below. The human tide traversing the bridge was thick and unrelenting—merchants in wool and spices, pilgrims with staves, apprentices running errands, and beggars seeking alms in the shadows beneath the gabled roofs.

On this particular day, the air was heavy with the late-summer heat, thick with the scent of sun-baked earth and the faint aroma of freshly baked bread spilling from a nearby bakery. A vibrant energy animated the crowd, a cheerful buzz of bartering and gossip that tightened faces with laughter and hastened the steps of merchants eager to make a sale. The city's prosperity was evident in the rich fabrics and lively chatter, casting a bright, warm glow over the busy marketplace.

A woman and a boy walked hand-in-hand through the press of people. Alianor Blackwood, was a striking figure, her hair a cascade of bright, fiery red that managed to look both vibrant and slightly unruly beneath the simple linen hood of her mantle. Her eyes, shrewd and a little tired, constantly scanned the crowd. She kept her grip firm on the small hand of her son, Thomas.

Thomas, eleven years old and impossibly pale, was her inverse in colouring. His hair was a shock of bright, pale gold — so luminous it appeared nearly

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white and seemed to capture the summer sunlight, giving him an ethereal quality that occasionally drew curious, if brief, stares from the muggles passersby.

“Hold close, Thomas,” Alianor murmured, pulling him closer to her side as a heavy-laden mule cart clattered past, narrowly missing their feet.

“Mother,” Thomas said, his voice a clear, high chime that cut through the cacophony. “Why is it we must go through the bridge gate? Is there not a simpler way there?”

Alianor gazed toward the distant, monumental structure of the London Bridge. From this distance, it was a dark, formidable line across the Thames, a jumble of stone arches and the taller shapes of the houses and shops built upon its back. “This path is the one your father, God rest his soul, always took. Although it may not be the most direct route to Diagon Alley, it is for sure the most discreet, . . . and we must make a stop elsewhere first.”

Today was the day. The day she would take Thomas to Diagon Alley to buy the things he needed for his first term at Hogwarts School of Witchcraft and Wizardry. It was a day of profound pride, and a deep, coiling dread.

The passage to the colossal stone bridge commenced deep within the bewildering maze of London’s cramped, twisting lanes, many still paved with cobblestones and heavy with the stench of garbage and coal smoke. They moved along the crowded main roads leading toward the south, such as Fish Street Hill, constantly having to avoid burden-carrying porters and the ceaseless flow of people, horses, and carts. The final approach to the bridge was marked by a towering stone gatehouse — a fortified edifice that frequently displayed prisoners in iron cages or shackled to the walls, a grim warning and deterrent to criminals and thieves. Once past this constriction, they emerged onto the bridge’s causeway. This was a bustling, covered thoroughfare of timber-framed structures built directly across the River Thames.

## The Crossed Keys

“There,” she said. She indicated the entrance to a small establishment with a nod. Beside the door stood a tall, wooden post, from which a cloth banner swayed. Embroidered on the banner was the intricate image of two crossed



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iron keys. The Crossed Keys was a famous, long-established ale house — a place known for its strong drink and rough crowd of merchants, sailors, and Londoners seeking a view of the river. It was this ale house, with its legitimate and very loud presence, that concealed the passage.

The entrance was peculiar. It featured two, thick wooden doors separated by a small, shallow space — a feature meant to act as a draught lobby or airlock to prevent the chill winter air from sweeping directly into the warmth of the common room every time the door opened. For wizards, however, this tight space served another function. Beneath the grime and the mundane, this architectural necessity was also a carefully concealed, discrete magical gateway.

Alianor pulled Thomas into the tight, unlit space between the two doors. It smelled heavily of stale ale, sawdust, and wet wool. She placed his small hands on the large iron handle of the inner door.

“The way is forward, Thomas,” she whispered. “Twist it as your father taught you.”

Thomas gripped the handle and twisted it firmly in the anticlockwise direction. Instead of the noisy common room of the ale house, the door opened onto a long, narrow corridor that seemed to defy the architecture of the bridge. The passage felt as though it had been carved directly into the hollows of the timber-framed buildings, the walls uneven and split as if the structures themselves had been pulled apart to make room. Dozens of doors lined both sides of the hallway, each one distinct—some of rotting oak, others of reinforced iron or colourful painted wood.

They walked south, passing three such portals until they reached a red door, tastefully ornate with intricate iron scrollwork. Thomas reached out, again twisting the handle anticlockwise. The door swung open into what appeared to be a void of absolute darkness. Yet, as they stepped across the threshold, the world ignited.

## The Sanctuary of Elias Robbert Fox

They emerged into a vast, cavernous room, brilliantly illuminated by the flickering warmth of numerous candelabras, torches, and oil lamps. The

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space was a labyrinth of knowledge and commerce, densely packed with towering shelves of books, bundles of rolled parchments, and a dizzying array of magical artefacts that hummed with a collective, low-frequency energy.

Standing guard at the entrance were two wizards in long, heavy robes of brown wool. The garments were reminiscent of Franciscan habits but lacked the circular cowl, featuring instead a sharp V-shaped collar and a deeper, darker hue.

The first was tall and clean-shaven with pale skin and long, dark brown hair. He held his hands together, clutching a light wood wand that was elegant in its simplicity.

The second wizard had dark skin and short black hair peppered with white follicles. His wand was a masterpiece of African blackwood, carved with minute figurines and inlaid with bronze details that flowed seamlessly into the woodwork.

Further into the room, three house-elves stood like sentinels. Unlike the raggedly dressed elves Alianor had seen elsewhere, these wore clean white mantles and leather sandals. They stood before a large table where a man was struggling to stand.

Elias Robbert Fox, a man in his early sixties with thinning light brown hair, leaned heavily on a chair for support. His body was crooked, and his face told a story of violence: two large scars carved across his features and neck, with another visible on his right arm, disappearing up his sleeve. As he saw Alianor, a smile tugged at the scar covering part of his lips.

The moment Alianor crossed the threshold, the concealment spell on her right ear flickered and died. A stunning piece of Byzantine jewellery—a large, lustrous pearl held by detailed silver—was revealed.

“Mr. Fox,” Alianor began, but the man raised a trembling hand.

“Call me Hob, Alianor,” he rasped, his voice full of old affection. “It has been too long, and I know I look... different.” He gestured vaguely to his scars and his twisted posture. “Edward would have seen the trap coming. Your husband would have prevented the attack that left me like this.”

Hob Fox was a rarity—a Muggle who had stumbled into the wizarding world by accident. Having no magic of his own, he had built an empire as a

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merchant of rare items, becoming indispensable to the Wizards' Council and Hogwarts professors alike. However, his success among the elite had earned him bitter enemies within the more conservative, "pure-blood" circles of the community.

## The Bargain

Alianor touched the pearl earring. "I have need of currency, Hob. This is a Byzantine specimen, silver and pearl."

"Why not the goblin banks, Alianor?" Fox looked at the piece, then at her.

"Because," she said, glancing at the two guard wizards, "I may also require the services of your men now that Thomas is headed to Hogwarts."

The tall, long-haired wizard stepped forward and took the earring. He closed his eyes, sensing the residue of the concealment spell. "The magic here is strong," he murmured, looking at Thomas with a piercing gaze. "Raw and instinctive."

He looked the boy in the eye. "Forget the instinct, lad. Master the wand. You don't want to end up like Ivar the Wandless."

"Who was that?" Thomas asked, his curiosity piqued.

"A Blackwood like you," the wizard replied grimly. "A powerful wizard who thought he was beyond the need for wood and core. He was powerful, ... powerful yet defeated because he lacked the focus a wand provides, ... defeated by a lesser wizard. You will learn about him at Hogwarts I suppose."

Mr. Fox gave a knowing wink to one of the house-elves standing at the foot of his table. With practiced efficiency, the elf reached into a fold of its clean white mantle and produced a small leather purse, carefully placing a handful of heavy gold Galleons, silver Sickles, and bronze Knuts inside it. The creature then stepped forward on its sandalled feet and presented the purse to Alianor with a shallow bow. She took the weight of the coins in her hand, her thumb expertly flicking through the metal as she counted the value. A flash of discontentment crossed her shrewd features, her lips thinning as she realised the exchange was less than she had hoped for, but she caught Hob's gaze and decided to remain silent, tucking the currency

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into her satchel.

Hob Fox then winked at the dark-skinned wizard, who drew his ornate wand. With a few deft movements, the wizard carved a beautiful earring from a scrap of dark wood, folding a thin silver filament into the base. He flicked his wand in a silent incantation, handing the finished object to Alianor.

“If you hold this piece while within London,” the wizard said, “I will know.”

Alianor tucked the token away. “And what of the wand, Hob? The one Edward made for the boy and entrusted to you?”

Fox sighed, leaning back against his table. “After the attack... Well, I decided this room was no longer safe enough. I hid it in a better place, in plain sight, among thousands of others. I entrusted its care to Gilbert Ollivander.”

The pair bid the merchant farewell and retreated back into the narrow corridor. They walked to the very end of the passage, where a door stood positioned diagonally across the corner. Thomas reached for the handle, rotated it anticlockwise, and the clean, cool air of the magical world rushed to meet them.

They stepped out, and Thomas gasped. They were no longer in the shadows of the bridge; they stood in the mouth of a bustling, vibrant, and utterly magical street: Diagon Alley.

## 2 Of Crooked Chimneys and Sapphire Sparks

The street was narrow, but the buildings on either side seemed to soar impossibly high, their architecture a riot of the medieval and the magically enhanced—gabled roofs, crooked chimneys that puffed sparks of emerald and sapphire, and windows that glittered with untold enchantments. The ground was paved with smooth, dark stone, and the crowd was a colourful mix of wizards and witches in robes of every cut and colour, interspersed with their children, some carrying cages and others clutching hefty books.

“The money, Thomas,” Alianor murmured, reaching into her purse and handing him a handful of unfamiliar, heavy coins. “Keep it safe.” The coins were Galleons—large, heavy gold pieces, round and bearing the image of a creature, alongside smaller Sickles of silver and Knuts of bronze.

As they stepped fully onto the thoroughfare, Thomas’s eye was instantly drawn to a series of paper posters plastered somewhat haphazardly upon a sturdy stone wall of a building across the lane.

He froze.

The posters, with surprisingly high detail for the time, showed the image of a woman in her mid-thirties, her face etched with a mix of fierce determination and a subtle, unsettling sorrow. Her hair, like his, was blond, almost white. She was holding a wand in her left hand with an almost aggressive confidence.

The bold, stark lettering beneath her image, written in a magically indelible ink, declared a single, haunting question:

“What happened to Mary Elizabeth Blackwood, legendary Auror of the Council?”

He stared at the face. The posters around it only deepened the mystery. One proclaimed her “The Left Hand of the Wizards’ Council”. Another spoke of

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her as a “Legendary Turney and Jousting Champion”.

A strange, prickling sensation ran across Thomas’s scalp. Instinctively, he raised his left hand and passed it quickly over his bright, pale hair.

As his fingers brushed the roots, the colour shifted. It darkened, deepening to a shade of dark brown, a rich, earthy colour that grounded his features. At the same time, the sickly pale tone of his skin warmed, gaining a healthier, almost tanned glow. The change was swift, subtle, and profound. His piercing grey eyes, however, remained the same colour.

He looked back at his mother. Alianor, who had been watching the street, turned to him and saw the change in his hair, the intense focus on the wall, and the sudden fear in his pale eyes. She only gave a small, almost imperceptible nod.

“We move, Thomas,” she said, her voice firm. “We have much to do.”

## **The Scribe & The Serpent**

Their first stop was a shop that seemed to vibrate with a low, thrumming energy. It was a dusty, cramped store with tall piles of worn books and scrolls. Alianor Blackwood gripped her son Thomas’s shoulder protectively as they stepped over the threshold of The Scribe & The Serpent.

Inside, the smell of new parchment and dust was overwhelming. A small, bespectacled witch was using her wand to lift stacks of heavy, leather-bound books and organise them onto precariously high shelves. In the corner of the shop, enchanted feathers, moving on their own, meticulously copied texts from old scrolls onto fresh, cream-coloured parchments. As soon as the script was complete, the newly inscribed parchments neatly folded themselves and began to stack with perfect precision. A charmed, silver needle then danced into motion, expertly sewing the stacked parchments together along one edge, seamlessly forming the gathered pages that would become the core of a new book. With a rustle of displaced air, robust hard covers then flew from a nearby shelf to join the newly sewn pages. They were built for permanence: thick wooden boards, often oak or beech, were covered in sturdy leather like pigskin or calfskin. Their binding was a heavy-duty affair, as they were sewn directly onto leather thongs or cords that were firmly attached to the boards.

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Practical, decorative metal fittings — clasps, corner pieces, and bosses — were frequently used to embellish them, with the result that they were made exceptionally heavy, thick, and undeniably sturdier than most contemporary covers.

The shopkeeper, whose beard looked woven from cobwebs, scraped a stool back.

“We require the first-year books for Hogwarts,” Alianor said, smoothing her simple wool gown. She produced a rolled parchment from her satchel and unfurled it with a practised snap.

“Very well,” the shopkeeper croaked, barely looking up.

Alianor read from the top of the list: “For Charms: *Fundamenta Incantationum: Volumen Primum* — Foundations of Enchantment: Volume I.”

The shopkeeper grunted, shuffled over to a back shelf, and returned with a formidable leather-and-wood volume edged with protective silver-leaf. “This is the one your son will spend most time with,” he said, setting it down on the counter. “Basic levitation and illumination, nothing too strenuous.”

Alianor nodded, running a thumb over the cold metal. She glanced back at her parchment. “For Transfiguration: *Dissolutio et Reformatio Rerum Simplicium* — The Unmaking and Remaking of Simple Things.”

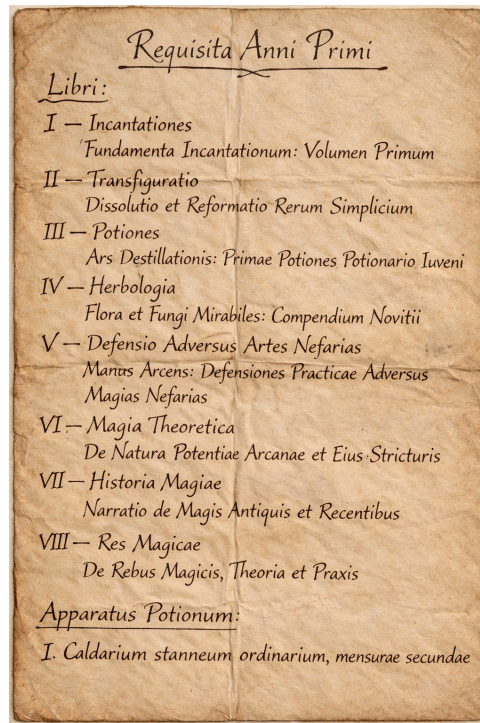
The shopkeeper set down a massive, scarred volume. “Dragon hide binding, that one. Very durable. Focuses mostly on turning one simple, small object into another.”

Thomas, eyes wide, whispered, “Like turning a feather into a pin?”

“Exactly so, boy,” the shopkeeper confirmed.

Alianor read the next title from her list. The shopkeeper shuffled to the back and returned with another volume. She read another. He fetched another. And another.

Thomas watched the tower of knowledge grow on the counter with mounting apprehension. Potions. Herbology. Defence Against the Dark Arts. Theoretical Magic. History of Magic. Each book was heavier than the last, each title longer and more intimidating than the one before it. He tried to imagine carrying them all, never mind reading them, never mind understanding them,



and felt a quiet, sinking dread settle in his stomach. The counter groaned under the collective weight.

Alianor read the final title from her list: “For Magical Artefacts: *De Rebus Magicis, Theoria et Praxis* — Magical Artefacts, Theory and Practice.”

The shopkeeper pushed forward one last thick, heavy volume. “Covers the essence and use of common enchanted items — wands, brooms, mirrors, that sort of thing. Crucial for understanding how many things around us work.”

“That seems... extensive,” Alianor said, looking at the formidable tower of knowledge for her eleven-year-old.

“It is Hogwarts,” the shopkeeper sniffed. “Learning requires weight.” He paused, looking Thomas up and down with keen, narrow eyes. “The boy... does he command the Latin tongue well?”

Alianor shifted her weight. “He understands it, yes.”

“All these texts, madam, are written in Latin, save for some footnotes. It is also the common language used to minister the courses at the school, and



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the basis for most spells. While the English tongue is useful in the corridors, your son will need fluent Latin to follow his Professors and understand the finer points of the magical theory and incantations. He will also need it to communicate with many of his peers, who come from all corners of the British Isles, Normandy, and even farther east. It is the language of higher learning.”

A small, genuine smile touched Alianor’s lips. “My late husband was insistent upon it. We lived in Hogsmeade when Thomas was very young, and his father taught him to speak it almost before he could run. After his passing and our move to London, I hired him a tutor, a Master Edmund, a very good one. Thomas has a solid grasp of it, I promise you. His private library, while entirely mundane, is quite extensive for a Muggle’s collection. He will not be found wanting for reading practice.”

The shopkeeper let out a satisfied grunt, finally accepting the situation. “Very well. A well-prepared student is a boon to the school. Now, we must gather the rest of your apparatus. You’ll need a *calamus scriptorius*, or a self-scribing charmed quill.”

He gestured to the stack of heavy books. “You’ll learn all about them in your Magical Artefacts course, I suppose. But for now, know that you’ll need it to copy the texts in the Hogwarts Library. Some of those manuscripts are far too delicate to be handled by a trembling young hand, and far too long to be copied by a slow one.”

The shopkeeper shuffled a few steps and reached into a carved wooden box lined with deep purple velvet. He withdrew a beautiful, snowy-white feather quill, fitted with a slender nib. It was decorated with small and tasteful silver ornaments woven near the base, glinting subtly in the dim light.

“This one,” the shopkeeper announced, holding it out for Thomas to see. “Is top-grade for a first-year. It is fluent in Latin, naturally, but also the English tongue, Celt, Scott, Irish, Norman French, and Greek — with a clear Byzantine influence in the last one.”

Thomas reached for it with reverence, careful not to touch the delicate tip. It felt strangely light, yet humming with purpose.

Alianor tilted the box, catching the light on the silver ornaments, and raised an eyebrow at the faint price stamped beneath the velvet lining. “A charming piece,” she commented, the warmth of her tone not quite reaching her shrewd

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eyes. “But the cost, I fear, is even more charming. It is a steep sum for a first-year’s writing instrument, enchanted or otherwise. Could you not, perhaps, offer a slight reduction for a young boy with such an extensive book list?”

The shopkeeper paused, considering the tower of tomes they had just bought. He stroked his woven beard, conceding a point with a slow nod. “Very well. For a student of such evident preparation, I will shave the price of one Sickle, no more. But I will include a basic, non-charmed Raven Feather quill — for his examinations, where such charms are, naturally, strictly forbidden. And,” he reached into a drawer, producing a slender wood piece with a silver rod tip, “a silverpoint<sup>1</sup>. It is not enchanted, but it is excellent for detailed illustrations in his Herbology and Potions texts, a favourite of great Muggle artists like Giotto di Bondone and Pietro Cavallini. A little extra value, free of charge.”

Alianor gave a slight, satisfied smile at the concession, accepting the silverpoint and the extra quill. “A fair bargain.”

## Eeylops

After leaving the bookshop, Alianor and Thomas approached their next destination: Eeylops Owl Emporium and Bestiary. As they pushed through the door, they were immediately struck by the sheer quantity and variety of owls, their cages stacked from the floor to the rafters. The air was alive with a symphony of soft cooing, sharp chirps, and the occasional dry rustle of feathers.

Thomas moved through the aisles in wonder, his eyes darting between the different species:

- Barn Owls: Their distinct, heart-shaped white faces and pale plumage made them look like ghosts flickering in the dim shop light.
- Long-eared Owls: Slender birds that sat perfectly still, their tall head

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<sup>1</sup>Silverpoint — A drawing instrument consisting of a thin rod of silver set into a wooden or metal stylus. It produces fine, precise lines on prepared surfaces and was favoured by artists such as Giotto di Bondone, Pietro Cavallini, and later Leonardo da Vinci. The marks cannot be erased, demanding a confident hand.

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tufts giving them a look of constant, startled alertness.

- Little Owls: Small, compact, and fierce-looking with bright yellow eyes and mottled brown feathers, they bobbed their heads as the pair passed.
- Great Grey Owls: Large, imposing birds with massive, circular facial discs and piercing yellow eyes that seemed to track every movement with unnerving intelligence.

Thomas stopped, mesmerised, before a massive Eurasian Eagle-Owl. It was a titan among birds, boasting prominent ear tufts and intense, fiery orange eyes that glowed like embers. Its powerful talons gripped a heavy perch, and its mottled tawny and black feathers gave it an air of authority. Nearby, a Snowy Owl sat in stark contrast, its plumage a brilliant, speckled white that seemed to capture what little light reached the corner of the shop.

“They are magnificent, Mom,” Thomas whispered, reaching toward the Eagle-Owl’s cage.

“They are,” Alianor agreed, gently pulling his hand back. “But that one in particular is far too easy to spot. It would draw every eye from London to Hogsmeade. We need something more discreet, Thomas. A Tawny Owl is a far better choice—they are the most common owls in England and Scotland, making them the perfect, inconspicuous messenger.”

The emporium keeper, a wiry man named Silas Vane, looked up from a ledger. “A wise mother you have, boy,” he said, beckoning them toward a cage near the counter. Inside sat a young Tawny Owl, its feathers a beautiful, soft mosaic of rich browns and greys, designed for perfect camouflage. “This one is young, mind you. That means he’s playful and full of energy — perhaps a bit destructive with a loose scroll or a stray quill — but that should resolve itself with time and proper training.”

Silas opened the cage slightly, and the bird let out a melodic hoot. “He’s an affectionate sort, has a marvellous recall, and he’s fast,” Silas added with a wink. “Really fast.”

“Does he have a name?” Thomas asked, watching the owl tilt its head curiously.

“I’ve been calling him Pippin,” Silas replied. “You may change it if you like, of course.”

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Thomas looked at his mother, and they both shared a rare, genuine smile. “Pippin,” Thomas repeated, the name feeling right. “I like it.”

Alianor turned to Silas, her expression shifting back to her usual shrewdness. “And the price for young Pippin?” When Silas named a sum, Alianor’s eyebrow arched—it was higher than she had anticipated.

“He is a prime specimen, Mr. Vane,” she countered smoothly, “but he is also, by your own admission, quite the handful for a first-year student.” After a brief, spirited bout of bargaining, Silas finally relented with a sigh.

“Very well,” Silas grumbled, though his eyes twinkled. “I’ll match your price, and I’ll even include a large sack of owl treats to keep him occupied while he learns his manners.”

## Slug & Jiggers

Leaving the bright activity of the street behind, Alianor and Thomas stepped into the dim, pungent atmosphere of the Slug & Jiggers Apothecary. The shop was a sensory assault; a heavy, complex scent of rotted cabbage and salted fish hung in the air, punctuated by sharper, more exotic notes of crushed herbs and dried resins. From the low, timbered ceiling hung bundles of dried feathers, leathery bat wings, and long, shimmering strings of dragon liver that swayed slightly in the draft.

Shadows danced across the floor, cast by the flickering green flames of a small hearth at the back. Shelves climbed every inch of the walls, crowded with thousands of glass jars containing everything from cloudy, swirling liquids to the bright, unblinking eyes of newts.

Just inside the entrance, perched atop a velvet-covered pedestal, sat an exquisite cauldron. It was a masterpiece of craftsmanship, forged from copper, polished and with ornate porcelain handles hand-painted with delicate floral patterns and reinforced with gleaming bronze filigree around the rim. Thomas stopped in his tracks, his eyes wide with admiration.

“Wow,” he murmured, reaching out to touch the cool porcelain.

“A fine piece,” the apothecary called out. He was a stooped man with stained fingers and a smudge of silver powder on his cheek. He emerged from behind

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a mountain of dried roots. “But not the best choice for the rigors of Hogwarts. You’ll want something that can survive a mismanaged potion or a clumsy lad’s elbow.”

He reached beneath a heavy wooden counter and hauled up a far more utilitarian vessel. “A standard pewter iron cauldron, size number two. It’s the requirement for the school and a much sturdier option.” He set it down with a heavy, metallic *thunk*. It was made of thick, dark cast iron—plain, unadorned, and fitted with simple, sturdy stoneware handles designed for function over form.

Alianor nodded in agreement, unfurling a long roll of parchment that crinkled loudly in the quiet shop. “We shall take the iron one. We also require the rest of the list: a set of glass phials, a dozen horned slugs, porcupine quills, and a set of brass scales.”

The storekeeper turned to the massive back wall, his hands moving with practiced grace. He retrieved a set of crystal-clear phials, nesting them in straw, then scooped a handful of dried, knobby horned slugs into a small tin. He added a bundle of sharp, translucent quills and a gleaming set of brass scales, placing each item one by one into the belly of the iron cauldron.

“And the total for the lot?” Alianor asked, her hand already hovering over her coin purse.

The apothecary reached for a wooden abacus sitting on the counter. It was a sturdy frame of dark oak, with polished stone beads sliding along brass rods. He moved the beads with a rhythmic *click-clack*, calculating the cost of the ingredients and the equipment with effortless speed.

“That will be seven Galleons and four Sickles,” he announced.

Alianor paused, a look of genuine surprise and pleasure softening her sharp features. The price was significantly lower than she had budgeted for. Sensing a rare moment of financial breathing room, she looked around the shelves.

“Do you happen to have an oil scented with myrrh<sup>1</sup> ?” she inquired.

The apothecary nodded and reached for a top shelf, pulling down a small, elegant ceramic flask sealed with wax. “A fine choice. It’s a base of sweet

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<sup>1</sup>Myrrh — An aromatic resin from trees of the genus *Commiphora*, native to Arabia and the Horn of Africa, prized since antiquity for its perfume.

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almond oil, heavily scented with pure myrrh and stabilised with a touch of ambergris as a fixative. It will last a long time.”

Alianor took the flask and turned to Thomas, her expression firm but not unkind. “I want you presentable, Thomas. Clean, combed, and perfumed for your professors and colleagues. The Blackwood name shall be associated with discipline, not the smell of a stable.”

She placed the small ceramic flask into the cauldron atop the scales. With the heavy iron vessel tucked under Thomas’s arm, they stepped back out into the vibrant chaos of Diagon Alley.

## Ollivanders

Finally, they stood before the shop Thomas had been anticipating, and dreading, the most. The building was old, narrower than its neighbours, and seemed to emanate a profound stillness. Over the single, dusty window, faded lettering announced: “Ollivanders, makeres of fyne wandis, sythen 382 B.C.” Ollivanders: makers of fine wands since 382 B.C.

The interior of the shop was just as Thomas had imagined: quiet, dusted with a golden, moted light, and utterly dominated by wands and its small boxes.

Hundreds of thin, square boxes were stacked meticulously from the floor to the high, shadowy ceiling on the opposite side of the counter. The air was cool, dry, and charged with an almost palpable energy.

Behind a high, polished counter stood Gilbert Ollivander, the current proprietor. He was an elderly man, sharp-eyed, with thin hair and long, calloused and strong hands that seemed to have a life independent of his body. He was carefully cataloging a piece of dark, knotty wood. He looked up, his dark eyes immediately locking onto Thomas.

Alianor stood just outside the entrance to the shop, the parchment shopping list rustling softly in her hand as she read it over again. She glanced up, taking in the antique wooden sign above the door, before her eyes drifted to the bustle of the street. A vendor across the lane was selling trunks from a canvas-covered stall. She crossed over to inspect them. Inside, Mr. Ollivander, entirely oblivious to Alianor outside, said to the boy in a dry,

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parchment-like rustle, “Ah, another young sorcerer, come to collect his first wand.”

The old man began pulling boxes from the towering stacks with incredible speed, their contents already seemingly known to him.

“Try this, young man. Oak, Dragon Heartstring core, twelve inches, quite supple. Do you know the *Lumos* spell?”

Thomas took the wand in his left hand. It felt plain, dry, and utterly inert in his grasp. He gave it a nervous flick, attempting a basic *Lumos* spell. The wand only sparked weakly, sending a plume of black smoke that smelled strongly of burnt toast straight into his face.

“No, no, definitely not,” Ollivander chuckled, waving the smoke away with a flick of his wrist.

“Perhaps... Ebony, Unicorn Hair, ten and a half inches, surprisingly whippy. Made for a duelist, this one.”

This wand was exquisitely carved with a spiral pattern, beautiful to behold. As Thomas held it, a sudden, powerful *CRACK* split the air, and a pane of glass in a nearby display case shattered outward, sending glittering shards across the floor.

“Sorry!” Thomas squeaked, dropping the dangerous piece of wood.

“It is quite alright, young man,” Ollivander said, his eyes alight with a strange, almost manic curiosity. “A strong core, but entirely the wrong vessel. This is typical. The wand chooses the wizard,” he quoted his own motto solemnly. “It is an intricate and often frustrating process.”

He made Thomas try a few more. A wand of Holly flared a harmless, icy blue light that immediately winked out. One of Yew felt strangely hot and uncomfortable, like holding a burning coal. None felt right; none clicked into place.

At that moment, Alianor stepped through the doorway, a new leather trunk of deep brown with brass fittings set down heavily at her side. Her face was serious, her red hair blazing under the shop’s light.

“Mr. Ollivander,” she said, her voice clear and carrying. “I believe you were entrusted some years ago with the care of a wand my husband made for the

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boy.”

Gilbert Ollivander’s eyes widened as the realisation struck him. The subtle details, the familiar aura she carried—it all snapped into place. He recognised her instantly. It had been more than ten years since he had last seen her. She was easily recognisable by her red, fiery hair and vibrant expressions, even though she had noticeably aged since their last meeting.

“Alianor... Blackwood,” he breathed, finally recognising the famous colour of her hair and the quiet authority in her manner. “The... the piece... yes. It’s safe. Disguised in plain sight here, among my other wands.”

He moved slowly, deliberately, to the rear of the counter. He reached high, to the top stack, and gently pulled down a single wooden box. It was completely covered in the typical identifying labels, like all those of his own wands.

Alianor gently took the box, her fingers trembling slightly, and handed it to her son. “This was made for you, Thomas. By your father.”

Thomas opened the box.

The wand inside was unlike any he had seen. It was simple, unadorned, and made of a wood he couldn’t name — it was a dark and dense hardwood, with a thick oil or wax finish. The wand’s texture was hand-hewn, beautifully wonky, forming a long pyramidal shape with four sides and rounded corners. A rugged iron fitting was pressed into the wooden base, serving to secure a cotton strip intended to wrap around the young wizard’s wrist.

As his fingers closed around the wood, it was as if a powerful, quiet chord had been struck deep within his chest. The wand felt like an extension of his own arm, a missing piece of himself. A wave of warm, silver light erupted from the tip, washing over the entire shop, making the hundreds of stacked boxes glow for a single, perfect instant.

“Oh, my word,” Gilbert Ollivander whispered, his hand going to his chest.

Thomas felt a rush of pure elation and, with a silent command, the wand responded perfectly, holding the light steady and bright.



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## The Mystery of the Wand

“This piece that truly defies me,” Ollivander admitted, leaning on the counter, his pale eyes full of bewildered respect. “I have never ceased to study it, and yet it resists every attempt to understand its creation.”

He placed both hands flat on the counter and began his explanation, his tone becoming that of a true master craftsman.

“We wandmakers work by a principle known to all true wizards: the wand chooses the wizard.” He tapped his motto. “It is a matter of the core—Phoenix Feather, Dragon Heartstring, Unicorn Hair—bonding with the wood—Holly, Oak, Ash—to find a magical echo in the soul of the one who wields it.”

He gestured to the wand in Thomas’s hand. “This wand, however, was made for you, young man. Made to fit you before you even showed the first sparks of magic. And yet... it fits your magic like a glove.”

“But why does it defy you?” Thomas asked, his curiosity now almost as great as his excitement.

“Its loyalty,” Ollivander said, his voice dropping to a near whisper. “My own creations will resist the magic of another wizard, yes. They will feel strange, heavy, or difficult to perform complex spellwork for a non-owner. But I have tried every basic, non-verbal charm on this piece—a simple *Accio*, a basic *Scourgify*. It refuses me completely. It will not perform the most rudimentary spell for anyone but its owner.”

He shook his head slowly. “It resists even my most advanced attempts to guess its core. The resistance is total. I can hazard a guess that the wood is Blackthorn based on the grain and texture, but its properties are completely masked. It is utterly, absolutely loyal.”

“It is a Blackwood family tradition, I believe, Mr. Ollivander,” Alianor explained softly. “Since before the Council’s founding. The line of Blackwood first wands are crafted at birth, not chosen at eleven.”

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## Wayfarer

Mr. Ollivander straightened his back, a rare spark of paternal pride softening his eccentric, misty-eyed gaze. He stepped toward a corner of the shop where three brooms stood displayed on a rack of dark mahogany.

“You see, young Thomas,” he began, gesturing to the instruments, “my family has lived and breathed wandcraft for generations. The call of the wood and the core has been a family tradition, followed by my father, my grandfather before him, myself and now even by my youngest, Griffin. He is also starting at Hogwarts this year by the way, you will meet him soon. But my eldest, Ariana, saw her future in the wind rather than the spark.” He chuckled, a dry sound like rustling parchment. “She deviated from the family tradition to invest herself in the fine art of broom-making. I keep a few of her pieces here to show what an Ollivander can do when she turns her hand to flight.”

He pulled the first broom from the rack. It was sturdy, with a thick ash handle and a tail of stiff, well-bound birch twigs. Simple iron stirrups were bolted to the sides. “This is the *Cumbrian Stout*. A true workhorse. It is reliable, sturdy, and exceptionally easy to master. It won’t win you any races, and it isn’t the most agile in a sharp turn, but it will never fail you in a storm.”

He replaced it and lifted a second broom that looked like a needle of polished oak. It was slick and slender, featuring gleaming brass foot-supports that had been polished to a mirror finish. “Now, this is the *Silver Streak*. It is built for one thing: raw, unrelenting speed in a straight line. It’s a bit unforgiving when it comes to sharp corners.”

Finally, he reached for the third broom, and his voice took on a tone of genuine reverence. This one was slightly shorter, the handle crafted with a subtle, ergonomic curve designed to tuck perfectly against a wizard’s legs and torso. The foot supports were of polished iron, sleek yet substantial.

“This,” he whispered, “is the *Wayfarer*. It is the jewel of Ariana’s current collection. It represents a perfect compromise — nearly as fast as the *Streak* on the straightaway, but with an agility for sharp turns that is unmatched. More importantly,” he tapped the curved handle, “it is weighted to be handled single-handed. If you are ever in a tourney, or heaven forbid, a combat situation where you must hold a wand in your other hand, the

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*Wayfarer* will listen to your knees and your balance more than your grip.”

Thomas reached out to touch the polished wood, his eyes shining.

“Griffin is taking a *Wayfarer* to Hogwarts. This specific piece, unfortunately, has already been purchased by a client as well. But you will find others just like it, and a full selection of models, at Ariana’s shop on the very edge of Diagon Alley.” Ollivander said with a wink. “Or,” he looked at Alianor, “I could arrange to have one delivered directly to the boat. He is taking one of the great hulks to Hogwarts later today, isn’t he?”

“He is,” Alianor confirmed. She stepped forward, her eyes narrowing as she read the price tag affixed to the broom’s handle. She reached into her leather purse, her fingers dancing over the coins Hob Fox had given her, and pulled out the required gold.

“We will take it,” she stated, handing the Galleons to Ollivander. “Have it delivered to the Hogwarts boat before departure. And please,” she added, her voice softening with a hint of nostalgia, “send my compliments to Ariana. It has been a very long time since I last saw her.”

## Twilfitt and Tattings

Leaving the wand maker to his next mark, Alianor and Thomas ducked into the warm, lint-filled air of *Twilfitt and Tattings*. The shop was a whirlwind of activity. The moment they crossed the threshold, a pair of enchanted measuring tapes leaped from a mahogany counter and began snaking around Thomas’s limbs, cinching his waist and spanning his shoulders with frantic energy. Nearby, a self-inking quill scratched notes onto a hovering piece of parchment with a rhythmic *skritch-skritch-skritch*.

The proprietor, a flamboyant man named Master Pendergast Malkin, emerged from a forest of hanging linen and silk. Alianor didn’t wait for a greeting; she unfurled her parchment list. “Three sets of plain black work robes, one pair of dragon-hide protective gloves, and one winter cloak with silver fastenings, please” she commanded.

Pendergast gave a sharp flick of his wand. A silver needle and a spool of black thread took flight, diving into a stack of pre-cut robes like a pair of hunting hawks. They zipped through the fabric, darting in and out to adjust

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the seams to the quill's precise measurements. As each piece was finished, it folded itself into a neat square and drifted through the air to land on the front counter, joined shortly by a pair of sturdy, pebbled-leather gloves.

The shop door chimed again, admitting a trio that stood out in the crowded room. A man in sensible Muggle woollens was accompanied by two daughters. Thomas watched them, intrigued; the father spoke in a low, melodic tone, referring to the younger girl as Celine and the elder as Cecile. Their speech was a rapid-fire language that Thomas couldn't quite follow.

A seamstress wearing a measuring rope like a scarf hurried over. "Monsieur Fournier! A pleasure to see you again. What can we do for the girls today?"

"If you please," M. Fournier said, his French accent thick and rolling. He held up a small winter cloak and a set of robes that were clearly well-loved but slightly faded. "Can these be adjusted for Celine? And she will need one new black robe as well." He then turned to his eldest. "For Cecile, three Hufflepuff uniform dresses and a new winter cloak."

Thomas's eyes drifted to the back of the store, where four mannequins stood like silent sentinels, each draped in the colours of the Hogwarts houses. At this period, the "dresses" were structured as long, modest kirtles with fitted bodices and sweeping skirts.

The Hufflepuff dress was a deep, earthy yellow with charcoal-grey trim, the badger emblem embroidered subtly on the breast. Thomas looked at the other three:

- Gryffindor: A bold scarlet gown with gold-threaded embroidery that seemed to shimmer like fire.
- Ravenclaw: A sophisticated bronze-and-blue ensemble, the fabric a rich, heavy velvet.
- Slytherin: A gown of emerald green with silver silk lacing up the sides, looking cold and regal.

"Hopefully," Mr. Fournier said with a hopeful smile, "Celine will be sorted into Hufflepuff as well, so she may inherit her sister's wardrobe next year."

Celine flashed a tight, artificial smile that fooled no one, her eyes betraying the disapproval. Thomas wondered if she was tired of hand-me-downs, or if

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her heart was set on the vibrant scarlet of Gryffindor, or if she already had a preference for a specific house.

Thomas turned his gaze to a second set of mannequins on the opposite wall, his stomach doing a nervous flip. He found himself staring at the Ravenclaw bronze and the Slytherin silver. His father had been a Ravenclaw, a man of wit and learning; his aunt, however, had worn the green of Slytherin. He pulled his gaze away, he preferred not to think about it.

Alianor counted out the payment, her eyes never leaving Master Pendergast until the transaction was settled. “Come, Thomas,” she said sharply.

As they stepped back out into the street, Thomas looked back one last time. Master Pendergast was already stooping over the Fourniers’ worn robes, his wand out to begin the task of making the old look new again.

## The Astrolabe

They made a final, brief stop at a shop specialising in celestial instruments to acquire the remaining items on Thomas’s list. Among the charts and quadrants, they purchased a heavy brass astrolabe. It was a weighty instrument consisting of a thick, circular main frame called the *mater* and several interchangeable plates engraved with the stereographic projection of the heavens. Atop these sat the *rete*, a skeletal, ornate metal web whose points indicated the positions of the brightest stars, allowing Thomas to calculate the time and the position of the planets by aligning the *alidade*—a pivoting sighting bar—on the back. With the astrolabe, a wooden quadrant for measuring altitudes, and a sprawling vellum constellation map tucked safely away, they prepared to leave.

# 3      The Tide of the Great Hulks

They exited Diagon Alley through the same unassuming door through which they had entered — wedged between two shops and marked only by the small, carved symbol of the Crossed Keys. Thomas pulled it open, and they found themselves back in the long, warped corridor of the bridge's interior. Navigating past the myriad of doors, they reached the portal painted with the same keys. As they crossed back into the cramped airlock, the familiar scents of stale ale and freshly baked bread rushed to meet them. The space was now agonisingly tight, with the large leather trunk and Pippin's cage barely squeezing in alongside them. Emerging onto the London Bridge, the bell of the Chapel of St. Thomas rang out four sharp peals, echoing over the Thames. Given the late hour and their heavy load, Alianor hailed a muggle carriage. They rattled northward across the bridge before turning eastward, following the river's edge toward the docks.

The carriage deposited them near the bustling Billingsgate market. They navigated a maze of back alleys, turning left and right past the smell of salt and scales until they reached a peculiar wall—a patchwork of timber-framed wattle-and-daub and old, repurposed, Roman red bricks. Stepping through the solid surface, they emerged onto the wizarding margins of the Thames.

Five massive vessels were moored to the stone pier. The first four, identical sister ships named the *Mermaid*, the *Siren*, the *Ceasg* and the *Melusine*, were behemoths of naval architecture — a magical hybrid of the sturdy cog and the spacious hulk, but nearly twice the size of any merchant vessel Thomas had ever seen. Their hulls were deep and rounded, featuring high, fortified forecastles and even more impressive sterncastles that towered like wooden fortresses over the water. Each sported two masts with immense square sails.

The fifth ship, the *Merrow*, was a relic of an older age. It was a long, low-slung galley, roughly forty meters in length, with thirty-two heavy oars protruding from each side like the legs of a centipede. It lacked the high castles of the sister ships, offering smaller living quarters, its two sails striped in the colours

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of all four Hogwarts houses.

Near the pier stood a small stone-and-wood office where a goblin clerk sat behind a high desk. He ignored the frantic activity of house-elves loading barrels and pallets of supplies, his quill scratching rhythmically as he processed passengers. When they reached the front, Thomas placed a gold coin on the counter.

“Single ticket for Hogwarts,” Thomas said.

The goblin took the coin without a hint of emotion. “First year?” he asked rhetorically. Thomas nodded. “Better to avoid the Slytherin lot then,” the goblin grunted, sliding back several silver coins and a handwritten slip of paper. “You’re on the *Siren*, middle deck, cabin eleven.” He gestured toward the second ship. At the prow, carved directly into the stempost and projecting along the beak beneath the forecastle, a siren of dark oak leaned forward with the rake of the bow, her upper body human and her scaled tail drawn tight against the timber, cut in shallow relief so the sea could wash over her without tearing the carving away. “The ship convoy will stop at Dublin, the Isle of Man, and Dumbarton - on the Clyde, some miles downstream from Glasgow” the goblin explained, his voice a dry rasp. “Then it will head north, hugging the west coast of Scotland. From there, you’ll travel by carriage to Hogsmeade and finally Hogwarts castle.” He tapped the parchment. “You’ll have to share the berths section with only one other student for now; two others are scheduled to embark at the Isle of Man and Dumbarton.”

## The Siren’s Call

Thomas took the paper, his heart hammering against his ribs. At the foot of the *Siren’s* gangplank, Alianor stopped. The iron mask of her composure finally slipped, her eyes glassing over with unshed tears. She pressed the leather purse of coins into his hand.

“For the rest of your uniforms once you are sorted, and for your time in Hogsmeade,” she whispered, her voice thick with emotion. She reached out, straightening his collar one last time. “Be presentable, Thomas. For your professors and your classmates. Eat well, study hard, and...” she looked at the owl in its cage, “...write to me. Often.”

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Thomas reached for his heavy trunk and Pippin's cage, preparing for the arduous climb, but a house-elf nearby intervened with a quick flick of its hand. A subtle shimmer of magic washed over the luggage, and both the trunk and the cage began to levitate, bobbing weightlessly in the air. With significantly less effort, Thomas simply guided them through the narrow gangway. He watched the trunk drift ahead of him, thinking to himself that such a spell would be a convenient one to master.

## Cabin Eleven

Stepping off the gangway and onto the *Siren's* open wooden deck, Thomas found himself in a whirlwind of activity. Two wizards stood mid-ship, their wands tracing arcs through the air as they directed barrels and pallets of supplies toward the lower decks with precision. The crowd of travellers split; some headed toward the towering forecastle at the bow, while others moved toward the sterncastle. One of the wizards, holding his wand pressed firmly against his own throat to amplify his voice, barked orders over the din, directing passengers to their respective cabins located in the castles and the more cramped quarters deep within the hull.

The hierarchy of the ship was reflected in its architecture. The sterncastle housed the most prestigious quarters—wood-panelled, private cabins for Hogwarts staff and professors, distinguished guests, and the families of the school's patrons, complete with stern-walks overlooking the ship's wake. Below them, and forward in the forecastle, senior students shared four-berth cabins with solid doors and the luxury of portholes.

Thomas, however, was directed toward the belly of the ship. The younger students were housed in cavernous spaces on the middle and lower decks, just above the cargo hold. Here, the layout consisted of long corridors with walls that separated the open cabins on each side. Each cabin was remarkably narrow, containing four berths—two stacked atop two—perpendicular to the corridor. A tiny, foldable wooden table, held in place by a simple cord, was the only furniture other than the beds. There was barely enough room under the lower berths for four trunks, and with a ceiling only two meters high, the taller students were forced to bow to avoid the heavy, exposed support beams.

Despite the lack of portholes, the middle deck felt surprisingly welcoming.



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It was decorated in a mixture of polished, varnished wood and clean white panels with brass accents. Oil lamps bathed the space in a warm glow, and gaps left above and below the curtains allowed for essential ventilation. In the common area of the main deck below the sterncastle, passengers gathered at fixed tables to share meals or pass the time with backgammon, ludus latrunculorum, pachisi or wizard's chess.

Though it was a massive vessel, the *Siren* required a crew of only eight to twelve wizards — far fewer than a Muggle ship of its size. Spells significantly improved ship performance by offering higher, more consistent wind speeds, resulting in much greater vessel velocity and shorter journey durations. Additionally, magic provided vital concealment, hiding the convoy from Muggle ships and ports.

Thomas navigated a steep, narrow flight of stairs, thankful once again for the levitation spell on his trunk. He reached a narrow corridor illuminated by small hatches that let in the fading afternoon light, supplemented by rows of oil lamps. The air here was pleasant, carrying the fragrance of olive oil scented with lavender. He eventually found his quarters, marked with an engraved wooden sign bearing the number 11.

Pulling back the thick curtain, he found the room lit by two oil lamps and four beeswax candles in brass candelabras. On the bottom right berth, he immediately noticed a broom, similar to the one he saw earlier at Diagon Alley, wrapped with a red knot and a letter addressed to him—his *Wayfarer*.

One of the cabin's occupants was already there. A boy, perhaps an inch taller than Thomas with short black hair, hopped down from the top left berth and extended a hand.

"Baldwin... Baldwin Attewell. Nice to meet you," the boy said with a friendly grin.

"Thomas Blackwood, nice to meet you," Thomas replied.

Baldwin's eyes widened, and his voice rose in surprise. "Blackwood? As in Mary Elizabeth Blackwood? The Auror of the Council and the youngest Hogsmeade tourney champion ever?"

Thomas offered a faint smile and a nod. "She's my aunt, my father's younger sister."

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“If you don’t mind me saying,” Baldwin remarked, looking him over, “you don’t exactly resemble her,” clearly referring to Mary’s legendary long, white-blond hair and her strikingly pale skin marked with white freckles.

In response, Thomas raised his left hand and ran his fingers through his short, dark brown hair. As he did, the strands shimmered and lengthened, turning a bright, platinum blonde. His skin paled instantly, blooming with the delicate white freckles that were the hallmark of the Blackwood family. He paused for a moment, then brushed his hand through his hair again; the colour shifted back to dark brown, and the sickly pallor of his skin warmed back to a healthy, almost tanned glow.

“Wow,” Baldwin breathed, leaning in. “You must teach me how to do that.”

“I would love to,” Thomas confessed, sliding his trunk under the berth and hanging Pippin’s cage on one of the wall hooks, “but I don’t actually know how. I just... do it.”

As he settled in, Thomas noticed a white, fluffy shape curled up under the opposite berth. Baldwin followed his gaze.

“Don’t worry about Dolores,” Baldwin said, nodding toward the white cat. “She’s far too slothful to even bother attacking him... or is it her?”

“He’s a him,” Thomas confirmed with a smile, watching the young tawny owl adjust to the swaying of the ship. “I call him Pippin.”

The boarding process was nearly complete, and as students settled into their respective quarters, the corridors below decks grew visibly quieter. Across the narrow passageway from Cabin 11, two young witches arrived at their own doorway, struggling slightly with two heavy trunks—one a cheerful yellow and black, the other a shiny, deep brown that looked brand new. Thomas immediately recognised them as the sisters from the tailor shop, Cecile and Celine.

In that moment, Pippin, perhaps spurred by the excitement of the journey, managed to nudge the latch of his cage loose. With a sudden flutter of soft feathers, he took flight, swooping across the corridor and landing squarely on the shoulder of the younger sister, Celine. She had been mid-bite into a small tourtelette, and the little owl was staring at it with unblinking intensity.

Celine laughed, her French accent lilting through the air, and pinched off a

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piece of the golden crust. Pippin devoured it instantly. She then reached up to stroke the top of his head; the young tawny owl stretched his wings and leaned into her touch, seemingly melting against her shoulder as he enjoyed the affection as much as the snack.

Thomas reached the doorway of his cabin, watching the scene with a mix of embarrassment and amusement.

“I see he has a fine taste,” Celine joked, looking at Thomas. “Apparently, even the owls of London recognise a proper Lyonnais tourtelette.”

Cecile smirked, nudging her sister. “You and your new feathered friend are due for a disappointing surprise once you see the ship’s mess menu a few days from port.”

Thomas leaned against the doorframe, shaking his head. “Wow, he’s been bought off already. Absolutely shameless,” he joked. “Just a piece of pie and he goes all soft. Look at him, he’s melting already.”

“Don’t forget the head-scratches,” Celine reminded him, her fingers still buried in Pippin’s soft plumage.

Thomas looked the owl in the eye and laughed. “Traitor. So much for loyalty.”

“I remember seeing you at the tailor’s in the Alley,” Thomas added as the girls finally shoved their trunks into their narrow cabin.

“And we remember you with your mother,” Cecile replied, smoothing out her robes.

“Would you like to join us in our cabin for a bit?” Thomas asked, gesturing toward Baldwin. He looked at Cecile, the elder sister. “It would be nice to hear from someone who actually knows what to expect at Hogwarts.”

After securing their luggage under the lower berths, the sisters accepted the invitation and followed Thomas across the hall. Inside Cabin 11, Baldwin stood up, offering a polite bow as they introduced themselves.

“Cecile Fournier,” Cecile said, introducing herself, before adding and gesturing to her sister, “and this is Celine.”

“Baldwin Attewell,” Baldwin replied, catching the cadence of their speech. “That’s a fine accent. Where are you from originally?”

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“Lyon,” Celine answered proudly. “It sits where the Rhône and the Saône rivers meet, far to the south and east.”

Baldwin nodded, showing a surprising grasp of geography. “I know the place. Famous for its wine and its hills. But that raises a question—why come all the way to the North? Why Hogwarts and not Beauxbatons?”

Cecile’s expression turned a bit more serious, her gaze lingering on the flickering oil lamp. “That,” she said softly, “is a long story.”

## The Merchant and the Baker

### *Lyon, Five Years Prior*

The sun hung low over the hills of Fourvière, casting long, amber shadows across the terracotta roofs of Lyon. Janus Laskaris walked with a steady, rhythmic gait, his young daughter Philippa skipping at his side. They began their journey on the rue Mercière, the heart of the city’s commerce, where the air was thick with the scent of tanned leather and expensive spices. Turning toward the river, they crossed the Pont Change, a massive stone bridge lined with the shops of money-changers and goldsmiths, their scales clinking in a metallic chorus above the rushing Saône. As they reached the western bank, the streets of Vieux Lyon narrowed into a labyrinth of medieval stone. The buildings here were tall and proud, featuring the famous *traboules*—secret passageways that cut through courtyards and under spiralling stone staircases. They walked toward the Montée des Carmes Déchaussés, where the incline of the hill began its steep ascent.

Janus Laskaris was a man of the world in the most literal sense. A fabulously rich merchant of both common and magical cargo, he was no stranger to the great centres of civilisation. He maintained residences in London, Paris, Rome, and Constantinople, and his business frequently took him to the markets of Venice, Athens, Alexandria, Jerusalem, Damascus, and Isfahan. Yet, despite his global reach, Lyon held a unique resonance for him. Although it was a profitable commerce hub, his reason for choosing it as a permanent residence was deeper; something about the city simply screamed “home.” The food and wine were incomparable, and the climate suited him perfectly. Even as a non-native speaker, he found that the Lyonnais French carried a rounded warmth; the words flowed more gently than the sharper speech of

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Paris, with vowels that lingered and consonants that softened. He took great pleasure in both speaking and listening to the local tongue.

Janus was accustomed to the company of the powerful, counting monarchs, ministers, doges, and emperors among his acquaintances. In the hidden world, he was well-known to the members of various wizarding councils, synods, and majlis, and he took pride in his contacts among eminent professors and headmasters. Yet, among all these prestigious figures, he particularly enjoyed the company of a humble Muggle resident: Monsieur Henry Fournier. Henry was a baker whose shop was located on the west margin of the Saône, near the stairs of the Montée des Carmes Déchaussés. While Janus could easily have had the finest pastries delivered to his mansion or prepared by his own staff, he preferred to visit the bakery in person. He enjoyed hearing the local news and gossip — who was marrying whom, who was expecting a child, whether the tavern owner had finally been caught diluting his wine, or how many men had been requisitioned for King Philip's army. In return, the young baker was fascinated by Janus's tales of exotic lands like Rome, Constantinople, Jerusalem, and Isfahan, captivated by the different customs and extravagances of distant rulers.

However, the nature of their friendship was about to change. On this particular day, at his daughter's request, Janus had brought high-quality ingredients so the baker could make a delicacy from his home: Michaelmas bread loaves. As the merchant and the baker sat sharing a loaf and some Rhône valley wine, discussing the latest local rumours, Janus noticed something peculiar. He was seated at a table facing the opening of the oven, while Henry sat opposite him with his back to the heat. Closer to the oven was Cecile, the baker's eldest daughter, who was about eight years old. Janus watched in silence as the glowing coals inside the oven began to coalesce; the embers rose and swirled, forming the distinct shape of a bird in flight. It flapped its fiery wings for a heartbeat before dissolving into a blooming flower and then a six-pointed star.

Janus glanced at his own daughter, wondering if she were the source of the magic. Philippa was on the floor with the baker's youngest daughter, Celine, who was two years younger than Cecile. They were drawing on a sheet of paper he brought from the orient with paints from the Italian peninsula. Janus felt a brief sense of relief when he saw Philippa drawing the same shapes on the paper as those appearing in the oven, assuming it was her influence. However, his relief was short-lived. He noticed a rash on Cecile's

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forearm and asked her about it. When the girl mentioned she had scratched it on the leaves of a rowan tree, Janus became instantly alert. While harmless to Muggles, the untreated wood and leaves of the rowan are a severe irritant to wizards. Though its treated wood is prized for wands — especially for defence against the dark arts — the rowan's fruits, flowers, and sap are dangerous and potentially fatal to wizards.

Later that night, Janus sent an owl to the *Confrérie des Arts de la Sorcellerie de France*, the prestigious wizarding guild in Paris. His contact there consulted *Le Livre d'Admittance*, the book recording every young wizard in the region defined by the six corners between Bretagne, Flandre, Alsace, Provence, Roussillon et Guyenne. Two nights later, the answer arrived, and Janus was stunned. As expected, Cecile Fournier's name was in the book, but to his immense surprise, so was the name of Celine Fournier.

Janus knew that the world was about to be turned upside down for the Fourniers. Uncomfortable as it was, he felt it was his duty to present the wizarding world to them himself, rather than leaving it to a clerk from the *confrérie* or a faceless letter. He realised he would miss the simple talks about Muggle life he shared with Henry; their conversations were about to become much more serious.

Janus took his wand, a small locket, and the letter from the Confrérie and headed to the bakery. Henry was surprised to see him so early, and looking so somber. Janus read the letter aloud to the trio, who were left entirely confused.

That confusion turned to sheer terror when Janus drew his wand. With a sharp gesture, Janus ignited the cold charcoal in the oven; with a second, he levitated a raw loaf of bread through the air and tucked it neatly onto the baking stone. Henry instinctively scrambled backward into a corner, pinning himself against the wall and shielding his daughters behind him. With a calm and serene tone, Janus assured the baker that he was still the same person Henry had known for years — the man who had introduced him to his late wife and mother of his daughters and later organised her funeral.

Intrigued, Celine approached the table where Janus had placed an open locket. Inside was a portrait that she could swear had just moved; the figure in the painting adjusted herself and then walked out of the frame entirely. Janus explained that this was a wizarding painting. He then assured Mr. Fournier that any rumours he might have heard in sermons or old tales —

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claiming that witchcraft was an unnatural or inherently evil art — were completely unwarranted. This seemed to calm the baker, who eventually sat back down at the table with Janus, his oldest daughter beside him and the youngest on his lap.

Janus then proceeded to reveal the true scale of the wizarding world. Using his wand to command charcoal dust and flour to form images and shapes in the air, he showed a map of the known world and its most important wizarding settlements. He pointed out eight eminent schools marked by incandescent charcoal:

- Hogwarts: in the Highlands of Scotland.
- Beauxbatons: within the French Pyrenees.
- Durmstrang: in the north of Scandinavia.
- Uagadou: in Buganda.
- Mahoutokoro: in the far East.
- Koldovstoretz: along the banks of the Upper Volga.
- Kamryn: in the Carpathian Mountains.
- Malakopí: within the massive underground community in Cappadocia.

Janus explained that in most of these schools, young wizards studied from ages eleven to seventeen. He offered to provide everything they would need regardless of their choice, but admitted he had more influence at Hogwarts, where he had studied and where he intended to send Philippa. As a patron of the school and member of its board he had helped recruit professors and staff from across the globe. He noted that while Beauxbatons was perhaps stronger in potions and alchemy due to a rising professor named Nicolas Flamel — whom he regrettably had failed to recruit — Hogwarts possessed the finest master of magical artefacts in Professor Magnus Grimm, whom Janus had brought from Constantinople. He also promised to provide tutors to ensure the girls were literate in Latin or Greek before they attended.

Henry hesitated, not out of fear of magic, but because of the vast distance. He also questions the travel and the difficulties given the conflict between England and France. Janus remained somewhat vague but stated that

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relations in the wizarding world were currently less conflicting. He gave his personal guarantee that he would personally bring the girls back to Lyon every summer in his own ship—a vessel that was part of a fleet protected from Muggle eyes and capable of navigating both the high seas and the Rhône river.

## Under the Gilded Heavens

Their conversation was suddenly interrupted by the heavy thud of boots echoing down the timber-ribbed corridor outside. A burly ship's mate strode past the cabin doors, swinging a brass handbell that clattered brightly over the ambient noise of the lower decks.

"Dinner is ready! Dinner is ready!" the man's gruff, sea-salted voice called out. "Gather in the common area under the sterncastle! Hot supper awaits!"

Almost immediately upon the sailor's passing, a frantic, joyful clatter of footsteps heralded a new arrival. A young girl came tearing down the corridor, her movement a chaotic, rambunctious mix of a brisk walk and an outright run. She possessed a boundless, kinetic energy, her eyes darting eagerly as she searched the doors. She skidded to a halt in front of the girls' cabin, peering into the empty room with a loud, theatrical sigh of disappointment.

From the doorway of the boys' cabin, Celine caught sight of her and leaned out. "Philippa! Over here!"

Philippa spun on her heel, her face lighting up with a brilliant grin as she bounded over the raised wooden threshold into Thomas and Baldwin's cabin.

"There you are!" Philippa declared, out of breath but thoroughly delighted.

"Philippa, come in," Cecile said smoothly, taking on the role of gracious mediator. She gestured toward the two boys. "Allow me to introduce you. This is Baldwin Attewell, and this is Thomas Blackwood. Boys, this is Philippa."

Baldwin offered a polite, somewhat stiff nod, his spectacles slipping slightly down his nose, while Thomas offered a brief, relaxed smile, his piercing grey eyes taking in the girl's energetic demeanour.



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“A pleasure,” Thomas murmured, his voice calm and grounded.

“Brilliant to meet you both, truly,” Philippa said, waving off the formalities with a frantic motion of her hands. “But did you hear the man? Dinner is ready! We must go right this instant before the older students eat the best of it!”

Cecile nodded in firm agreement, smoothing the front of her robes. “She is absolutely right. I suggest we hurry. This will be the last time we enjoy a truly good meal until we drop anchor in Dublin.”

Baldwin blinked, adjusting his glasses. “Why is that?”

“Because tonight’s feast was prepared on shore, back in London, right before we left the pier,” Cecile explained as she ushered them out into the corridor. “Over the next few days, however, our meals will be prepared in the ship’s galley. I assure you, the conditions down there are much fewer, the heat is stifling, and the food will have noticeably less taste. So, eat well tonight.”

Motivated by Cecile’s pragmatic warning, the quintet made their way through the belly of the ship. They navigated the tight, shadowy corridors, the wooden floorboards swaying gently beneath their feet as the vessel cut through the currents of the Thames. At the end of the passage, they climbed a narrow, steep set of wooden stairs that protested with loud creaks under their weight, finally emerging into the small and cozy common room situated beneath the towering sterncastle.

It was long and slightly curved, filled with narrow wooden tables flanked by sturdy benches. The room was bathed in a warm, flickering, golden glow emanating from thick beeswax candles and polished brass olive oil lamps mounted on iron sconces along the bulkheads. The air was thick and heady with the scent of roasting meats, baked bread, the sharp tang of the burning olive oil, and the faint, ever-present aroma of sea salt and waxed timber. Small, thick-paned windows lined the port and starboard sides, offering glimpses of the dark world outside.

But it was the ceiling that commanded true awe.

Spanning the entirety of the common room’s curved roof was a breathtaking, stylised map of the heavens. It was a masterpiece that bridged earlier Romanesque style with the soaring, decorative elegance of later Gothic styles. Rather than a realistic depiction of the night sky, it was a symbolic,

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iconographic tapestry. The background was painted in a deep, flat, and impossibly rich expanse of ultramarine and dark indigo.

Most of the stars and a slender, delicate crescent moon were rendered in gleaming silver. However, the great navigational anchors of the sky—Polaris, Ursa Minor, Ursa Major, Cassiopeia, and Orion—were distinguished by heavy, textured gold. They were painted in oversized, mythical shapes: a great gilded bear, a smaller bear, a crowned queen, a towering hunter.

The true magic of the ceiling, however, lay in its enchantment. It was vibrantly alive. Wisps of painted, silver-lined clouds moved slowly across the indigo expanse. As the ship rocked on the waves and shifted its course along the river, the golden constellations slid accordingly across the timber canvas. It was not a literal tool for the helmsman, but a shifting, comforting representation of the very stars the sailors relied upon above deck.

The five of them managed to secure a prime spot at a table pushed right up against one of the small windows. Sitting in the centre of the scarred wooden surface was a beautifully carved Pachisi board game. Thomas quietly pushed it aside to make room for the pewter trenchers and wooden cups that a passing steward was hastily laying out.

While they waited for the main platters to arrive, they peered out the thick glass of the window. The ship had well and truly left the bustling docks behind and was navigating the wider, darker stretches of the Thames. It was the dead of night. Looking back, the immense, hulking shadow of the Tower of London was slowly receding into the distance, its imposing Norman stone barely distinguishable from the black sky, save for the flickering orange pinpricks of torches burning on its battlements. The city of London was a fading cluster of embers.

Out here on the water, the river was pitch black, a rippling mirror of obsidian that caught only the pale reflection of the real moon and the occasional, scattered bonfires burning lonely vigils on the muddy banks of the estuary.

## Hepburn

As they turned their attention back to the warmth of the room, the crowd parted slightly, revealing a massive, commanding presence near the front

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of the hall. It was Professor Humphry Hepburn, the corpulent Hogwarts Headmaster. He was a large man with a remarkably warm disposition, currently laughing boisterously with a group of nervous-looking first and second-year students.

Thomas, ever observant, leaned across the table toward Cecile. “Is that Professor Hepburn?” he asked, his voice low over the din of the room. “What is he like? His classes, I mean, and him in general.”

Baldwin adjusted his spectacles, looking thoughtful. “I’ve seen him a few times in Diagon Alley this past summer. Once, he was buying up armfuls of potion ingredients and supplies, and he looked right as rain. But another time, I saw him walking out of what seemed a council meeting in the upper rooms of the Leaky Cauldron... he looked utterly miserable. He definitely seems happier when he’s just buying items for his potions.”

Cecile smiled knowingly, resting her elbows on the wooden table. “It is no surprise to see him down here tonight, eating with us,” she said. “He could have easily dined hours ago with the other professors in the captain’s quarters. But he doesn’t operate like that. He takes particular care in dealing with the younger students.”

She leaned in slightly, lowering her voice so as not to be overheard by the older students nearby. “He’s a Hufflepuff, you know, and brilliant at Potions and Alchemy. But he absolutely despises politics and bureaucracy, which is probably why he looked so miserable at that Council meeting. He is incredibly warm and good-natured. Some say he is a bit too relaxed with the rules, especially with the first-years.”

“Relaxed?” Philippa perked up, her eyes gleaming with the promise of future mischief. “I like the sound of that.”

“Don’t get too comfortable,” Cecile warned, though she was smiling. “Hepburn might be forgiving, but he relies on his staff to keep order. Professor Agnes Ravenclaw and Professor Hugh Ligier are entirely different beasts. They are much, much stricter. Ligier is intense, and Professor Ravenclaw...” Cecile paused, her eyes glinting with a bit of shared gossip. “Well, I have the distinct impression that Agnes Ravenclaw believes *she* ought to be the Headmistress instead, and she runs her classes with an iron fist.”

Thomas, who had been listening quietly while watching the magical gold-leaf stars shift above them, spoke up, his tone mild but laced with genuine

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curiosity. “Who among them is the most senior? Professor Ravenclaw or Headmaster Hepburn?”

Cecile looked at Thomas, a playful smirk breaking across her face. “Honestly? Looking at how they carry themselves... neither of them looks a day older than a hundred and twenty.”

There was a beat of silence as the mental image registered, and then Baldwin snorted loudly. Philippa burst into a bright, ringing laugh, Celine and Cecile quickly joined in, and even Thomas let out a soft, genuine chuckle, his shoulders relaxing.

Before Philippa finished laughing, the loud clatter of pewter trenchers interrupted them as the first massive platters of roasted capon and spiced root vegetables were finally set down upon their table, pulling their attention to the feast before them.

The heavy, spiced aromas of the English feast filled the space beneath the shifting, gilded ceiling. Cecile wasted no time, piling her pewter trencher high with thick slices of roasted capon, dark gravy, and buttery root vegetables, eating with unabashed enthusiasm. Celine, however, eyed the heavy local fare with far less zeal. She delicately picked at a crust of bread and a small portion of vegetables, her expression suggesting she was already deeply missing the culinary of her continental home.

As they ate, the lively hum of the common room wrapped around them, insulating their table from the chill of the river outside.

By the time the platters were cleared, the enchanted ceiling above had deepened to its fullest midnight blue, the golden constellations sliding slowly across the painted timber as the ship found the open water.

## Marzipan Phoenix

At the front of the common room, Headmaster Hepburn had risen to his feet. He clapped his large, meaty hands together, the resounding noise easily cutting through the lively chatter of the hall.

“Right then!” Hepburn announced, his booming voice echoing off the painted, starry ceiling. His tone was incredibly warm, but it carried the firm, un-

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questionable authority of a Headmaster. “The sea breeze is picking up, and tomorrow brings a long day of travel. It is time for all first and second-year students to return to your cabins for the night. Off you go, now. Sleep well!”

A collective, albeit reluctant, groan rose from some of the younger tables, but the students obediently began to rise. Thomas, Baldwin, Celine, Cecile, and Philippa gathered their cloaks and joined the flow of students heading toward the main stairwell. The gentle rocking of the ship had indeed grown slightly more pronounced as they left the sheltered estuary for the open water.

At the landing, the group had to part ways. Philippa offered a bright, energetic wave before bounding up the carved wooden steps toward her private cabin in the sterncastle.

Thomas, Baldwin, and the two French girls turned the opposite way, carefully descending the narrow, creaking stairs back down into the shadowy, timber-ribbed corridors of the middle deck. The air down here was cooler, smelling sharply of brine and the protective tar coating the hull.

They reached the girls’ door first. Celine, looking thoroughly exhausted from the day’s travels, leaned against the doorframe.

“Good night, Thomas. Good night, Baldwin,” Cecile said gracefully, offering them a warm smile. “It was lovely talking with you both.”

“Good night,” Thomas replied smoothly, while Baldwin offered a polite nod and a tired, “See you in the morning.”

Leaving the girls to their rest, Thomas and Baldwin walked the short distance to their own door and pushed the curtain open. Both boys stopped in their tracks, pleasantly surprised. While they had been eating, the ship’s stewards—or perhaps a bit of helpful shipboard magic—had been at work. The narrow, utilitarian berth beds had been neatly made up, the heavy woollen blankets turned down invitingly against the chill of the sea air.

But it was the small detail resting on the wooden ledge beside their pillows that caught Thomas’s eye. Sitting on a tiny square of parchment was a beautifully crafted marzipan cake, shaped perfectly like a sleeping phoenix.

Thomas picked his up, admiring the delicate detailing of the marzipan feathers. He took a bite, and the sharp, bright flavours of ginger and cool mint burst across his tongue, leaving a pleasant, warming sensation in his chest that

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perfectly countered the damp cold of the cabin. It was absolutely delicious.

Finishing the treat in two bites, Thomas wiped his fingers, feeling a deep sense of contentment settle over him. He moved around the small cabin, leaning over to blow out the thick beeswax candles and twisting the brass knobs on the olive oil lamps until the flames sputtered and died, plunging the room into comfortable darkness.

He climbed into his berth, finally allowing the tight, constant mental grip on his Metamorphmagus features to relax in the shadows.

“Good night, Baldwin,” Thomas said quietly into the dark, the rhythmic creak of the ship’s hull already lulling him to sleep.

“Night, Thomas,” Baldwin murmured from across the cabin, his voice heavy with sleep.

## 4 The English Channel

Thomas walked along the familiar, mud-slicked outskirts of London, heading in the direction of his home, but the very earth beneath his boots felt fundamentally wrong. The cobblestone streets seemed to heave, moving up and down and swaying violently from side to side, making it nearly impossible to remain upright. He took a few staggering steps, his centre of gravity completely betrayed, and fell hard to the damp ground. Pushing himself up, he stumbled forward, only to need to brace himself heavily against a rough timber-framed building wall just to stay on his feet. The sensation was deeply disconcerting, an unnatural vertigo that made his head spin.

And then he heard a loud, rushing splash. *A splash?* That didn't fit the streets of London. The sound echoed again, louder this time, followed by a violent jolt as his body slammed hard against the wooden side of the narrow berth bed where he was sleeping.

Thomas snapped awake, gasping as the ship rolled and pitched fiercely against the relentless assault of the waves. His heart hammered in his chest. Instinctively, he passed a trembling hand over his head. In the disorientation of sleep, his tight mental grip had loosened; beneath his fingers, he felt the magic settling as his hair rapidly turned from its striking natural pale blond to a darkened, unassuming brown, while the sickly pale tone of his skin warmed back into a healthier, almost tanned glow. Judging by the violent, rhythmic heaving of the hull, the ship had undoubtedly reached the turbulent waters of the English Channel.

He swung his legs over the side and climbed down from the berth, planting his feet in the middle of the small cabin. Instantly, the floor dropped out from under him, then surged upward, swaying sharply from side to side. Thomas lunged, bracing his forearms against the heavy oak bed frame just to keep from being thrown to the floorboards.

In the lower berth on the opposite side of the cabin, Baldwin groaned, beginning to stir from the commotion. Blinking sleep from his eyes, the young muggle-born wizard started to push himself up into a sitting position

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just as a massive swell caught the ship's broadside. The vessel lurched violently.

"Ouch!" Baldwin yelped loudly, rubbing the top of his head where it had collided squarely with the wooden slats of the berth above him. He slumped back onto his pillow, wincing. "Bloody hell... we must have entered the Channel."

Thomas, his stomach churning and his equilibrium still entirely scrambled by the relentless movement, swallowed thickly. "With all the wizarding in the world," he muttered, white-knuckling the bed frame, "you'd think there ought to be a spell to make a ship sail a bit more smoothly."

"I second that entirely," Baldwin groaned, carefully sliding out of bed while keeping his head tucked low.

They were just finishing pulling on their day clothes, stumbling and swaying with every swell, when the sharp, piercing ring of a brass handbell cut through the heavy oak doors. Heavy footsteps thumped down the corridor, accompanied by a booming voice.

"Breakfast is ready! Breakfast is ready!" a burly ship's mate bellowed, his gruff voice echoing over the groaning timbers. "Gather in the common area under the sterncastle! Bread and fruits await!"

As the ringing faded down the passageway, the relative silence of the lower decks gave way to the muffled sounds of yawns, creaking floorboards, and the soft murmur of waking chatter from the adjacent cabins. Thomas pulled back the heavy wool curtain of their doorway, stepping out into the narrow, dimly lit corridor. Glancing to the side, he noticed the curtain to Cecile and Celine's cabin was already tied back, the small room empty.

"They're probably in the common room already," Baldwin noted, adjusting his spectacles as he stepped out behind Thomas.

The two boys made their way down the passage, forced to press their hands flat against the damp, panelled walls to steady themselves as the ship continued to rock and roll over the surging waves. With every rise and fall of the bow, Thomas felt a miserable cold sweat breaking out on the back of his neck. The ship's movement was bothering him more and more by the second, twisting his insides into tight knots.



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As they finally pushed through the double doors into the common room, the atmospheric magic of the space offered a brief distraction. The enchanted ceiling, which the night before had mirrored a midnight sky of deep ultramarine and dark indigo with a glowing silver moon, had completely transformed. It was now a vast expanse of clear, light morning blue. At its centre hung a rich, golden, stylised sun, radiating warm, illuminated rays that chased away the lingering shadows of the room. The constellations of stars, barely visible, had shifted following the Earth's rotation.

Scanning the room, Thomas and Baldwin quickly spotted Cecile and Celine sitting at the exact same heavy oak table they had occupied the previous night. The boys started navigating the moving floor toward them.

They were halfway there when the ship took a sudden, vicious plunge. The movement finally got the best of Thomas. His face drained of colour, he clamped a hand over his mouth, abandoned Baldwin, and sprinted frantically toward an open porthole window, just managing to lean out over the churning grey water before throwing up into the sea spray. For a few agonising seconds, as his physical and magical control slipped, the deep brown of his hair retreated slightly, allowing the luminous, bright pale blond of his natural state to shimmer into view at the roots.

He gripped the brass rim of the window, taking deep, shuddering breaths of the salty air, fighting to pull his disguise back into place.

## Wormwood

Before Celine, who had half-risen from her seat in alarm, could say a word, a painfully blunt, friendly female voice spoke up from directly behind them.

"You look horrible. Awful, really."

Thomas weakly turned his head, wiping his mouth with the back of his sleeve. Standing a few feet away was a small girl with long, light brown hair and a slightly tanned complexion. She wasn't looking at him, however; her attention was entirely focused on rummaging through a beautifully embroidered purse. Finding what she was looking for, she pulled out a small packet of dried, pungent herbs.

Without asking for permission, she grabbed a small wooden bowl from a

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nearby table, unstoppered a clay jar, and poured in a measure of water. Drawing her wand with practiced ease, she pointed it at the bowl.

“*Quiesce*,” she muttered. Immediately, the water inside the bowl stilled completely, lying perfectly flat and unbothered by the violent rocking of the ship. With another sharp flick of her wrist, she added, “*Aqua fervere*.”

The still water instantly began to boil and steam. She sprinkled the dried herbs into the boiling water, swirling it gently before stepping forward and shoving the steaming bowl directly into Thomas’s hands.

“It’s wormwood,” she stated matter-of-factly. “It will make you feel better, ease your seasickness. Drink.”

Thomas, desperate for any kind of relief, didn’t argue. He lifted the bowl and took a cautious sip of the hot infusion. The moment the liquid hit his tongue, his face scrunched up in an expression of profound disgust. He coughed, his eyes watering. “Gods, that’s more bitter than a shoe sole!”

“I said it would make your seasickness better,” she replied plainly, her expression entirely earnest. “Not that it would taste good.”

Grimacing, Thomas tipped the bowl back and drank the rest of the foul-tasting concoction in three large gulps, his facial expressions twisting violently, giving away exactly how much he loathed the taste. But almost instantly, the terrible, lurching knot in his stomach began to untangle, replaced by a soothing, localised warmth.

Feeling incredibly relieved, Thomas placed the wooden bowl—whose remaining dregs still miraculously rested perfectly flat despite a sudden tilt of the deck—onto the nearest table. He turned back to the girl, standing a bit straighter now.

“Thank you,” he said earnestly, extending his hand to compliment her quick spellwork. He opened his mouth to introduce himself, but she spoke over him.

“Mæve... Mæve Medici,” she said, briefly shaking his hand with a firm, completely un-self-conscious grip. She then gestured toward a table across the aisle. “And that’s Aiko Sanada.”

Thomas followed her gaze. Sitting alone at the table, radiating a quiet, intimidating stillness amidst the chaotic dining room, was another girl. Her

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appearance was extremely tidy, minimalist, and disciplined in her dress. Even after a night on a storm-tossed ship, her robes were immaculate, perfectly fitted, and free of unnecessary ornamentation. Resting securely against her hip, she wore her wand on a finely crafted leather belt. It was a unique masterpiece; a gleaming length crafted from goblin silver, housing a kitsune<sup>1</sup> hair core. The grip was visibly distinct, the handle made of honoki wood wrapped tightly in textured ray skin. She sat with impeccable posture, observing the room with dark, calculating eyes.

“I’m Thomas,” he said, offering a polite nod in Aiko’s direction. “Thomas Blackwood.”

The effect of his last name was instantaneous. Aiko’s disciplined, stoic mask—the face of a girl who clearly approached magic with the discipline of a warrior—fractured. She reacted with sudden, intense surprise, trying but failing to hide a surge of eager excitement. She practically leaned over the table.

“Blackwood?” Aiko asked, her voice tight with barely suppressed awe. “As in *Mary Elizabeth Blackwood*?” She had, after all, come all the way to Hogwarts specifically to study in the exact same place as Mary Elizabeth Blackwood, whom she considered the ultimate *bushi*. It was her life’s ambition to emulate her.

Sensing the dangerous territory of his famous aunt, Thomas expertly deflected, choosing instead not to answer the question directly. He took a step back, gesturing broadly to his right.

“This is Baldwin Attewell,” Thomas deflected seamlessly. He then pointed toward the table near the window. “And those two are Cecile and Celine. And—”

“Breakfast!”

Philippa came practically skidding into the common room, her hair slightly messy, completely unfazed by the violent rocking of the ship as she marched over to join them.

“—and this is Philippa,” Thomas finished, relieved by the distraction.

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<sup>1</sup>A fox spirit of Japanese folklore, believed to possess great intelligence, magical abilities, and the power to assume human form. The number of its tails, up to nine, indicates its age and power.

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Philippa looked between Mæve, who was busy re-tying her herb pouch, and Aiko, who was still staring fixedly at Thomas.

“Why don’t you two join us at our table?” Philippa offered warmly, effortlessly bridging the social gap.

Mæve nodded affirmatively, her focus already shifting to the plates of bread being brought out, while Aiko, recovering her minimalist composure, gave a sharp, formal nod of acceptance.

## The Sixth Ship

Mæve and Aiko had barely taken their seats when a member of the ship’s crew placed a wooden board laden with thick slices of bread. He gestured toward the far end of the common room, where the rest of the breakfast spread awaited.

It was a simpler fare than the lavish feast of the night before, but still far more than Thomas had expected. In one woven basket lay a variety of breads of different sizes, shapes, and shades of rye and wheat. Beside it sat the butter—which would prove to be much saltier than Thomas was accustomed to, heavily preserved to last the entire leg of the journey.

Further down the spread were baskets of fresh fruit: mostly apples and pears, dotted with late-summer plums and cherries. Beside them sat large glass jars where fruits lay suspended in thick, golden honey. As Philippa sagely pointed out to the group, the honeyed blackberries, figs, and dates might look like a tempting sweet, but experienced travellers knew to eat the fresh fruit now. Fresh apples and plums would only be available near the ports, while the honey-preserved provisions would sustain them for longer into the voyage.

For drink, a row of sturdy clay jugs offered barley water, cold water, and steaming hot water. Beside the hot water lay a wooden tray divided into compartments, each holding dried herbs and fruits for infusions: mint, chamomile, lavender, rose petals, elderflower, linden blossom, dried apple pieces, raspberries, and slices of pale ginger.

The group served themselves generously and returned to the table. Most opted for an herbal infusion, save for Thomas, who poured himself a cup of

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barley water, and Philippa, who brought back only a cup of plain cold water.

Once seated, however, Philippa reached into her purse. From its depths, she retrieved a beautiful *dallah*—a copper pot with a long, elegant spout and a wooden handle—along with a paper parcel that emitted a rich, dark, earthy aroma. She carefully spooned some of the dark brown powder into the vessel, added a touch of honey, and poured her water over it.

She then drew her wand. It was an exquisite piece of craftsmanship, fashioned from Mediterranean olive wood with a tight, dark grain, ending in a grip of shimmering Black Sea mother-of-pearl. A band of goblin silver joined the wood and pearl so precisely that the seam was nearly invisible. Intricate geometric carvings ran the entire length of the wand, flowing from wood to silver to pearl in one continuous, unbroken design.

With a practiced flick, Philippa tapped the base of the copper pot. “*Calefacio*.”

The bottom of the vessel instantly grew hot, the water inside hissing and bubbling to a boil. She waited a moment for the brew to settle, then poured a pitch-black liquid into her cup. She took a tentative sip, and a look of pure contentment washed over her face.

“Nothing better than some hot *qahwa*<sup>1</sup> to start the day,” she sighed happily.

The other students stared at her, thoroughly bewildered by the murky drink. Noticing their stares, Philippa smiled. “My dad brought it back from al-Yaman, in the far south of *Jaz̄irat al-‘Arab*<sup>2</sup>. It gives you a burst of energy. Perfect for early mornings.”

Mæve leaned forward, her eyes bright with curiosity. The promise of a potent, energy-giving brew was clearly too much for her to resist. “May I?” she asked.

Philippa obliged, pouring a small measure into a spare cup. Mæve took a hearty gulp—and immediately choked, coughing twice as her face contorted at the intense, bitter flavour.

Aiko let out a rare, melodic laugh. “There is not a herb, potion, or medicinal root on this earth that escapes my cabin companion’s attention,” the Japanese

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<sup>1</sup>The early Arabic term for coffee in Yemen.

<sup>2</sup>Literally “Island of the Arabs” — was the term used in medieval Arabic geography to describe the Arabian Peninsula, bounded by the Red Sea to the west, the Persian Gulf and the Sea of Oman to the east, and the Indian Ocean to the south.

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girl noted. Her Latin was flawless, spoken with a light, rhythmic accent that Thomas hadn't expected.

Mæve, recovering her breath and pushing the cup away, shot Aiko a playful glare. "Well, my cabin companion only thinks about combat and knights! Or *bushi*<sup>1</sup>, as she calls them. You all should see the size of the sword she has in our cabin."

"It is a *tachi*<sup>2</sup>," Aiko corrected smoothly, taking a delicate sip of her chamomile infusion. "And the journey from Kyoto to England is not without its dangers."

"Can you imagine?" Mæve asked the table, her eyes wide. "She has been traveling for more than two months already. All alone!"

"I wasn't exactly alone," Aiko replied, her tone perfectly mild. "I had the company of the crews and passengers across five different ships between the Far East and London. The *Siren* makes my sixth and final vessel."

For the remainder of the breakfast, the rocking of the *Siren* and the chill of the morning sea were entirely forgotten. The group sat in captivated silence, listening attentively as Aiko recounted the incredible voyage that had brought her from the far edges of the world to London. She spoke of the staggering scale of Zaiton, a bustling, cosmopolitan port in the East where her second ship had departed, and of Calicut, the legendary City of Spices on the Malabar Coast, where merchants of a hundred different tongues haggled over fortunes in pepper and silk. From there, her journey had taken her to Aden, the sun-baked gateway to the Red Sea in al-Yaman, before a brief overland trek brought her to the bustling docks of Alexandria, the great Mediterranean port founded by Alexander the Great and from where many Eastern spices and goods were sold to European merchants. From there she finally boarded the grand trading galleys of Venice to reach the English waters. For Philippa, whose family traded extensively across the Mediterranean and Arabia, the names of Venice, Alexandria, and even Aden were familiar territory, prompting knowing smiles and shared merchant

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<sup>1</sup>*Bushi* was the Japanese term for a warrior of the military class, later also known as *samurai*. In medieval Japan, *bushi* were trained from childhood in the arts of combat and military strategy, bound by a strict code of honour and loyalty.

<sup>2</sup>A *tachi* was a type of Japanese sword, longer and more curved than the later *katana*, worn suspended from the belt with the cutting edge facing downward. It was the primary sidearm of the mounted *bushi* and a mark of warrior status.

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knowledge. But the faraway docks of Calicut and Zaiton were entirely beyond her knowledge, and as Aiko described the vibrant, distant lands of the East, Philippa leaned forward, listening with just as much wide-eyed curiosity as the rest of them.

The sun had just slipped over the horizon, leaving behind an indigo twilight where the waning moon already hung prominent in the sky. The afternoon had been a lazy but deeply entertaining one. The newly expanded group had spent the better part of the day tucked away in the cozy warmth of the common room, listening to Aiko and Philippa trade stories of distant ports, foreign customs, and strange delicacies, all while passing the hours over a spirited game of Pachisi—or Ludo, as it was more commonly known in the British Isles.

## Polaris

As evening set in, Cecile, Celine, and Mæve decided to retire to their cabins for the night. Thomas, Baldwin, Philippa, and Aiko, however, felt the need to stretch their legs after hours of sitting. Together, they wrapped their cloaks tight against the biting sea wind and headed up to the middle deck to observe the night sky.

The deck was abuzz with a quiet, focused tension. Near a sturdy oak table, three men were gathered. Thomas immediately recognised one as the *Siren's* captain. Beside him stood the convoy's chief navigator, while a third man—likely a navigation assistant—approached from the stern, hauling a wet log line, a knotted rope with a piece of wood tied to its end to measure the ship's speed.

The chief navigator was currently squinting through a wooden cross-staff, shifting the sliding transom to measure the height of the Pole Star above the dark horizon to estimate their latitude. Spread across the oak table beneath the dim glow of a lantern lay a magnetic compass, rolls of astronomical maps, and trigonometric tables. The captain, meanwhile, hunched over a counting device—much like an abacus in form, but closer to a counting board in function—sliding beads to calculate their dead reckoning<sup>1</sup>.

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<sup>1</sup>A navigation method in which a ship's position is estimated from its last known location using speed, time, and compass heading. Reliable over short distances, but errors accumulate without celestial or landmark corrections.

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Around three meters away, at a second table, a young boy watched the men with a look of peaceful, perpetual awe. He had dark skin, was tall and remarkably skinny—possessing the posture of someone who spent far more time looking upward at the heavens than straight ahead at the world around him.

Resting on the table before him was a brass astrolabe. While it was standard requirement for Hogwarts astronomy classes, his was notably larger, brilliantly polished, and already showed the soft wear of extensive, loving use. In his right hand, he held a beautiful, elegant wand crafted from dark bog oak, its handle delicately engraved with the stars of the Cassiopeia constellation.

He held the wand not like a weapon, but precisely as a scholar might hold a quill. With smooth, deliberate strokes, he drew symbols and lines in thin air. The glowing, bright red “ink” of his magic hovered in the wind, contrasting sharply against the deepening indigo of the night sky.

Aiko paused, tilting her head. “Are those...?”

“Arabic numerals, yes,” Philippa murmured.

“I thought those looked familiar,” Aiko said softly. “Just like the ledgers of the merchants in Alexandria.”

The boy finished his calculations in a flurry of glowing red sweeps. With a casual, practiced flick of his bog oak wand, the floating mathematics dissolved. Without turning around, he spoke to himself—though his voice was perfectly pitched to carry over the wind to the officers’ table.

“Three degrees, twenty four minutes starboard, if we are to maintain the heading,” he murmured.

A minute or two later, the chief navigator finally finished manipulating his wooden counting board. He stared at his results, his jaw tightening. Looking highly vexed that an eleven-year-old boy had beaten him to the math, he grunted a confirmation to the captain. The captain then turned to the ship’s log, aggressively scratching onto the parchment using clunky *Is*, *Xs*, *Ls*, and *Ms*.

From his table, the boy watched the scratching quill with a faint, thoughtful smile. European navigators still clung so stubbornly to cumbersome Roman numerals. It was a stark contrast to the brilliant, elegant manuscripts on the



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heavenly bodies from the Maragha school<sup>1</sup>, which he had spent entirely too many hours reading back in the Merton College Library in his native Oxford.

Intrigued, Philippa stepped forward, the others trailing behind her. She warmly introduced herself and the rest of the group, and asked what exactly had just transpired.

The boy turned, his eyes reflecting the starlight. “Cassian,” he said, offering a slight, gracious bow. “Cassian Sterling. The convoy has found it necessary to alter our course. We are moving further away from the coast to avoid muggle embarkations.”

Thomas frowned, looking out at the dark, rolling waves. “Don’t we have concealment charms for that?”

“Concealment charms are rarely perfect, especially upon the open water,” Aiko chimed in practically. “The sea is entirely too unpredictable. Careless wizarding ships are the origin of half the muggle myths about phantom vessels and sea-devils.”

Cassian nodded slowly, his gaze drifting back up to the cosmos. “Precisely. We must venture so far from the shoreline that the coastal bonfires, and even the pharos of St Catherine’s Oratory on the Isle of Wight, will slip beyond the curvature of the earth. Out here, in the vast, unbroken dark... the captain and his navigator must rely entirely upon the position of the stars to orient the ship, lest we wander aimlessly off our course.”

As he spoke, Philippa noted how entirely unique the boy’s voice was. Cassian spoke with a very particular, slow, and rhythmic cadence. His diction was impossibly clear, and he deliberately stretched out and emphasised specific words—not just to maximise their comprehension, but to evoke a profound sense of wonder in his listeners.

Baldwin, stepping up beside Thomas, looked up at the dizzying spray of stars. “How exactly does one use them to navigate?”

Cassian’s perpetual smile widened into something radiant. His fascination with the heavenly bodies was instantly, undeniably magnetic. “Consider the night sky,” he said, his voice dropping to a warm, resonant timbre. “It is not merely a scattering of light, but a grand, cosmic clockwork.”

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<sup>1</sup>An astronomical observatory in Maragha, Persia. Its scholars produced some of the most advanced astronomical work of the medieval world.

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He raised his bog oak wand. A thin, glowing red line shot from the tip, soaring up to connect the stars high above them. First, he traced the jagged “W” of Cassiopeia. Then, he swept his wand across the dark expanse, linking seven bright stars. “Behold Charles’ Wain, or The Plough as it’s also known by.”

His wand lingered on the two stars at the front of the plough’s blade. “These two... Dubhe and Merak. They are the pointers.” He extended a brilliant red thread of magic outward from those two stars, drawing it across the sky until it pierced a solitary, bright star in the north. “They point the way to Polaris, the Pole Star. The one fixed point in our rotating sky.”

Lowering his wand, Cassian picked up his heavy brass astrolabe. “Because Polaris remains steadfast above the northern pole of our world, we need only measure its height above the horizon with the astrolabe to divine our exact latitude.”

He then reached into his robes and produced a small, beautifully crafted pocket brass compass. “And, as the Plough rotates around that fixed star throughout the night, acting as the hand of a great celestial dial... we may use the orientation of those stars to measure the exact time of the night.” Cassian looked at them, his eyes wide with profound, genuine awe. “We are never truly lost, so long as we remember to look up.”

## 5 The Irish Sea

The morning arrived without drama. Thomas became aware of it gradually — the quality of the light through the gap above the curtain, warmer and more direct than the grey seep of the previous days, and then the sound of boots on the deck above, purposeful and unhurried, the ordinary noise of a crew that wasn't managing a crisis.

He lay still for a moment, listening for the ship's motion. The long, rolling swell was still there, but it was gentle now, almost courteous, the Siren moving through the water as though she belonged there.

Pippin made a small, contented sound on his hook.

Thomas got up.

### A Roof Tile for Breakfast

By the time he reached the main deck, the crew had already been at work for some time. Two long tables had been mounted on the open deck amidships, sturdy and well-secured to cleats bolted into the planking, and benches fixed alongside them. The sky above was a clean, pale blue, the kind that suggests it has been that way for some time and intends to continue. The sun was still low but already warm on the face when you turned toward it. The sea around them was dark and calm, running in slow, easy swells that caught the light along their crests.

Baldwin appeared at his shoulder, blinking behind his spectacles.

"Oh," Baldwin said, looking at the sky with the expression of someone revising their expectations upward.

"Yes," Thomas agreed.

They found places at the nearer table. Others arrived in ones and twos — Philippa, who looked at the weather with satisfaction, as though it had made

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a sensible decision; Celine, who tilted her face toward the sun immediately and closed her eyes for a moment before sitting down; Cecile, who assessed the tables, the benches, and the securing arrangements before sitting down, satisfied that they were adequate.

Breakfast came up from the galley in a wooden crate, and the contrast with the previous mornings was immediate and democratically suffered.

The bread was gone. In its place were ship's biscuits<sup>1</sup> — hard, flat, pale rounds that looked considerably more confident than they had any right to be. Thomas picked one up and discovered it had the density and temperament of a roof tile.

“You have to soak it,” Cecile said, without looking up. She had already placed hers in her cup and was waiting with the patience of someone who had done this before.

A round-faced boy with rosy cheeks, who had arrived at the table looking entirely cheerful for early morning on the open sea, picked up his biscuit and examined it with an expression of polite scepticism. He took a considered bite.

The sound it produced was architectural.

He set it down carefully. “Right,” he said, with great composure, reaching for his cup.

Celine laughed. Philippa passed him the pot of hot water.

“Barnabus Finch,” the boy said, by way of introduction, dunking his biscuit with the composure of a boy who had just learned an important lesson about the sea.

The fresh fruit was also gone. The basket in the centre of the table held honeyed fruits instead — figs and blackberries suspended in thick golden honey, dates soft and dark at the bottom of their jar, and slices of apple preserved in the same amber sweetness. Philippa took the honeyed apple slices from the smaller basket at the table's end and distributed them without comment, the implicit message being that this was what there was now and

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<sup>1</sup>A flat, hard bread made from flour, water, and sometimes salt, baked multiple times to remove all moisture. Hard, dry breads of this kind have sustained armies and sailors since antiquity — the Roman military carried a similar provision called *bucellatum*. It required soaking in water or broth to be edible.

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should be appreciated accordingly.

The biscuits, once sufficiently soaked, were not exactly good. But they were edible, and the butter that came with them — heavily salted, preserved for the journey — improved matters considerably.

The morning settled into itself.

## Up to Four to a Board

Someone produced a Pachisi board before the cups were cleared, and then another appeared, and by mid-morning four games were running simultaneously on the two tables, the boards laid out in the patches of sun between the cups and the honey jars.

The games enforced their own groupings, up to four to a board, and the groupings produced their own small dramas.

Cassian Sterling played with the unhurried goodwill of a boy whose attention was mostly elsewhere. He moved his pieces correctly and without apparent error, but between turns his gaze drifted upward — to the rigging, to the horizon, and most frequently to the sky itself, which offered nothing of particular astronomical interest at this hour but seemed to content him anyway. He won the first game by a margin that surprised everyone, including apparently himself, having spent most of it studying a formation of clouds to the northwest.

“You weren’t even watching the board,” Aiko said.

“I was watching it,” Cassian said, still looking at the clouds.

Aiko Sanada played the way she did most things — with precise, minimal movements and an expression that gave nothing away. She did not take risks. She did not need to. Her pieces advanced with a consistency that was less exciting to watch than some of the other players but produced results with a reliability that became, over the course of the game, quietly unnerving.

Mæve Medici played earnestly and well, a small book and a cup of something medicinal open beside her on the bench — Thomas could tell from the smell, which was the kind of smell that was very serious about its intentions and that no one would seek out for pleasure.

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Griffin Ollivander turned the board over twice to examine its construction before the first game began, and had to be reminded on three separate occasions that it was his turn. When he did move, he moved quickly and without hesitation, as though the decision had been made some time ago and he had simply been thinking about something else in the interim. He had a leather tool roll on the bench beside him that he consulted during longer waits for reasons that remained unclear.

Thomas played, and lost, and played again. The morning passed in the particular way that good mornings on the water pass — slowly enough to feel long, quickly enough that the sun was already well up before he thought to check it.

## Enjoy It

Philippa stretched her arms above her head and looked at the sky with an expression of uncomplicated pleasure.

“This is wonderful,” she said. “I could stay here.”

“Enjoy it,” Cecile said, from across the table. “The Irish Sea is unpredictable. It can change from one moment to the next.”

Philippa considered this, then turned her face back to the sun. “All the more reason.”

The afternoon came in warm and slow. The games continued, new configurations forming as students moved between tables. Conversations started and stopped and started again. Someone found a ball of twine and two of the second-years organised a game at the stern that Thomas didn’t fully understand but that seemed to involve a great deal of argument conducted in excellent spirits.

The sea stayed calm. The sun moved across the sky at its own pace, indifferent to the journey.

By mid-afternoon the coast had appeared to the west — low at first, a dark line that could have been cloud, then gradually resolving into land, green and definite. It came closer as the afternoon wore on, the line thickening and differentiating, and Thomas found himself watching it from the rail with the

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particular attention you give to things you haven't seen before.

Dublin. He had never seen it.

## The City on the Ridge

The sun was sitting on the western horizon, fat and orange and slightly flattened by the atmosphere, when the Siren rounded the headland and Dublin opened up before them.

Thomas had expected a port. What he saw was a city.

It came at you from the water in layers. The waterfront first — the timber wharves extending into the Liffey, the cranes and the loading apparatus of a working port, the boats of various sizes moored or moving, the smell of fish and salt and the particular damp-wood smell of a river meeting the sea. Behind the waterfront the city walls ran solid and serious along the bank, their stonework the colour of old bone in the evening light, gates and towers spaced along their length with the practical regularity of structures that were maintained because they needed to be. The city pressed itself inside those walls with the density of a place that had learned not to sprawl.

Above it all, on the ridge that rose behind the rooftops, Christ Church Cathedral caught the last of the sun on its stonework — Romanesque at its base, the pointed arches of newer work rising above, the whole structure sitting on its elevation with the authority of something that had organised the city's skyline around itself for two centuries and intended to continue. To the east, the square towers of the castle were just visible above the roofline, solid and administrative.

The bells were ringing the hour as they came into the harbour. The sound carried clearly over the water, mixing with the noise of the port — the calls of the dock workers, the creak of rope and timber, the complaint of gulls circling the fish wharves in the orange light.

Thomas watched the city come closer and didn't say anything. It didn't seem to require comment.

The ship took on fresh water and supplies while the light failed, the crew working efficiently in the last of the dusk and then by lantern. Passengers

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came aboard — a few at a time, their trunks and bags winched up or carried, the goblin clerk at his high desk scratching names into his ledger with the same rhythmic indifference his counterpart had shown in London.

Most of the students stayed on the open deck. The tables were still out and the evening was still warm enough, and no one was particularly willing to give up the open air until compelled. A second-year from Cork produced a wooden flute and played it quietly at the stern, a melody modal and unhurried that suited the hour exactly.

Dinner came up from the shore kitchen in covered pots, and the smell that preceded it up the gangway was enough to produce a general movement toward the tables before it had fully arrived.

It was a different order of meal from the biscuits of the morning. There was brown bread, dense and dark and still faintly warm, with a crust that gave properly under the hand, and beside it crocks of butter so good that Thomas stopped after the first piece and looked at it with quiet respect. Salt-cured and rich, it had a depth that the London butter hadn't. Cecile spread hers with the focused appreciation of a person who understood butter professionally.

There was fish — fresh from the bay, simply prepared, with a clarity of flavour that needed nothing added to it. There was a pottage of leek and parsnip and onion, thick and savoury, served in deep wooden bowls. There was more bread. There was, somewhat unexpectedly, a pot of something dark and softly spiced that turned out to be a preserve of blackberries, and which disappeared faster than anything else on the table.

Celine, who had been picking cautiously at the ship's provisions for two days with the expression of someone too polite to comment, ate with unrestrained enthusiasm for the first time since London, which seemed to please Cecile enormously.

The flute player at the stern changed to something with more movement in it. The lanterns on the dock threw long orange shapes across the water. Somewhere in the city, another set of bells marked the hour.

The ship left in the dead of night.

Thomas didn't know exactly when — he was asleep before the gangway was raised, the brown bread and the good butter and the long day of sun



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having done their work thoroughly. He felt it, dimly, at the edge of sleep: the changed quality of the ship's movement as she left the shelter of the harbour, the slight deepening of the Liffey's smell before the open sea replaced it, the distant sound of the dock bells receding.

By the time he was aware of any of it, they were already gone.

## The Irish Hare

Cecile and Celine came back to their cabin after dinner to find it no longer entirely theirs.

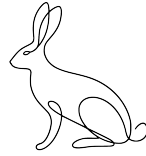
The third berth, the upper left, which had been empty since London, had an occupant. A trunk was stored neatly below it — not large, but covered in a pattern of hand-stitched embroidery along its leather straps, small repeated motifs in dark thread that were too detailed to make out in the lamplight. From the berth itself came the slow, even breathing of someone deeply and completely asleep.

On the small foldable table, held down against the motion of the ship by a brass candlestick placed on its corner, was a folded piece of paper. Cecile picked it up.

The handwriting inside was neat and slightly forward-leaning, the Latin correct and natural, the tone of the thing entirely without self-consciousness.

*To my cabin companions — I am sorry to miss you this evening. I boarded late and I'm afraid the journey from home has caught up with me entirely. I hope you'll forgive me for sleeping through our introduction. My name is Elara O'Connell. I'm from Dublin, first year, and I'm very glad to meet you both, even if you are currently asleep and reading this in the morning — or still awake and reading it now, in which case I hope you had a good dinner. I heard it was prepared on shore and I have hopes for it. We can talk properly tomorrow. Good night.*

— Elara



Below the signature, in the space left at the bottom of the page, something moved.

Celine leaned closer, holding the lamp low over the paper. A hare — small, perfectly observed, rendered in a handful of sure lines — was making its way across the lower margin of the letter. It moved with the particular lightness of a hare at speed, ears flat, hindquarters driving, each hop covering the distance with an ease that made the small space of the page seem briefly larger than it was. It reached the edge, paused for a fraction of a second as though considering, and then turned and came back the other way, unhurried now, stopping once to sit up and look at nothing before continuing its circuit.

Celine watched it for a long moment without speaking.

“I like her already,” she said.

Cecile looked at the letter, then at the sleeping figure in the upper berth, then back at the hare still making its quiet rounds at the bottom of the page.

“Yes,” she said. “So do I.”

## The Changed Motion

Thomas was not sure what woke him. Not a sound exactly — more the absence of the rhythm he had fallen asleep to. The Siren had found a steady motion somewhere in the Irish Sea, a long, rolling movement that had lulled him under almost immediately after his head touched the pillow. Now that motion was gone, replaced by a shorter, more erratic rhythm, the ship climbing and dropping in a way that suggested the sea had changed its mind about the whole arrangement.

He lay still for a moment, listening. Rain, heavy and insistent, against the deck above. The groan of timber under stress. Pippin shifting on his hook, feathers rustling in the dark.

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He climbed down from his berth.

Baldwin was already awake, sitting on the edge of his lower berth with his spectacles on, which meant he had been awake for some time. He looked up when Thomas's feet hit the floor.

"Rough," Baldwin said.

"Yes," Thomas agreed.

They dressed without much discussion and made their way up to the common room.

It was empty of students. The enchanted ceiling was doing its best with difficult material — a dark, turbulent sky, the stars entirely gone behind cloud, the golden constellations absent for the first time since they had boarded. The lamps swung on their brackets with every roll of the ship. At the far end of the room, near the door that led to the sterncastle, Headmaster Hepburn was standing with the captain, both men leaning over the navigation table, speaking in low voices.

Thomas and Baldwin took the nearest bench and sat down quietly. Neither man had noticed them.

"— can't hold this heading much longer," the captain was saying. His voice was the voice of someone delivering an assessment rather than a complaint, precise and without drama. "Visibility is gone. I can't see the coastal lights and I won't risk moving in closer to find them. Not in this."

"How far are we from the passage?" Hepburn asked.

"Far enough that it matters." The captain straightened. "We need guidance, Headmaster. The stars are covered and the lights are useless to us. If we sit here we lose time we don't have, and if we move blind we risk the rocks."

Hepburn was quiet for a moment. Thomas watched him think — the headmaster's broad face still, his eyes on the navigation table without really looking at it.

"The selkies," Hepburn said.

The captain nodded once, as though this was the answer he had been waiting for someone else to say first. "It's that or we anchor and wait out the storm."

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Which could be two days.”

“We can’t wait two days.” Hepburn straightened and reached for his wand. “Wake the staff. I want every first and second year student in this room. As quickly as you can manage it.”

Thomas and Baldwin looked at each other.

“Selkies,” Baldwin said, quietly enough that it didn’t carry.

“You know what they are?” Thomas asked.

“I’ve read about them.” Baldwin pushed his spectacles up. “Not much. The sources I found weren’t particularly —” he paused, searching for the right word, “— convinced they were real.”

“They apparently are,” Thomas said.

They didn’t have to wait long. Philippa arrived first, which surprised no one who had spent any time around Philippa — she appeared to have been fully dressed already, her blue eyes alert, taking in the navigation table and the two men and the general atmosphere of controlled urgency with the rapid assessment of someone who had grown up around merchant emergencies.

“What’s happened?” she asked, sitting down across from them.

Thomas opened his mouth. Baldwin got there first, turning on the bench to face her and launching into a precise, slightly breathless account of everything they had overheard, in sequence, with very little editorialising. He had the manner of someone who had spent years in a bookshop absorbing information and had been waiting for a situation that required it.

He was halfway through when Celine appeared in the doorway, her sister a step behind her. Celine was still in her nightclothes, a heavy wool blanket pulled around her shoulders, her hair loose and her expression suggesting she had been woken from deep sleep and had come anyway without stopping to argue about it. Cecile was dressed, but only just, and was looking around the room with the careful attention she brought to everything.

They sat down. Baldwin, with minimal prompting, repeated himself from the beginning.

Philippa and Celine both looked at Cecile when he reached the part about

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the selkies.

Cecile shook her head slightly. “Don’t look at me. Both my previous journeys were entirely uneventful. I’ve never heard of this being done.” She considered for a moment. “Which I suppose means it doesn’t happen often.”

## All First and Second Years

The room filled gradually after that. Students arrived in ones and twos, some dressed and some not, all carrying the slightly dazed quality of people assembled by authority in the middle of the night. Thomas watched them come in, putting names to faces where he could — Mæve Medici arrived with her herb pouch already in her hand, which suggested that whatever she had been doing before the summons, sleeping had not been part of it. Cassian Sterling came in looking not at the people around him but upward, at the empty ceiling where the constellations should have been, with the expression of someone personally affronted by the cloud cover.

And then a boy Thomas hadn’t yet met came through the door, and the room was slightly different for it.

He was flamboyant — there was no other word that fit as precisely — not in the manner of someone demanding attention but in the manner of someone so entirely himself that attention followed as a natural consequence. He wore his robes with a deep green scarf wound at his neck, and he moved through the filling room with an unhurried ease, finding a place to stand near the port windows and looking out at the darkness beyond the glass with the focused interest of someone who intended to understand what he was looking at. Beside him, a girl with dark hair and a smudge of charcoal on her cheekbone was already doing the same — not looking at the people arriving around her but at the swinging lamps, the shifting ceiling, the room itself. She had a sketchbook under her arm.

Hepburn waited until the movement settled, then raised his voice.

“Thank you for coming. I’ll be brief.” He explained the situation in the same direct terms he had used with the captain — the weather, the visibility, the risk of the rocks, the need for guidance that the ship’s instruments couldn’t provide in these conditions. “Selkies know these waters,” he said. “They

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can guide us through safely. But calling them requires a chant, and selkies are more responsive to younger voices — they find them closer to their own nature. That’s why you’re here.”

He moved through the room distributing strips of parchment. “The Latin portion, all of you should manage. The Gaelic —” he paused, scanning the room, “— who among you knows it?”

Elara O’Connell raised her hand without hesitation. Two second-years followed — a boy and a girl, Scottish by the look of them.

“Good.” Hepburn gave them a separate parchment. “You’ll carry the second portion. Everyone else follows my lead on the Latin. We’ll perform the chant in the lower hull, close to the water. Follow me.”

## The Third Voice

The lower hull was cold and close and smelled of tar and bilgewater and the sea pressing against the other side of the timber. The lamps down here were fewer, and the ones that were lit swung more dramatically than those above, throwing the curved walls into alternating light and shadow. The students pressed together in the available space, shoulders touching, the ship’s movement more pronounced down here, more immediate.

Thomas kept one hand on a support beam. Beside him, Baldwin had his parchment raised to catch the lamp light.

Hepburn raised his hand. The room stilled.

They began.

The Latin came up first and it came up well — twenty voices finding the rhythm together, filling the low space with something that felt purposeful and deliberate. Then the Gaelic rose beneath it, Elara’s voice leading, the two second-years following, and for a moment the two portions found each other and became a single thing.

They finished. Hepburn raised his hand for silence.

They waited.

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The hull spoke in its own language — the long groan of stressed timber, the irregular knock of waves, the high thin whistle of wind through a gap somewhere above. Nothing else. No answer.

The captain, standing near the forward bulkhead, did not move. Hepburn's expression remained composed, but Thomas saw his eyes move sideways toward the captain and then back.

"Again," Hepburn said.

The second attempt was bigger. Some of the students who had listened carefully the first time began to approximate the Gaelic phonetically, following Elara and the second-years by ear, shaping the sounds without understanding them, giving the chant more body. Thomas tried it himself, watching Elara's mouth and doing his best to follow. It felt clumsy and probably sounded worse, but the collective effort was real.

They finished. Hepburn held the silence again.

Nothing came back. The hull gave them only the storm.

The captain turned partially away and spoke in a low, rapid voice to his first mate. Hepburn was very still. The apprehension in the room no longer had to be looked for — it had weight and temperature, pressing in alongside the cold.

Thomas looked at his parchment. The Latin was correct. He had pronounced it correctly. It hadn't been enough the first time and it hadn't been enough the second time, and he didn't know what the third time would do differently.

Then Reza Pahrs began to sing.

He wasn't singing the words. He had no Gaelic, clearly, and he wasn't attempting to pronounce it either. He was singing the notes of the Gaelic portion — the melodic line that ran underneath the words, separated from its text entirely, as though he had listened twice and quietly removed the music from its container. He started low, in a register that was velvet smooth, each note placed with an unhurried certainty. Then the line rose, and somewhere in the upper register there was a quality that was not quite roughness but not smoothness either — a texture, like the grain in worked wood. Both qualities present, neither cancelling the other.

Elara turned toward him slowly, her expression unguarded, entirely caught

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off balance. She studied him the way she studied an exquisite work of art — not as a mystery to be solved, but as a thing worth simply appreciating.

One by one the other voices fell into place, not from confusion but because something had changed in the room and everyone felt it, the way you feel a shift in pressure before weather arrives.

Reza sang on. He found something beneath the melodic line — a second thread, lower, offered rather than stated, patient — and the two lines moved together in the close, lamp-lit space of the hull.

The answer came almost immediately.

Three sharp knocks, low and resonant and entirely deliberate, from the port side of the hull. A pause. Then two more, further forward. Then a long, slow sequence running from the bow toward midship, measured and clear, like a hand moving purposefully along the outside of the timber.

Hepburn's face changed. The relief on it was complete and immediate, a man setting down a heavy apprehension he had been carrying without showing it. Around him, the crew straightened collectively, the tension leaving their shoulders all at once.

"Starboard," Hepburn said, already moving toward the captain. "Two knocks, turn to starboard. Take her around."

The captain was already calling upward through the hatch, his voice carrying the same precision it had in the common room, unhurried and exact. Above them, the ship began to move differently.

Reza had stopped singing. He was listening to the last of the knocking with his head tilted slightly, a look of quiet attention on his face.

Elara was still watching him. "How did you know to do that?"

He turned to her. "They just like good music, darling."

## The Stone Coin

Hepburn sent them upstairs while the crew worked. The common room was warmer than the hull and the ceiling had shifted during their absence — the



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storm sky still dark and roiling, but the enchanted light of the lamps seemed to have registered the change in the room's mood, burning a fraction steadier than before.

They gathered at the familiar table by the window. Bread had been laid out, and butter, and a basket of apples from Dublin, and the pot of hot water with herbs beside it. Outside the glass, the sea remained invisible, the rain moving in long sheets across the darkness.

Thomas poured himself a cup of barley water and sat down. From below, muffled through two decks of timber, came two measured knocks — a correction to the heading, perhaps, or a warning passed and heeded. The sound was distant but clear, and reassuring in a way he hadn't expected.

Baldwin had been quiet since they came up the stairs. He was doing his thinking face — spectacles pushed up, hands around his cup, eyes focused on something slightly in front of him rather than the room.

Reza sat down across from Elara without particular ceremony, unwinding his scarf slightly in the warmth. Elara had opened her sketchbook on the table beside her bread and was looking at a page she had apparently filled during the night — the hull's curved timbers, the swinging lamps, a few quick lines that suggested the shape of the storm outside without depicting it directly.

"I'm Reza," he said, to her and to the table generally.

Elara looked up. She introduced herself, then worked around the table — Thomas, Baldwin, Philippa, Celine, Cecile — and Reza acknowledged each name with a nod that was brief and attentive, filing them away properly.

"I knew selkies existed," Baldwin said suddenly, not quite to anyone. "I'd read about them. The sources I found called it folklore." He paused. "The sources were wrong."

"The sources always call it folklore," Elara said, tearing a piece of bread. "In Ireland we don't need to write it down to know it's true."

"What do you know about them?" Thomas asked her.

She considered, the bread held loosely in her fingers. "They live in the sea. They can shed the seal skin and take human form on land. They're not dangerous unless they've been wronged. They don't particularly seek out wizards — they have their own concerns, which are older than ours." She

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glanced at Baldwin. “They can be called in the old way, when the need is genuine and the call is made properly. They come because they choose to. Not because they’re obliged to.”

“But they came,” Celine said.

“The call was right, eventually.” Elara looked at Reza briefly, then back at her bread.

“I’ve read that there are formal arrangements,” Baldwin said, thinking aloud. “Between the wizarding world and —” He stopped. The door from the corridor had opened.

The selkie came in without announcement, and the room rearranged itself around him the way a room does when something enters that belongs to a different set of rules. He was lean, with black hair and pale skin and bare feet that left faint damp prints on the wooden floor. He wore a simple linen tunic under a seal skin draped across one shoulder. He was slightly wet and entirely unbothered by it. His eyes moved across the room once, taking everything in, and then settled on Hepburn.

Hepburn rose. He crossed the room with a respect that was not the formal courtesy he might extend to a visiting dignitary but quieter and more considered. He drew his wand.

“What is he doing?” Philippa asked under her breath.

“Watch,” Elara said.

Hepburn produced a Galleon from his coat, held it up briefly, and set it on the table between them. He touched it once with his wand. The gold shifted, dulled, lost its warmth, and became stone — the same shape and markings as before, but grey and cold and heavy-looking where it had been bright a moment ago.

The selkie looked at it. He picked it up.

“That stone,” Baldwin said slowly, working it through as he spoke, “is —”

“An obligation,” Elara said. “The wizarding council made it mandatory. If a selkie presents that stone to a wizard, that wizard is required to provide assistance. Not asked. Required. The closest wizard to them when they show it is bound to help — there’s no refusal. No choice.” She paused. “After the

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help is given, the stone turns back to gold. That's the payment."

"So the gold is the end of the debt," Philippa said, watching Hepburn.

"The stone is the debt," Elara said. "The gold closes it."

The selkie held the stone coin in his closed hand for a moment. Then he inclined his head toward Hepburn — not quite a bow, but carrying the same weight as one, an acknowledgment between parties who regarded each other as worth the formality. Hepburn returned it.

The selkie turned toward the door.

At the threshold he paused — not long, barely a full second — and his gaze moved back across the room. It found Reza, who was sitting with his cup and his green scarf, watching the whole thing with calm, interest and intent to remember it. The selkie looked at him. Just looked, for that fraction of a second — the particular recognition of one creature for another who has done something worth acknowledging — and then he was gone.

The door settled shut behind him.

From below, distant and clear, a single long knock sounded against the hull. Then silence. The ship moved steadily beneath them, and outside the rain continued, but the quality of the movement had changed — purposeful now, guided, finding its way through the dark with something alongside it that knew the water and the rocks and the shape of the passage ahead.

Celine let out a slow breath.

"Well," said Reza, picking up his cup at last. "That was a very good morning."

## 6 Crécy

*Paris, the 16th day of August, in the year of our Lord 1347*

*From Étienne de Beaumont, Conseiller en Chef de la Confrérie des Arts de la Sorcellerie de France, to his esteemed colleague and dear friend Malcolm Dunbar, Chief Councillor to the Wizards' Council of Scotland, Edinburgh.*

Malcolm,

I trust this letter finds you in good health and that the summer has been pleasant in Edinburgh. I write to you tonight not with the usual matters of commerce and council, but with something that has kept me from sleep for three consecutive nights, and which I fear will keep me from sleep for many more. I ask that you read what follows with the seriousness I know you to possess, and that you forgive the directness of my account. There is no gentle way to present it.

You will have heard of the battle at Crécy. It was fought, in Picardy, between the forces of King Philip and those of the English King Edward. I will spare you the military particulars — they are the business of Muggle kings and of little consequence to our affairs. What concerns us is what came after.

A soldier was recovered by a French scouting party three days following the engagement. He was the sole survivor found upon the field. He was a common man-at-arms, a man of no particular education or standing, and he was in a state of such severe distress that the physicians who attended him believed he had lost his mind entirely. He had not. I have since spoken with him myself, at considerable length, and I am satisfied that what he witnessed

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was real.

He told me the following.

He had been wounded during the battle and had lost consciousness. He awoke in darkness, lying among the dead. The field was still. He could not determine how much time had passed, only that it was early into the night. As his eyes adjusted, he became aware of movement among the fallen — both French and English alike, for the dead do not observe allegiance.

At first he took the shapes for horses, or for men on horseback. They were neither. He described a figure without skin, the raw musculature exposed, the body a grotesque junction of man and horse fused into a single form. The torso of a man rose from the back of a horse's body, but there was no separation between the two — the flesh and sinew ran continuous, as though the creature had been made wrong from the beginning and had never been corrected. The arms were long, ending in claws of considerable reach. It moved on hooves.

The description is unmistakable. What this soldier encountered is what your countrymen in the Northern Isles call a Nuckelavee.

It was tearing the dead apart.

Not with hunger or purpose that the soldier could discern. The long arms reached down, the claws opened the armour and the bodies beneath with an ease that suggested the resistance of steel and bone was negligible to the creature. It worked methodically, moving from one body to the next. As the soldier watched, paralysed with terror, he counted. There were seven.

Seven Nuckelavees upon the field, moving among the dead of both armies, the hooves striking the helmets and breastplates of the fallen, the claws pulling men apart as one might pull apart wet bread.

A second survivor — a man the soldier had not known was alive —

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made a sound. A breath, or a moan, or the involuntary noise of a body failing. It was enough. The nearest creature turned toward the sound with immediacy. It covered the distance at speed. The soldier heard the impact and the sound that followed. He told me he closed his eyes. When he opened them, the man was in two separate pieces and the creature had already returned to its work.

The soldier understood then that absolute stillness was the only thing preserving his life. He began to move, slowly, using the bodies around him as concealment, dragging himself across the field on his stomach. He told me he crawled for what felt like an hour. He did not look up. He moved toward the sound of running water — a small stream that crossed the edge of the field.

He reached it. In his exhaustion, or his terror, he lost his footing on the bank and fell into the water. The splash was considerable, and the sound carried.

One of the creatures came. He described it covering the ground between them in seconds. He could hear the hooves on the earth, and then, as the creature reached the margin of the stream, a sound he did not expect — a violent, agonised shriek. The water thrown up by his fall had struck the creature. Where it touched the exposed flesh, the reaction was immediate and severe. The creature recoiled, writhing.

The soldier, operating now on nothing but the instinct of a man who has found the one thing that hurts the thing trying to kill him, began to throw water. He cupped it in his hands, he kicked it, he hurled it with every motion available to his broken body. The creature retreated. A second one, approaching from behind the first, stopped at the water's edge and would not cross. The soldier kept throwing water until his arms would no longer obey him. Then he collapsed in the stream.

That is where the scouting party found him. Half-submerged, barely breathing, still lying in the running water as though some part of him understood, even in unconsciousness, that it was the

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only safe place left.

His account was dismissed by the military physicians as battlefield madness. It came to our attention by the usual channels — the Confrérie maintains observers among the Muggle forces, as you know — and when the details reached me, I felt a coldness in my chest that has not yet left.

It is widely known among our kind that the appearance of a Nuckelavee is a presage of pestilence. Malcolm, you know the stories as well as I do. Before the great pestilence of Justinian<sup>1</sup>, which devastated the Eastern Roman Empire and ravaged the known world from the shores of Persia to Gaul and the Iberian Peninsula, three were seen upon a field of the recently dead — the largest number ever recorded together.

Three, and the known world was brought to its knees. There were seven upon the field at Crécy.

I do not know what is coming, my friend. But I believe something is, and I believe it will be worse than anything the histories record. I am sharing this with you before I present it formally to the Confrérie, because I trust your judgement above that of my own council, and because whatever approaches will not respect the borders between our nations any more than it will respect the borders between our world and the Muggle one.

I urge you to inform the Council and to take whatever precautionary measures you deem appropriate. I will do the same here, once I find the words that will make old men in comfortable chairs listen to the testimony of a common soldier about things they would prefer not to believe in.

Write to me soon. I find I am in need of the counsel of a friend.

With the deepest respect and urgency,

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<sup>1</sup>The devastating pandemic that struck the Byzantine Empire in 541 AD. It is believed to have killed tens of millions and is one of the deadliest pandemics in recorded history.

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Étienne de Beaumont



## 7 The Isle of Man

The island appeared to starboard in the early afternoon — a low, dark mass of green hills and grey rock, sitting in the Irish Sea. The sky was overcast but not threatening, a pale, even grey that flattened the light and made the sea look like hammered tin.

The stop was brief. The Siren dropped anchor in a sheltered bay while a small tender ferried passengers and cargo from the shore. Most of the new arrivals were older — fifth and sixth-years returning from summer, a few adults who might have been parents or Council officials, their faces set with the particular expression of people resuming duties they had briefly been free of. Their trunks came aboard in nets, swung up by the crew with practised indifference.

Among them, conspicuously alone and visibly younger than anyone else on the tender, was a boy. He was slight and pale, with black hair that looked as though it had been combed at some point that morning and had since abandoned all pretence of cooperation. He stood near the bow of the small boat with his trunk at his feet and his hands in his pockets, watching the hull of the Siren grow larger with an expression that was difficult to read — not quite nervous, not quite calm, but held carefully between the two.

Thomas, leaning on the rail above, watched the tender come alongside. One first-year boy, no owl, no companion. He checked the slip of paper from the goblin clerk at London. Cabin eleven, four berths, two others scheduled to embark at the Isle of Man and Dumbarton. This had to be one of them.

He made his way down to the main deck, where two crew members were already lowering a rope ladder over the side.

The boy climbed up with more determination than grace, his trunk hauled after him in a net by one of the sailors. Thomas stepped forward as he swung his legs over the rail.

“Thomas Blackwood,” he said, extending a hand as the boy stepped aboard. “I think we’re sharing a cabin.”

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The boy looked at the hand, then at Thomas, and took it. His grip was brief and gentle. “Conall Quayle,” he said. His voice was quiet, with an accent that softened the consonants and gave the vowels a particular, rounded quality — unmistakably Manx.

“Can I help with that?” Thomas gestured to the trunk. It was not large, but Conall was not large either.

“I can manage,” Conall said, and then, after a pause that suggested he was reconsidering the narrow stairs down to the middle deck and the weight of the trunk relative to his own frame, “Actually, yes. Thank you.”

They carried it between them down to the middle deck, Thomas navigating the familiar route while Conall took in the narrow corridors, the oil lamps, the smell of lavender and timber and sea. Thomas showed him the cabin — the two remaining berths, the hooks for cloaks, the small folding table — and left him to settle in.

At lunch, which was served on the open deck in the thin, grey daylight, Thomas brought Conall to the usual table and introduced him to the group. Conall sat beside Baldwin, ate his food without complaint, and answered questions politely but briefly. He smiled when Philippa made a joke about the ship’s biscuits having developed a personality of their own, and he listened with quiet attention when Cassian pointed out a formation of gannets diving into the water off the port side, but he did not volunteer much about himself. By the end of the meal, the general impression was of a boy who was pleasant, reserved, and entirely unremarkable.

This impression would not survive the night.

## **The Wolf in Cabin Eleven**

Thomas woke to a sound he could not place.

It was low and rhythmic, a deep, slow pull of air followed by a longer, heavier release — breathing, but not human breathing. It had a roughness to it, a resonance that came from a chest larger and differently shaped than a boy’s. The cabin was dark. The oil lamps had been turned down to nothing, and only the faintest seam of grey light crept in above the curtain from the corridor.

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He lay still, listening. The breathing continued, steady and unhurried, from the berth directly below his own.

Thomas leaned over the edge and looked down.

A wolf was sleeping in Conall's bed.

It was large — far larger than Thomas would have expected to fit in the narrow berth — and it lay curled on its side with its heavy head resting on the pillow, its dark fur rising and falling with each deep breath. One of its hind legs twitched slightly, as though it were running in a dream. The woollen blanket was bunched beneath its body, and one massive paw hung over the edge of the mattress.

Thomas's body reacted before his mind caught up. He jerked backward, his elbow catching Pippin's cage on the wall hook. The cage swung, tipped, and fell to the floor with a tremendous metallic crash that detonated the silence of the cabin like a cannon shot.

Pippin exploded into a frenzy of screeching and wing-beating inside the rattling cage. Baldwin shot upright in his berth with a strangled gasp, his hand flying to his spectacles on the ledge. He jammed them onto his face, looked directly at the wolf — which had raised its head, ears flat, amber eyes wide and startled — and produced a sound that was not quite a word and not quite a scream but occupied the full territory between them.

The wolf blinked.

Then, with a fluidity that was deeply unsettling to witness at close range, the animal's shape began to change. The dark fur receded, the limbs lengthened and narrowed, the heavy skull reshaped itself, and within the span of a few seconds, Conall Quayle was sitting in the berth where the wolf had been — pale, dark-haired, entirely naked, and looking profoundly inconvenienced rather than embarrassed.

He grabbed the blanket and pulled it up to his chin.

"Sorry," he said, in the same quiet, rounded voice from the gangway. "I should have mentioned that."

Thomas was gripping the frame of his berth with both hands, his heart hammering so violently he could feel it in his teeth. Baldwin had not moved from his rigid, upright position and appeared to have temporarily lost the

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capacity for speech. At the foot of Baldwin's upper berth, Dolores lifted her head, surveyed the commotion from the safety of the high ground, and went back to sleep unbothered.

Pippin, however, had not lost anything. The young tawny owl was battering the inside of his cage with the righteous fury of a creature who had been woken by a crash, confronted with a predator, and was now expected to simply carry on. He screeched, flapped, threw himself against the bars, and then — with a deftness that suggested he had been practising — nudged the latch open with his beak and launched himself through the gap.

“Pippin —” Thomas lunged, but the owl was already gone, a blur of brown feathers banking hard through the curtained doorway and across the corridor.

Thomas dropped down from his berth and went after him, Baldwin close behind, both of them still barefoot and thoroughly rattled. They crossed the narrow passage and stopped at the entrance to the girls' cabin, where the curtain had already been pulled partially aside.

Inside, Celine was sitting up in her berth, still half-asleep, her hair loose around her shoulders. Pippin was perched on her left shoulder, pressed tightly against her neck, his feathers puffed out to twice their normal volume. He was making small, agitated sounds and showing no intention of moving. Celine, acting on what appeared to be pure instinct, had already raised a hand to stroke the top of his head, murmuring something soft in French.

Cecile was on her feet, fully alert, looking past Thomas into the corridor with the sharp, assessing gaze of someone who had heard a commotion and was already cataloguing its possible causes. Elara, in the upper berth across from Celine, had propped herself up on one elbow, her dark hair falling across a cheekbone still faintly smudged with last night's charcoal.

Cecile looked at Thomas. Then she looked at Thomas again, more carefully.

“Your hair,” she said.

Thomas stared at her. He reached up and touched his head. Beneath his fingers, the strands were soft, cool, and unmistakably pale — the bright, luminous platinum blond of his natural state, catching even the dim corridor light with an almost spectral glow. His skin, too, had drained to its true pallor, the white freckles visible across the bridge of his nose.

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He hadn't felt it happen. The shock of the wolf, the crash, the chase — he had simply forgotten to hold it.

He closed his eyes for a second, passed his hand through his hair, and felt the familiar, low pull of the change as the colour deepened back to brown, the warmth returning to his skin. When he opened his eyes, Cecile gave a small, satisfied nod, the matter handled.

But Elara had not looked away.

She was staring at the spot where his hair met his forehead, her expression entirely unlike Cecile's brisk discretion. Her lips were slightly parted, her eyes wide — not with alarm, but with the rapt, unguarded fascination of someone who had just watched pigment shift across a living surface. She looked at him the way she looked at the enchanted ceiling, or the swinging lamps in the hull, or the hare she had drawn at the bottom of her letter — as a living thing that revealed how the world actually worked, if you watched closely enough.

"That," Elara said softly, almost to herself, "was beautiful."

Thomas, still catching his breath and acutely aware that he was standing in a girls' doorway at an unreasonable hour with bare feet and disordered hair, did not have an immediate response to this.

Cecile turned her attention to Baldwin, who was leaning against the doorframe looking as though the morning had already used up his full capacity for surprise.

"What on earth was all that noise from your cabin?" she asked.

Thomas opened his mouth. "It's a long story."

Behind him, quiet footsteps approached. Conall appeared at his shoulder, fully dressed, his dark hair as unruly as ever, his expression carrying a faintly apologetic calm and in no particular hurry to explain himself.

"A very long story," Conall agreed.

## 8 Caledonia

The convoy entered the Clyde sometime after midnight. The change was immediate — the dark, open chop of the Irish Sea gave way to a flatter, quieter current, the water thickening with silt and turning the colour of peat beneath the hull.

Cassian Sterling was on the open deck, as he had been most nights. His astrolabe lay on the table before him alongside a roll of astronomical charts, and at his elbow a charmed quill copied his murmured observations onto a notebook with a soft, continuous scratching. The sky was extraordinary. A new moon meant no competing light, and the *Via Lactea* — the Milky Way — lay across the heavens in a vast, luminous band, its detail sharper and richer than he had seen it all voyage.

He estimated the time at roughly two in the morning, judging by the rotation of the Plough around Polaris — accurate, he reckoned, to within a quarter hour. He was noting this down when the colour of the sky changed.

It began as a faint, trembling curtain of green low on the northern horizon, so pale it might have been mistaken for cloud. Then it deepened, climbed, and a second band of violet rose beneath it, and the two moved together in long, slow waves that had no pattern he could identify.

### The Aurora Borealis

Cassian watched the Northern Lights with a fascination that was also, quietly, a frustration. Unlike the stars, whose positions could be calculated centuries into the future; unlike the planets, whose wandering paths obeyed elegant mathematics; unlike even the comets, which followed rough but discernible cycles — the aurora appeared to obey no schedule whatsoever. Aristotle's *Meteorologica* classified it among atmospheric phenomena: winds, clouds, rain. Cassian was not comfortable with that assertion. He had been born under this light, had grown up watching it from the fields outside Oxford, and

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the eleven-year cycle in the intensification of its appearances had been noted by those who studied the heavenly skies more carefully than Aristotle's heirs. Eleven years was too regular to be weather. He suspected an astronomical origin — something tied to the sun itself, perhaps — but it was a conjecture, and he could neither prove nor disprove it.

A heavy hand nudged his shoulder and Cassian jumped nearly a metre off his stool.

Headmaster Hepburn stood behind him, wrapped in a thick travelling cloak, his broad face lit from above by the shifting green light. He had, it turned out, left standing instructions with the ship's crew to wake him in the event of an aurora.

"Forgive me, Mr. Sterling," Hepburn said, smiling at the boy's alarm. He looked up at the sky with an expression of deep, professional satisfaction. "Do you know what the Northern Lights do to certain plants?"

Cassian did not.

Hepburn explained. White daisies, meadowsweet, heather, marigold, thistle, yarrow — when exposed to the light of an aurora during their growing season, their properties as potion ingredients are significantly altered. Enhanced, in many cases. "But the flowers must be collected preferably while the light is active or shortly after," Hepburn said. "Not the day after."

He looked at the boy. "Are you familiar with a broom, Mr. Sterling?"

"No, sir."

Hepburn chuckled. "Professor da Senna will be delighted to hear that." He drew a large, sturdy, well-used broom from behind the navigation table where he had propped it. "Not to worry. Mine will carry us both if we are careful. Mount behind me and hold on to my waist."

They flew low over the dark water, Cassian gripping the headmaster's cloak with both hands, the cold air rushing past and the aurora rippling above them. They landed in a field on a hillside not far from the river, the grass silver with dew.

Hepburn drew his wand. "*Lumos*." The tip bloomed with a clean, steady light. He gestured for Cassian to do the same.

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It took the boy three attempts. On the fourth, a wavering glow appeared at the tip of his bog oak wand — modest, slightly unsteady, but sufficient. Hepburn gave a satisfied nod and said nothing more about it.

Working by wandlight and aurora light together, Hepburn showed the boy the flowers — the white daisies first, their petals faintly luminous under the green sky, then the others. He instructed Cassian to collect as many of the daisies as he could find while he attended to the rest. They worked in near silence, the only sounds the rustle of their cloaks in the grass and the occasional hoot of a distant owl, the aurora shifting slowly above them.

They returned with the first daylight.

## Dumbarton

The *Siren* was already moored at Dumbarton, as far upriver as the convoy could manage. The Clyde above this point grew shallow and unpredictable, the riverbed rising with sand and gravel until there was simply not enough water beneath the keel for vessels of this draught. Glasgow lay further upstream, but the great hulks could not reach it.

From the deck, Dumbarton presented itself bluntly. The rock came first — a massive, dark volcanic plug rising sheer from the northern bank of the river, split into two peaks, its face scarred. A timber-and-stone fortress sat atop it, solid and functional, its walls following the contours of the rock with the resigned practicality of a structure built to survive weather and siege rather than to impress. Below the rock, a small settlement of low stone buildings and thatched roofs clustered near the water's edge, smoke rising from a handful of chimneys into the cold, still air. A few fishing boats were drawn up on the muddy bank. It was not Dublin. It did not try to be.

Cassian handed the collected herbs to Hepburn at the foot of the sterncastle stairs. The headmaster accepted the bundle with genuine warmth. “You have done me a great service, Mr. Sterling. These daisies will make a considerable difference to the school’s stores.” He paused, and added, with a slight twinkle, “You may find yourself called upon again in the future, should the lights oblige.”

They parted in separate directions — Hepburn up toward his quarters in the



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sterncastle, Cassian down toward the middle deck. He reached the main deck just in time to see a house-elf positioning the heavy gangway into place, the plank settling with a solid thud against the stone pier.

## The Gangway

Many students were already on the open deck. The morning was considerably colder than the days before — the first real bite of northern autumn — and the group had split accordingly. Some chose the open air, pulling their cloaks tight and eating under the clear, pale sun; others retreated to the warmth of the common room beneath the sterncastle.

Two boys came down the pier. They talked loudly and laughed freely, their conversation switching back and forth between two tongues with the effortless fluency of the truly bilingual — one moment a rapid, guttural speech, the next a lilting, musical language that carried across the water to the students on deck.

Elara O'Connell, sitting at a table close to the pier, had gone very still. When the boys spoke in Gaelic, she could follow them almost perfectly, the words close enough to her own Irish that meaning carried across with only the occasional gap. But when they switched to Inglis<sup>1</sup> she lost them entirely, the sounds as foreign as if they had begun speaking Greek.

The two boys reached the foot of the gangway and began hauling their heavy trunks up the steep incline. Halfway up, the house-elf who had placed the gangway made a small, silent gesture with one hand. The trunks shimmered and lifted, suddenly weightless, gliding up the remaining distance as though carried on still water.

At the top of the gangway, the captain stood to the right, greeting each new arrival with a handshake and a few words — the ordinary courtesies of embarkation. The two boys shook his hand in turn, the taller one offering a respectful nod, the other — a sandy-haired boy with an open, friendly face — saying something that made the captain give a brief, approving laugh. Then

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<sup>1</sup>Inglis — The Germanic language of the Scottish Lowlands, descended from Northumbrian Old English. In the fourteenth century its speakers still called it Inglis; the name Scottis (Scots) would not emerge until the late fifteenth century. It is entirely unrelated to Scottish Gaelic, the Celtic language of the Highlands, which shares its roots with Irish.

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he turned to the left, where the house-elf stood, and extended his hand.

“Thank you for the help with the trunk,” he said, simply and clearly.

The house-elf stared at the offered hand. The captain glanced sideways. The gesture did not go unnoticed by some students on the open deck. The elf reached out and took the boy’s hand, and for a brief moment, a genuine, unguarded smile broke across its small, lined face.

The boy turned back to his companion. *Always thank those who help you*, his mother liked to say.

Elara watched the whole exchange from her table. She said nothing, but she picked up her charcoal and opened her sketchbook.

A ship’s crew member strode to the centre of the deck, pressing his wand firmly against his throat. His voice, when he spoke, boomed across the ship with the amplified authority they had grown accustomed to, directing the stream of new passengers — students of all ages and several members of the Hogwarts staff — toward the forecastle, the sterncastle, or the lower decks according to their rank and year.

The two boys descended the narrow stairs toward the middle deck corridor. The taller one found his cabin first. He pushed the curtain aside and peered in. Two of the berths were empty but clearly slept in, the blankets thrown back and the pillows still dented. In a third — an upper berth — a tall, dark-skinned boy was sleeping soundly, his astrolabe resting on the folding table beside an open notebook. On the low ceiling above his head, just within arm’s reach, a small cluster of stars had been sketched in white chalk.

The sandy-haired boy continued on.

## **Black Fur**

He reached the doorway of Cabin 11, where Thomas, Baldwin, and Conall were sitting on their berths, talking.

He looked in, gave a broad, easy grin, and tossed his trunk under the remaining berth with a practised shove.

“Colum Douglas,” he said, straightening up and looking at them with open,

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cheerful curiosity. “Pleased to meet you.”

“Thomas Blackwood.”

“Baldwin Attewell.” Baldwin adjusted his spectacles from his berth, Dolores the white cat curled in her usual spot beside his pillow.

“Conall Quayle,” Conall said quietly, from the lower berth opposite.

Colum nodded at each name, filing them away. Then his eyes moved around the small space — the berths, the hooks, the arrangement of the blankets — with the quick, cataloguing gaze of someone accustomed to reading a room.

“Right,” he said, his tone still cheerful but newly precise. “Who’s the Animagus?”

There was a brief, shared silence.

Conall raised his hand, his expression carrying the same faintly resigned calm he had shown after the incident. “That would be me.”

Baldwin stared at the newcomer. “How did you — we only found out ourselves two nights ago.”

The boy pointed at Conall’s berth. “The sheets are only rumped in a small circle in the middle, roughly the size of a curled-up animal, not a person stretched out. There’s black fur on the pillow and a few strands on the blanket.” He glanced at Dolores on the pillow, then up at Pippin on his hook. “You’ve got a white cat and a tawny owl. Neither of those leaves black fur.” He looked back at Conall and shrugged. “So. Animagus.”

Thomas exchanged a look with Baldwin. Conall, for his part, gave a small, almost appreciative nod.

Colum clapped his hands together. “Now — when’s breakfast? I’m starving.”

“We were just heading up,” Thomas said, getting to his feet. “The common room is lovely, but there’s nothing quite like the morning sun on your face — even if it’s a bit cold.”

“Cold is fine,” Colum said, already moving toward the door. “I’m an Edinburgher.”

## 9 The Loch

The loch appeared before the sun did.

Thomas was on the open deck when the *Siren* passed through the mouth — a narrow gap between two dark headlands that opened, without warning, onto a vast body of still, black water. The mountains rose directly from the shoreline on both sides, their flanks steep and treeless near the summits, covered lower down in a dense, dark mantle of oak, birch, and Scots pine that came right to the water's edge. The reflections were so precise in the stillness that the boundary between mountain and water dissolved entirely, the loch becoming a second sky turned on its axis.

There was no wind. The air was cold and tasted of peat and wet stone and the salt of the Atlantic layered beneath peat and wet pine. Mist lay in long, pale bands across the surface, thinning as the convoy moved through it but never quite disappearing, clinging to the hollows between the hills like cloth caught on branches. The silence was immense — not the silence of emptiness, but the loaded, attentive silence of a place that was listening.

Ahead, the *Mermaid* led the procession, her dark hull cutting a clean line through water that had the colour and opacity of strong tea. Behind her, the *Ceasg* followed at a measured distance, and behind the *Siren* came the low, oar-bristled shape of the *Merrow*, and finally the *Melusine*, bringing up the rear. The five ships moved in single file, their sails furled, gliding forward under the quiet propulsion of the crew's spellwork. The wake of each vessel spread outward in long, symmetrical chevrons that reached the banks and came back as faint, lapping echoes — the only sound the mountains returned.

The loch stretched westward for miles, the mountains crowding closer on each side as the water deepened. In places, the slopes were so sheer that they seemed to lean over the ships, their upper ridges lost in low cloud. Waterfalls — thin, white threads against the dark rock — dropped from heights that were difficult to judge in the flat, pre-dawn light. A heron, startled by the *Mermaid*'s passage, lifted from the shallows with heavy, deliberate wingbeats and crossed to the opposite bank, where it landed and stood motionless,

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watching the convoy pass with the professional indifference of a creature that had seen ships before and had not been impressed.

The sun found the upper ridges first. A line of pale gold crept down the eastern slopes, catching the wet rock and the highest branches of the pines, while the water below remained in shadow. The effect was of two separate worlds stacked one above the other — the lit peaks above, sharp and immediate, and the dark, mirrored loch below, still holding the night.

As the convoy pressed deeper, the mountains converged. The loch narrowed steadily, the banks drawing together until the passage ahead resembled a strait — a bottleneck of dark water squeezed between two steep, forested promontories. The *Mermaid* slowed, and behind her, each ship followed suit, the distance between them compressing as the convoy came to a gradual, coordinated halt in the widening just before the narrows.

## The Port

On the foredeck of the *Mermaid*, a figure moved. Thomas could make him out only in outline at this distance — a man, wand raised, his arm tracing broad, sweeping arcs through the morning air. There was no sound, no incantation that carried across the water. But the effort was visible in the man's body: the wide stance, the exaggerated extension of each gesture, the slight backward lean of a wizard bracing against the weight of his own spell.

For a moment, nothing happened.

Then the south shore began to change.

Scattered stones half-submerged along the waterline — the kind that had sat there for decades, covered in dark weed and entirely unremarkable — shifted. The movement was slow at first, almost geological, the stones grinding sideways through the shallows with a deep, resonant sound that travelled across the still water. A timber beam, waterlogged and grey, rolled lazily to the surface and drifted toward the stones with a purpose that driftwood does not ordinarily possess.

The pace quickened. Rocks rose from the loch bed, streaming water, and slid toward each other with the grinding, heavy inevitability of a lock mechanism engaging. Timber beams — half-buried in the bank or floating loose in the

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shallows — surfaced and rotated into position, slotting lengthways between the stones with a series of deep, satisfying thuds. More stones followed, stacking and interlocking, the structure extending outward from the shore in a broad, straight line, reaching for the deeper water where the hulls could sit.

Within minutes, a solid stone-and-timber pier jutted from the wild shoreline, wide enough for two carts abreast, its surface flat and dark with the wet of its own assembly. At the shore end, the stones had formed a ramp that merged with the bank as though it had always been there.

Thomas watched from the rail, his hands resting on the cold wood.

The brilliance of it was not the magic. The brilliance was the material. A Muggle shepherd looking down from the ridge would have seen, minutes ago, rocks and driftwood — the most ordinary debris in the Highlands. Stones in the shallows, timber on the bank. There was nothing to conceal because there was nothing to notice. And when the ships departed and the last student was gone, the spell would release, and the pier would simply come apart — the stones settling back into the water, the beams drifting to the banks, the loch returning to its ancient, undisturbed composure. By the following morning, no trace.

## *Wingardium Leviosa*

By the time the *Siren* was moored — third in line along the temporary pier, her hull resting against the stone with a low, steady groan — the students had already returned from breakfast. The meal had been called early, before the sunrise, and many of the younger faces carried the evidence of a short night: half-closed eyes, slow movements, the particular unfocused look of children woken before their bodies had agreed to it.

A ship's mate strode through the lower decks, wand pressed to his throat. "All students are to return to their cabins and finish preparing their belongings. Those who have not yet packed — and there appear to be a great many of you — should do so now."

In the middle deck corridor, the familiar, narrow space filled rapidly with trunks, cages, and the controlled chaos of departure. Cecile stood outside her cabin door, wand raised, and spoke clearly. "*Wingardium Leviosa.*" Her

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heavy trunk lifted from the floor and hung in the air, perfectly steady, the spell cast with the easy precision of a girl who had drilled the incantation so many times that the words and the wand movement had become a single, indivisible act. She said the words louder than necessary, her eyes on Celine — instruction disguised as demonstration.

Celine watched her sister's grip, the angle of the wand, the stress on the second syllable. She raised her own wand, repeated the incantation once, and her trunk rose cleanly from the floor on the first attempt.

Cecile looked at it, then at her sister, and said nothing — but the brief, quiet satisfaction on her face said a good deal.

Further down the corridor, Baldwin required three or four attempts before his trunk obeyed, the progression visible in real time: the first try produced a faint wobble, the second lifted one corner, the third raised the trunk a full foot before it dropped. On the fourth, it held. He had the manner of a boy who had read extensively about the theory of levitation but whose wrist had not yet received the message. Conall and Colum managed shortly after, following corrections from Cecile — a slight adjustment to the arc of the movement, a firmer emphasis on the vowel — until both trunks floated with reasonable stability.

Nearly everyone in the corridor had produced the spell by the time the general movement toward the stairs began. Thomas had not.

He stood with his wand extended, his jaw tight, repeating the incantation with a precision that was technically correct and practically useless. The trunk sat on the floor with the stubborn indifference of an object that had no intention of cooperating. He tried again. The tip of his wand produced a brief, silvery flicker that died immediately, like a candle touched by a draught.

The corridor was emptying. Celine glanced back at him, hesitating at the foot of the stairs.

Thomas lowered his wand, frustrated and apprehensive. He reached up with his left hand and caught a few strands of his hair between his fingers. As he pulled them free, the colour bled out of each strand almost instantly, the rich brown fading to the luminous, pale gold — as though the hair, once separated from him, could no longer hold the disguise. He looped the pale strands across his knuckles. Without a word — without a sound — the trunk and Pippin's cage lifted from the floor and hung motionless in the air,

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perfectly obedient.

The words of caution from the tall, long-haired wizard in Elias Robert Fox's office resonated in his mind. *Forget the instinct, lad. Master the wand.*

He tucked the wand into his belt and guided the trunk toward the stairs.

## Solid Ground

The open deck was bright with early morning light, the sun now fully above the eastern ridge, throwing long shadows across the planking. The air was sharp and clean — the particular cold of a Highland autumn morning, carrying the scent of pine resin and peat smoke from a source too distant to see. After days of open ocean, the loch's salt was different — sheltered, still, tempered by the peat runoff from the hills and the resin of the pines crowding the banks.

Students filed across the deck toward the gangway, their trunks and cages floating or dragged or carried behind them in varying states of magical competence. The pier below was already busy — mates from the *Mermaid* and the *Ceasg* directing luggage and supplies with brisk, practised efficiency.

At the top of the gangway, the captain stood to the right, shaking each hand in turn with the measured courtesy of a man who had done this at every port and would do it again at the next. To the left, the house-elf who had placed the gangway stood at his post. As the students descended, most of them greeted both — following the example Colum had set at Dumbarton, a gesture that had quietly become habit over the course of the voyage. The elf shook each offered hand with both of his own, his large eyes bright, his happiness palpable.

Thomas reached the top of the gangway, shook the captain's hand, and turned left. The elf's grip was warm and surprisingly firm. He bowed twice, quickly.

He walked down the gangway onto the pier. The stone was solid beneath his feet — solid, and cold, and unmistakably Scottish. Behind him, the *Siren* rocked gently against her mooring, already lighter without the weight of her passengers.



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His first step on the pier felt uncertain, and his second felt worse. The ground was perfectly still, but his body refused to believe it. After so many days aboard the *Siren*, his legs had grown so accustomed to compensating for the roll of the waves that they continued doing it now, adjusting for a movement that was no longer there. The pier seemed to sway gently beneath him — a slow, lazy tilt to one side, then the other — and he had to stop and widen his stance just to keep his balance. He stood still, waiting for the sensation to pass. It didn't. Around him, other students were having the same trouble; Baldwin grabbed Thomas's arm to steady himself, and further along the pier Philippa was walking with the exaggerated care of a person crossing ice.

Ahead, the mountains rose into clear sky, and the road to Hogwarts lay beyond them.

## 10 The Caravan

A long caravan of carriages came down the narrow track from the hills, rounding the last bend in single file before drawing to a halt along the length of the pier. Thomas counted them from the rail — more than thirty, each one dark-bodied and well-built, with large windows and iron-rimmed wheels. They had no horses. The shafts at the front of each carriage extended forward into empty air, and yet the carriages had arrived under their own momentum, their wheels turning with purpose, the spacing between them oddly generous — far wider gaps than the arrangement seemed to require.

Sitting on the driver's bench of the first carriage, reins held loosely in both hands despite the apparent absence of anything to rein, was a remarkably small witch. She had short, fiery red hair — a brighter, more untamed shade than his mother's, Thomas thought — and even from a distance, her frame was striking in its compactness. She could not have been much more than one hundred and fifty centimetres tall. She wore a plain linen shirt tucked into trousers that had been folded twice at the hems and no shoes, her feet bare, her toes curled over the edge of the footboard as though the contact with the wood was a preference rather than an oversight.

The caravan drew to a halt along the length of the pier, the carriages settling with a series of soft creaks. The small witch dropped from her bench with the easy agility of a person far more comfortable outdoors than in and crossed the stone pier toward Headmaster Hepburn in a rapid, light-footed walk that was almost a run. She threw her arms around him. It was not a formal greeting; it was the embrace of a colleague who was also a dear friend, warm and unhesitating, and Hepburn returned it with a booming laugh that carried across the water.

"That's Professor Saoirse Millan," said a voice at his shoulder.

Thomas started slightly. He hadn't heard the French sisters approach — Celine a step behind her sister, both carrying their things.

"She teaches Care of Magical Creatures," Cecile continued. "She's quite good. And a bit... peculiar."

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Thomas looked back at the professor. Hepburn and Millan had begun walking together along the line of carriages, talking in low voices. The language was not Latin, and it was not English. Thomas could not place it — it had a lilting, rounded quality, the vowels open and musical. He caught only fragments, a word here and there. One word he was almost certain he heard was *selkies*. The effect on Millan was immediate. She stopped mid-stride, turned fully to face the Headmaster, and for a brief instant the easy, kinetic energy of her manner was replaced by an absolute, focused stillness — the attention of a naturalist who has just been told about a sighting. Then she was moving again, matching Hepburn’s longer stride with two of her own, firing rapid questions.

They reached the middle of the caravan. Hepburn drew his wand and pressed the tip firmly against his throat. When he spoke, his voice carried across the entire pier with the amplified clarity the students had grown accustomed to aboard the ships.

“All students are to board the carriages in groups of six. Take your cats, owl cages, and toad boxes with you inside the carriage. Leave your trunks and all other luggage on the ground in front of the carriages — the staff will secure them on the roof. Do not attempt to load them yourselves. Don’t make a mess of it.”

The last line drew a few laughs. Hepburn removed his wand from his throat and nodded to Millan. What followed silenced the laughter.

Millan drew her wand — a short, light piece of wood with a handle of polished antler, into which the delicate, stylised forms of various creatures had been engraved with fine, loving care — and raised it. Without a word — not a syllable, not a murmur — she began to move. Four carriages’ worth of trunks rose simultaneously, lifting in neat, coordinated rows and drifting through the air to settle atop their respective carriages. The precision was startling — each trunk rotated to fit flush against its neighbour, settling onto the carriage roofs with barely a sound. As the luggage found its place, leather straps zipped across the trunks lengthways, cinching tight with a series of sharp, satisfying clicks, followed immediately by a second set running perpendicular to the first, locking everything down in a firm, criss-crossed lattice. The whole operation took less than two minutes.

Cecile, who had spent the better part of a morning drilling *Wingardium Leviosa* with the younger students on the ship and understood exactly what

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simultaneous levitation across four separate targets actually required, said nothing. But she exhaled slowly through her nose in a display of admiration.

With the last trunk secured, Millan apparated. There was no dramatic gesture, no swirl of a cloak — one moment she was on the pier, the next she was on the driver's bench of the first carriage, settling back into her seat with her bare feet up on the footboard as though she had never left it.

## The Land of Fire and Ice

Thomas, Colum, Cecile, and Celine climbed into the fourth carriage.

The interior was a surprise. After the utilitarian simplicity of the *Siren's* cabins — the narrow berths, the folding table, the heavy curtain for a door — the carriage felt almost like entering a study. The space was compact but meticulously built. The walls were panelled in dark oak, joined with a cabinet-maker's precision, every seam flush, every corner reinforced with small brass fittings that caught the light. Two long benches faced each other across the width of the carriage, upholstered in a deep, wine-coloured wool, firm rather than soft, the kind of upholstery that would last decades without losing its shape. A narrow shelf ran along one side beneath the windows, and above it hung two small brass lamps in gimballed brackets, unlit but clean and well-maintained. The ceiling was low, vaulted slightly, and lined with the same dark oak as the walls. It was not luxurious. It was craftsmanship — the work of a builder who believed that function and beauty were the same thing.

The windows were large, far larger than those on the ship, offering an unobstructed view of the world outside. Colum took the rear-facing bench on the left; Cecile sat opposite him, adjusting her robes with her usual brisk efficiency. Celine settled beside her sister, setting Pippin's cage on the floor between her feet. The cage was empty. Pippin himself was already on her lap, settled comfortably against her stomach with his eyes half-closed, leaning into the slow, methodical head-scratches she was administering with one hand. The young owl had, it appeared, traded his loyalties for a reliable supply of affection and the occasional pastry crumb, and showed no sign of renegotiating the terms. Thomas looked at the scene with an expression of theatrical offence that fooled no one, least of all himself — the corner of his mouth kept betraying him. Thomas took the remaining rear-facing seat

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beside Colum and set his things down.

Two seats remained.

A few minutes later, the carriage door opened again, and two more students climbed in. First years, by the look of them, but not from the *Siren* — Thomas was certain of it. He had spent enough days in the ship's corridors and common room to recognise every face aboard, and these two were new.

The girl entered first. She was pale — strikingly so, her skin almost translucent, carrying the particular quality of a person raised in a climate where the sun did not insist. Her hair was platinum blonde, cut to the shoulders, straight and fine, held back from her face by a single practical braid along one temple. Her eyes were a sharp, cold blue that took in the carriage and its occupants in a single, unhurried sweep.

Thomas looked at her and felt a quiet, private jolt of recognition. The paleness, the platinum hair — the colouring was close enough to his own natural state to produce an odd, uncomfortable echo. On her, the combination was striking, it looked right. The severity of it suited her angular features and gave her an air of composed intensity that was entirely her own. It fit her beautifully. Thomas ran a hand through his dark brown hair — an unconscious gesture — and looked away.

The boy who followed her was her visual opposite in almost every regard. He was tall — unusually so for eleven — and powerfully built, with dark skin and a strong, defined jawline. He carried himself with a quiet confidence that was not arrogance but simple self-possession, the ease of a boy comfortable in his own frame. His eyes moved around the carriage with an appreciative attention to detail — the brass fittings, the oak panelling, the quality of the joinery — that suggested a person who noticed how things were made.

They spoke to each other as they settled in with the relaxed familiarity of people who had shared close quarters for an extended period — many days inside a small ship, most likely. Their Latin was fluent but distinctly accented — his carrying a warm, rounded quality, hers clipped and precise, the vowels shorter, the consonants harder. Neither accent was British.

The boy spoke first, addressing the carriage with a natural warmth.

“Efe Adeyemi,” he said, extending a broad hand toward Thomas, the nearest to him. His grip was firm and brief. He worked around the carriage — Colum,

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Cecile, Celine — greeting each with an easy directness.

“Astrid Ragnarsdóttir,” the girl said. Her voice was lower than Thomas had expected, steady and measured. She nodded to the group rather than offering a hand, but the gesture carried its own courtesy.

Celine, whose curiosity operated on a schedule that did not wait for appropriate moments, tilted her head at the name. “Ragnarsdóttir,” she repeated carefully, her French accent wrapping around the unfamiliar syllables. “Where is your family name from?”

“It isn’t a family name,” Astrid said. She did not correct Celine with any sharpness — it was simply a fact that needed stating. “It’s a patronymic. It means daughter of Ragnar. My father is Ragnar, so I am Ragnarsdóttir. It’s the custom in Iceland.”

“The land of fire and ice,” completed Efe.

Celine absorbed this with visible fascination, the kind that would almost certainly produce follow-up questions at a later and less convenient time.

She turned to Efe. “And where are you from?”

“Southwark,” Efe said.

There was a beat. Then Efe grinned — a warm, broad expression that confirmed the joke before anyone had to ask. Colum exhaled a short laugh. Efe’s grin widened before he settled into a more measured tone.

“My family moved to London when I was six. From the Kingdom of Edo, in the west of Africa. We were brought to England by a merchant of rare magical items, Mr. Fox.” He said the name with a quiet, settled warmth, the way you speak of a person who had earned a permanent place in your family’s story. “He offered my father a position, and my father accepted.”

Thomas said nothing, but the name landed with a sharp, private clarity. Mr. Fox. Elias Robbert Fox — the crooked man in the room behind the red door, leaning on his table, his body scarred and his smile pulling against the damage. The house-elves in their white mantles. The leather purse of coins. And standing guard at the entrance, the dark-skinned wizard with the magnificent African blackwood wand carved with minute figurines and inlaid with bronze — Efe’s father, Thomas now realised. He filed the connection away without comment.

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## The Glen

The carriage lurched gently and began to move.

For the first stretch of the journey, the conversation continued — the easy, exploratory talk of people recently introduced, establishing the basic coordinates of who they were and where they had come from. Efe and Astrid, it emerged, had traveled together aboard the *Melusine*, the rearmost ship of the convoy, and their rapport had the quality of a friendship forged in confined quarters over shared meals and long days at sea.

But gradually, as the road climbed and the landscape opened around them, the talk thinned and stopped. Not because anything had gone wrong between them, but because the windows demanded it.

The country on either side of the narrow track was unlike anything Celine had ever seen. The road ran high along the shoulder of a glen, following the curve of a long, dark loch that lay far below them, its surface black and perfectly still, reflecting the mountains on its far shore with such fidelity that the reflection was indistinguishable from the thing itself. The hills rose steeply from the water's edge — not the gentle, rolling green of southern England but harder, their flanks covered in a dense, dark pelt of oak and birch and Scots pine that gave way, higher up, to bare rock and heather the colour of rusted iron.

Where the glen narrowed, the mountains pressed close, their ridges running parallel to the road like the walls of a vast, roofless corridor. Waterfalls cut white threads down the dark rock faces, some dropping from heights so great that the water dissolved into mist before it reached the bottom. In the hollows between the peaks, pockets of low cloud sat motionless, as though the mountains had caught them and were keeping them.

The light was different here. Far above the trapped mist in the hollows, the higher cloud cover was in constant motion, and the sun found its way through the gaps in long, horizontal shafts, illuminating single stretches of hillside in vivid, burning gold while the land on either side remained in deep shadow. The effect shifted constantly — a ridge would blaze for a moment and then darken, and the light would find a new slope, a new angle, a new arrangement of colour that lasted only seconds before changing again.

Thomas leaned against the window frame and watched it pass. He had no

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memory of this place, not exactly. He had been too young when they left for London to carry detailed pictures in his mind — no specific ridge, no particular tree, no view that he could point to and say *I remember that*. But the impression was there, deep and inarticulate: the quality of the air, the scale of the silence, the way the land felt — not welcoming, not hostile, but present, aware of you in the way that very old places are. It settled over him like a scent he could not name but knew he had encountered before.

He wished the caravan moved more slowly. The beauty outside the windows deserved more time than the road was giving it.

Then Cecile, who had been sitting facing forward, straightened in her seat.

“There,” she said quietly.

Thomas turned.

Very far ahead, still small with distance but already unmistakable against the sky, the castle sat upon a high, dark outcrop of rock above the shore of a vast lake. It rose from the stone as though it had been grown from it rather than built upon it, a sprawling mass of towers and turrets and high curtain walls, the stonework catching the afternoon light along its western face. The towers were too many to count at this distance — some slender and impossibly tall, others broad and fortified, their crenellated battlements sharp against the grey sky. Windows glinted across the façade in scattered points of reflected light, hundreds of them, as though the castle were watching the valley below with a thousand bright, quiet eyes.

Thomas, Colum and Astrid rose from their seats and moved to the front-facing bench, pressing in beside Cecile, Celine and Efe so that all six of them could watch the castle through the back window as the caravan continued its approach. The bench was not built for six, and the arrangement required a degree of compression that would have been uncomfortable if anyone had been thinking about comfort. No one was.

Thomas looked at Celine. She had gone entirely still. Her lips were slightly parted, her eyes wide, the half-eaten apple in her hand forgotten. She was not trying to analyse what she was seeing or compare it to anything she had known. She was simply receiving it — the whole vast, impossible, luminous fact of the place — with the unguarded awe of a girl who had traveled a very long way from a bakery in Lyon and was now looking at the castle where her life was about to change. She did not say a word. She didn’t need to.



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## The Painted Posts

As the road descended from the high glen and the distance to the castle closed, the landscape on both sides of the narrow track shifted. The wild, uninhabited country of the mountains gave way — gradually and then all at once — to the marks of habitation.

On the left, set back from the road at the bottom of a gentle slope, the village of Hogsmeade — the only all-wizarding village in the British Isles — came into view.

It was not large, but it was deeply, unmistakably itself. The buildings were a crooked, comfortable collection of stone and timber, their roofs thatched or slated in dark grey, their chimneys — many of them slightly off-vertical, as though the houses had settled into the field over the years and brought their chimneys with them — trailing thin threads of smoke in colours that no Muggle fire would produce. The lanes between the buildings were narrow and winding, following no grid, respecting no surveyor's line, running instead along paths that had been worn into the ground by feet and hooves and the habits of many generations. Shop fronts faced the main street, their signs hand-painted and slightly crooked, and through the carriage window Thomas caught glimpses of warm light behind thick glass, the shapes of people moving inside.

Thomas looked at it. The view unlocked nothing specific — no street, no doorway, no face. But it unlocked a feeling: a low, formless warmth that sat behind his ribs, the residue of a place that had once been home to a very small boy and a family that was still whole. He did not try to sharpen it into a memory. He let it sit where it was.

On the right, the mountains fell away entirely, opening onto a broad, flat field that stretched toward a dark lake at its far edge. The field was vast — far larger than any sporting ground Thomas had seen in London — and it was occupied.

At the near end stood a large oval arena built entirely of heavy timber, its structure open to the sky. Two grandstands ran along the longer sides, their seats rising in steep tiers. Beyond the arena, scattered across the field at irregular intervals, stood smaller installations — targeting ranges, jousting tracks, and obstacle courses of various configurations. But what dominated

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the field entirely were the posts.

A series of massive wooden columns — enormously tall, painted in vivid, saturated colours that stood out against the green and grey of the landscape — rose from the ground at varying heights and distances from one another. They were everywhere. They ran the full length of the field, from the shallows of the lake at the far edge, where their reflections doubled their height in the still water, through the open ground past the arena, and all the way to the near side, close enough to the road that Thomas could see the grain of the painted timber. The winding course they described snaked between the other installations, around natural features of the terrain, and back again in long, sweeping loops. It was, unmistakably, a racing circuit.

“That’s broom racing,” Cecile said, leaning forward to look past Celine. “Course racing, specifically. And that —”

A figure had launched from the far end of the circuit. It moved with a speed of an arrow loosed from a longbow, a sheer velocity that seemed to ignore the air rather than negotiate with it. The figure reached the first post, banked hard, and came around it in a turn so tight that the angle defied sense.

“— must be professor da Senna,” Cecile finished.

The rider flew closer, contouring a post near the road, and Thomas watched carefully. He did not slow as the turn approached. If anything, the broom accelerated on the exit of the turn, the rider leaning into the curve and then surging out of it with a burst of speed that left a faint, visible disturbance in the air behind it. Then he was gone, banking behind a distant post, and the circuit was empty again, and the field was quiet.

## The Winged Boars

The caravan slowed.

Ahead, the road narrowed to a single track and approached a tall iron gate set between stone pillars. Atop each pillar sat a carved stone boar, winged and rearing, worn smooth by weather but still proud. The gate itself was elegant — wrought iron, ornamented rather than fortified. It looked, Thomas thought, considerably more fragile than the entrance to a castle of this size ought to be. But then, the real protections of a place like this would not be

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the kind you could see.

Professor Millan dropped from the driver's bench of the first carriage and walked toward the gate. She drew her wand, raised it, and began. The first movements were small — quick, precise flicks directed at specific points along the gate's framework, as though she were unlocking a sequence of invisible catches. Then the gestures widened, the wand tracing broader arcs through the air, her arm extending fully. She did not speak. Not a word, not a whisper. The spells were entirely silent, and yet their effect was immediate: a translucent barrier shimmered into visibility across the full span of the gateway, hanging in the air like a sheet of still water suspended on its edge. It held for a moment — long enough for Thomas to see the faint distortions it produced in the landscape behind it, the trees and the sky bending slightly as though seen through old glass — and then it parted, drew aside, and folded into nothing.

With a final, slow flick, the iron gate began to swing open. It moved with a ponderous weight that contradicted its appearance entirely, as though the metal were ten times heavier than it looked, the hinges resisting and then yielding with a deep, resonant groan that Thomas felt in his chest.

The first carriage rolled through. Then the second. One by one, the carriages passed between the stone pillars and their winged boars, moving slowly, the track beyond the gate curving gently upward through a corridor of tall trees.

When the last carriage had passed through, Millan closed the gate. It swung shut with the same heavy, slow authority with which it had opened. She raised her wand again, and the sequence reversed — the translucent barrier reappeared, shimmering into existence across the gateway, holding for a moment, and then fading until the gate looked exactly as it had before: elegant, ornamental, and entirely insufficient for the task of protecting what lay beyond it.

Millan tucked her wand into her belt and walked back along the line of carriages toward the front, her bare feet silent on the packed earth of the road. She climbed back onto her bench, settled into her seat, and the caravan moved forward through the final stretch of tree-lined road toward the castle.

The towers filled the sky above the canopy now, close enough to see the individual stones of the walls and the shapes of the gargoyles perched along the parapets. The sound of the carriage wheels changed as the track gave

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way to paved stone. The trees thinned, and then opened, and then fell away entirely, and Hogwarts castle rose before them in its full, staggering immensity — closer, more real and more overwhelming than it had been from any distance.

The caravan slowed to a walk, and then stopped.

# 11      The Castle

Thomas stepped down from the carriage onto flagstone. The ground was old and uneven, worn smooth in places by centuries of feet, and after the long, swaying hours on the road it felt impossibly, almost aggressively solid beneath his boots. Colum dropped down beside him, steadied himself with a hand on the carriage frame, and looked up.

The castle filled the sky.

From the glen, it had been a silhouette — towers and turrets and high curtain walls, impressive but reducible to a shape against the clouds. Here, at the foot of its own rock, the scale defeated the eye. The walls rose sheer from the stone outcrop, their surfaces a patchwork of grey and darker grey where rain and lichen had worked the masonry over centuries. Buttresses the size of houses braced the lower courses. Above them, towers climbed at heights that should not have held, their windows catching the afternoon light in scattered points that moved as the clouds shifted. Gargoyles crouched along the parapets — dozens of them, each different, each watching a different quarter of the sky with the fixed, humourless attention of sentries who had not been relieved in four hundred years.

A broad stone stairwell led from the courtyard to the main entrance — a pair of heavy oak doors, iron-studded and tall enough to admit a mounted knight, set deep within a pointed arch. Students were already climbing the steps, their trunks floating or dragged behind them.

Cecile and Celine emerged from the carriage behind them. Celine stood for a moment, her head tilted back, her lips slightly parted, taking in the full vertical reach of the nearest tower. Cecile placed a hand on her sister's shoulder — gently, briefly — and then began walking toward the stairs with the purposeful stride, returning to a place she knew.

Thomas did not follow immediately. He turned instead to take in the broader scene.

The courtyard was alive with arrival. From the direction of Hogsmeade,

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a steady procession of figures descended through the air on broomsticks — older students, by the look of them, their landings practised and unhurried, their trunks roped to their backs or levitated alongside. A few staff members arrived the same way, distinguishable by their heavier robes and the particular, unhurried authority with which they touched down. One witch landed on the far side of the courtyard carrying what appeared to be an enormous potted shrub under one arm and a stack of leather-bound folios under the other, dismounting with the ease of someone stepping off a low wall.

It was a scene of controlled chaos — the ordinary, annual machinery of a school reassembling itself after a summer apart.

Then his eye found the patch of grass.

It lay perhaps twenty metres from the foot of the stairwell, a level stretch of turf running along the base of the castle's eastern wall. Two figures occupied it, and the space around them was conspicuously empty — not because anyone had been told to keep their distance, but because the nature of what was happening there made distance the only sensible response.

A man and a girl were training in combat — defence techniques, by the look of it.

The man was tall and lean, his stance low, his weight distributed with the particular economy of someone who had spent years learning exactly how much movement was necessary and how much was waste. He was in his late forties, perhaps older — his dark hair, cut short, was already heavily threaded with white, and the lines on his face carried the deep-set quality of marks that had been earned rather than aged into. His eyes were watchful in a way that went beyond attention; they moved with the constant, restless sweep of a man who had trained himself never to stop scanning.

The girl opposite him was slight, her long dark hair pulled back into a single, practical braid that hung between her shoulder blades. Her skin was very pale; freckles dusted the bridge of her nose and her cheekbones. She had the most piercing blue eyes — not dark or sharp, but soft and luminous, hazy like the blue of a summer sky — with pinpoint pupils.

She held her wand with an ease that did not belong to her age.

Both wore padded gambesons — the quilted, close-fitting garments that Thomas recognised from illustrations in his Defence texts, designed to absorb

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the residual force of deflected spells. The man's was a worn, creamy white with green edging along the front opening, collar, and cuffs, and a small Slytherin crest embroidered over the left breast. The garment showed the unmistakable signs of extensive use and many repairs — patches of newer fabric where old burns had been cut away, a long seam along the ribs that had been resewn with heavier thread. It was the gambeson of a man who trained often and kept what worked — but the depth of its wear suggested it had seen more than mere training.

The girl's was black with orange edging, cut tighter to her smaller frame, and conspicuously newer — the colours still vivid, the stitching clean, the padding still full. It bore no house emblem.

The man opened.

*“Stupefy.”*

The red bolt crossed the distance between them in less than a heartbeat. The girl sidestepped it — not by a foot, not by a generous margin, but by a hand's width, the spell passing close enough to disturb the loose strands of hair at her temple. The economy of it was striking. She had moved exactly as much as she needed to and not a fraction more, as though she had measured the trajectory of the spell in the instant it left his wand and calculated the minimum displacement required to survive it.

She returned fire before the red light had finished dying in the air behind her.

*“Expelliarmus.”*

He blocked it. His shielding spell was quick and textbook — a sharp, practised flick that sent her disarming charm scattering into white fragments. She blocked his counter with the same clean efficiency. He sent another. She deflected, adjusted her footing, and fired back.

The exchange accelerated.

The spells began to overlap — red, white, red — each one arriving faster than the last, the interval between cast and counter compressing until the individual incantations blurred into a continuous, percussive rhythm. The cracks of impact echoed off the stone wall behind them, sharp and flat, like the reports of a whip. Thomas could see the effort in both of them now —

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the man's jaw set, his wand arm moving in tight, controlled arcs; the girl's braid swinging with each pivot, her feet adjusting on the grass with small, quick steps that kept her balanced and mobile.

It was a lesson — fast, fluid, but not dangerous. A drill between two people who had done this many, many times before.

Then the man sent a disarming charm that was harder than the rest, maybe a bit too hard, he thought to himself.

Thomas saw it in the man's shoulder — the slight, additional rotation, the extra half-inch of extension in the follow-through that loaded more force into the spell than any of the previous exchanges. It crossed the grass like a thrown stone. The girl's shield caught it — her wand was already in position, the defence technically sound — but the force of the impact travelled through the charm and into her arm, pushing her back half a step. Her rear foot slid on the wet grass. Her balance broke.

Instead of recovering, she slashed her wand in a sharp, vicious diagonal and spoke two words.

*“Sanguinem Scinde.”*

The man's wand hand opened from within. The skin parted in a clean, bright line across the palm — not from impact, not from any force that had struck him from outside, but as though the blood itself had chosen to leave. The wound was precise and bloodless for a single, suspended instant before the red welled up and ran freely between his fingers. His wand fell to the grass.

The girl lowered her wand and stood still, breathing hard.

The courtyard had gone very quiet.

The man bent, retrieved his wand with his uninjured hand, and pressed its tip against the split palm. The skin drew together and closed cleanly, the blood ceasing as though a tap had been shut. He flexed his fingers once, then again, testing the repair with the methodical patience of a man who had mended himself many times before and understood the importance of checking the work. He did not look up while he did this.

When he spoke, his voice carried across the field with a clarity that made several students near the carriages go still.



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“Laura.”

He was still looking at his hand, turning it over, examining the line where the wound had been. But his voice had a tightness to it that had nothing to do with the injury.

“Good wizards are above certain spells.” He looked up. His eyes locked onto hers, and his face held a frustration and an anger that Thomas recognised — the kind that can only come from someone who deeply loves and cares. “The best wizards have no need for such spells. None! Do you hear me?”

For a moment, Thomas thought she might argue. Her jaw tightened, and her chin lifted a fraction — the smallest, most instinctive gesture of defiance. Then something in his expression reached her, or something in her own chest answered it, and the defiance collapsed. Her lip pressed tight against the upper, and her eyes filled.

The man crossed the distance between them in three strides, pulled her into his arms, and kissed the top of her dark hair. She pressed her face against the white gambeson, her small hands gripping the quilted fabric at his sides. He held her. The arm that had been wounded wrapped around her shoulders without hesitation, as though the hand had already forgotten what it had cost.

They stood like that for several seconds, the girl’s face hidden, the man’s chin resting on the crown of her head, his eyes fixed on something far beyond the courtyard wall. Then he released her, placed both hands on her shoulders, and said something too quiet to carry.

She nodded once.

## The crib

Thomas was still watching when a hand landed on his shoulder with enough force to suggest its owner had not entirely mastered the art of measured physical contact.

Baldwin came bounding around from the back of a carriage, half-running, half-jumping, his spectacles slightly askew, his face flushed with the unmistakable expression of an eleven-year-old boy who had just seen something he had

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only ever read about.

“Merlin’s *beard*,” Baldwin breathed, gripping Thomas’s arm. “Is that —”

“Professor Hugh Li. . .” Cecile said, approaching from behind them. Her voice was calm, but her eyes had not left the pair on the grass.

“Laura Orwell,” Baldwin interrupted her.

Thomas looked between them. “Who?”

Philippa, who had just appeared beside them with the quiet inevitability of someone who never missed a conversation worth hearing, gave Thomas a look of undisguised disbelief.

“Have you been living under a rock? She’s Hogwarts’ biggest mystery since the Chamber of Secrets.”

“Chamber of what now?” said Thomas.

“Never mind.” Baldwin’s hand was still on Thomas’s arm. He was practically vibrating. “Eleven years ago, to this very day, the four ships of the Hogwarts convoy entered the loch. The *Melusine* was still under construction in the shipyard, so there were only four — the *Mermaid*, the *Siren*, the *Ceasg*, and the *Marrow*. The port had been assembled, everything was normal, and then —” He faltered, not from forgetting, but from the sheer pressure of wanting to say everything at once.

Philippa picked up the thread with the easy authority of someone who had heard the story from more sources. “A fifth ship appeared drifting slowly towards the port. A full-sized hulk, larger than any of the sisters and darker in colour.”

“They boarded it,” Cecile continued, her voice lower. She had heard this from older students who had heard it from older students still, and the story had acquired the particular, reverent weight of a tale told many times in common rooms after dark. “It was in pristine condition, no damage, no marks on the hull to suggest what had happened or where it had been. No crew either, no passengers, no cargo, no log. The galley was cold. The water barrels were full. The rigging was set as though someone had just finished trimming the sails and then simply. . . ceased to exist.”

“Empty,” Philippa said. “Completely empty. Except —”

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“Except for a baby,” Baldwin said, unable to contain himself any longer. “A newborn girl, alive and healthy, wrapped in a clean blanket, lying in a beautiful crib in one of the cabins of the sterncastle. The name *Laura Orwell* was carved into the wood on one side. Nothing else. No letter, no seal, no indication of who had placed her there or why.”

“The Wizards’ Council launched an investigation,” Philippa added. “Every wizarding and Muggle ship on the western seaboard was accounted for. A few wrecks were checked — none matched the design. The hull itself resisted every charm they cast to trace its origin. The crib was examined by three separate experts. Nothing.”

“Eleven years,” Baldwin said, shaking his head slowly, “and not a single answer.”

“By the Headmaster’s request, her guardianship was assigned to Professor Ligier,” Philippa said. “He grew fond of her and adopted her shortly after.”

Baldwin nodded. “She was raised within the castle walls. Learned to walk in its corridors, grew up among the ghosts and the portraits and the shifting staircases.” He paused, adjusting his spectacles. “Hogwarts is not her school. It is, and has always been, her home.”

Ligier and Laura reached the heavy oak door at the top of the stairs. He pushed it open with his free hand and guided her through. The door swung shut behind them with a low, resonant thud that carried down the steps and across the courtyard. They did not look back at the carriages. They did not acknowledge the arriving students.

The group stood in silence for a moment, watching the closed door.

“But who left her there?” Celine asked.

Her voice was soft, carrying the particular quality of a question asked not because the speaker expected an answer, but because the absence of one felt unbearable.

Baldwin looked at the heavy oak door at the top of the stairs, now shut and still, as though it had never opened.

“Nobody knows.”

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## The Mirror

The interior courtyard was one of the quieter spaces of Hogwarts, enclosed on all sides by pale walls and narrow arched corridors. The masonry was clean and severe rather than ancient, recently raised by wizarding hands but already bearing the marks of hard weather and hurried passage. In one corner stood a single oak tree, deliberately planted, its branches spreading just wide enough to cast shade across the flagstones and soften the echo of footsteps.

Students clustered everywhere: some whispering in hurried Latin, others laughing too loudly, a few standing apart with rigid backs and hands clenched around borrowed trunks or sleeves. It was the sort of noise made by children pretending not to be anxious.

Celine was still in one of the corridors that opened onto the courtyard, walking slowly toward the light. She held the mirror carefully, as though afraid that even her breath might disturb it. The glass shimmered faintly, catching more than light — movement, distance, warmth.

Her father's face wavered into focus.

"Are you warm enough?" he asked, his voice tinny but warm. Behind him, the wooden masts and salt-stained rigging of a ship swayed against a pale sky.

"I'm fine," Celine said quickly. "Truly. The castle is... huge. It is a forest of stone towers and high bridges, larger than any cathedral I could have imagined."

He smiled, though worry still clung to the corners of his eyes. "Your sister?"

"Nearby," Celine said, glancing across the courtyard. Cecile was speaking animatedly with a tall girl, her hands moving as if she was already in a classroom explaining something important.

Her father nodded. "Good." He hesitated, then added, more firmly, "Listen to me. Whatever house they put you in, you won't be alone. You'll always have your sister. And Philippa, she's sharp. Stay close to her."

Celine nodded, blinking. "I will."

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She had just begun to lift the mirror closer, as if to imprint his face into memory, when a shadow fell across the glass.

“Well, that’s interesting.”

The voice was sharp, amused in a way that made her stomach tighten. Hector Hawthorne stood there, a boy with an air of mocking confidence. Before Celine could react, his hand darted forward and seized the mirror by its edge.

“Hey —!” Celine cried, lunging, but Hector was already moving.

He was quick, light on his feet, darting backward with a laugh as he turned the mirror over in his hands. The image of her father flickered wildly, then vanished into a blank shimmer.

“What’s this?” Hector said, loud enough that several nearby students turned. “Talking to people already? Didn’t know we were allowed visitors.”

“Give it back,” Celine said, her voice trembling despite herself. “It’s not yours.”

He ignored her, craning his neck as though trying to peer deeper into the glass. “That wasn’t anyone from here,” he said. “No robes. No wand. Funny way of speaking, too.”

A few students laughed. Others watched silently.

Celine stepped forward again, her hands half-raised. “Please.”

Hector’s smile widened. “Please,” he echoed. “Did he teach you magic too... or is he a muggle?”

Cecile’s voice cut across the courtyard. “Leave her alone!”

She was already moving, pushing past two older boys, her face flushed with anger. But Hector Hawthorne was faster. He spun on his heel and bolted toward the oak tree.

“Catch me if you want it back,” Hector called, already scrambling up the low stone border and grabbing the lowest branch.

Celine stood frozen, heart pounding, staring upward as he climbed. The mirror glinted between his fingers.

That was when Thomas decided to act. He had been standing a step behind

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Colum, quiet, observant, his posture loose enough to seem almost uninterested. When he moved, it was without haste or drama. His left hand lifted slightly at his side, fingers straight, and several pale strands of his own hair were already looped around them, tangled there as if by habit rather than intention. His eyes found the back of Colum's wand hand — and held.

Colum, wand already in hand from nervous habit, stiffened. His arm jerked upward, sharp and sudden, as if seized by an invisible string. His wrist turned, his elbow locked, and the wand's tip snapped into line with Hector in the tree. Colum felt the pull travel through his shoulder and down to his fingers — a cold, precise pressure that moved his joints with an authority that was not his own.

“Wait —!” Colum said, startled, his fingers tightening uselessly around a wand that had nothing to do with what happened next.

A flash of light lanced forward from behind Colum and crossed the courtyard in a flat, bright line. It passed so close to the tip of the outstretched wand that the difference was invisible to anyone watching from the front — which was everyone. From where the courtyard stood, the spell had come from Colum's wand. From where Thomas stood — one step behind, his left hand low at his side, the strands still wound tight across his knuckles — it had not.

It wasn't violent, not exactly. It was quick and precise, like a decision made too fast to reconsider.

Hector yelped as an unseen force struck him squarely in the chest. He flew backward, spinning twice before landing hard on the stone with a thud that echoed through the courtyard.

The mirror hit the ground a heartbeat later.

The sound it made — sharp, brittle, final — cut through everything.

Silence fell.

Celine stared at the ground, her breath caught somewhere between her ribs and her throat. The mirror lay in pieces — four of them — its shimmer gone, the surface dull and lifeless.

Cecile reached her at last, wrapping an arm around her shoulders. “It's all right,” she said fiercely, though her eyes were fixed on the broken glass. “It's

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all right.”

Hector sat up slowly, groaning, his bravado evaporated. A few students murmured. Others stepped back.

All eyes turned to Colum Douglas, whose face had gone pale.

“I —” he began. “I didn’t —”

But Cecile was already turning to Colum. She seized his sleeve, eyes bright with gratitude. “*Merci*, thank you,” she said, and before he could react, she leaned forward and kissed his cheek.

His ears turned red instantly.

From the edge of the courtyard, Professor Magnus Grim had been watching.

He stepped forward now, his long coat whispering against the stone. He did not raise his voice. He did not scold. He simply looked down at the boy on the ground.

“Mr. Hawthorne,” he said calmly. “Hogwarts does not take well to bullies.”

Hector swallowed and looked away.

As Grim straightened, his gaze flicked — not to Colum, not to Cecile — but briefly, deliberately, to Thomas. Thomas stood where he had been a moment before — a step behind Colum, his left hand now resting loosely at his side, the pale strands of hair no longer visible between his fingers. His expression was carefully, perfectly blank. One eye closed and opened again, so quick it might have been dismissed as dust or strain. But it was not.

Professor Grim, Thomas, and Colum knelt and collected the mirror pieces.

Grim rose, holding the pieces he had taken. He plucked a small white daisy growing improbably between the stones nearby and tucked it into his sleeve.

“Miss Celine. Miss Cecile. You two as well,” he said, looking to Colum and then to Thomas, whose expression remained carefully blank. “Come with me.” He turned and walked away without another word, evidently certain they would follow. They did.

Behind them, the courtyard slowly began to breathe again — but something had shifted, unnoticed yet irreversible.

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## The Workshop

The Fournier sisters, Colum and Thomas followed Professor Magnus Grim in silence. Philippa, who had not been explicitly invited but possessed the distinct talent of appearing as though she belonged, fell into step beside them. Grim did not object.

They wound through a labyrinth of stone corridors until they reached a small, unassuming wooden door set deep within the castle's spine. Professor Grim halted. He raised his wand, tracing a silent glyph in the air. The iron lock gave a sharp, satisfying click, and the door swung inward.

With a flick of his wrist, the heavy velvet curtains at the far end of the room swept open, allowing the Highland light to flood the dusty space. With another flick, the oil lamps mounted on the stone walls flared to life, their warm yellow glow mixing with the daylight to create an amber haze. The room was part study, part workshop, filled with ticking instruments and the smell of ozone and new parchment.

Grim ushered them inside and, with a wave of his wand, pushed two high-backed chairs forward for Celine and Cecile. The door clicked shut behind them, sealing out the noise of the castle.

"The fragments," Grim said, extending a hand.

He placed the two shards he had gathered onto his workbench. Colum and Thomas stepped forward, placing their own pieces beside them.

Grim stood over the broken glass. He flicked his wand and muttered, "*Revelio*."

Nothing happened. The glass remained dull and inert.

Grim hummed, unimpressed. He turned to the cold fireplace, summoning a generous handful of grey wood ash into his palm. He blew the ash into the air above the table, where it hung suspended in a gravity-defying cloud.

"*Diagnosce et manifestare*," he intoned.

Immediately, the swirling ash coalesced. It darkened and amalgamated, forming complex geometric shapes and thin, ghostly strings in the air above the mirror pieces. Some of the shapes were twisted and deformed; many of the connecting strings snapped and whipped in the air, seeking anchors that



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no longer existed.

“Interesting,” Grim murmured, leaning closer, his eyes reflecting the floating ash. “Intriguing . . . oh, unfortunate.”

He opened a drawer and levitated a thin filament of pure gold. With a subtle twist of his wand, the metal disintegrated into a fine, shimmering powder. He directed it into the suspended ash, mixing the gold with the grey.

Then, he began the surgery.

With precise movements of his wand, Grim distanced the four mirror fragments from one another. He slashed his wand through the air, rupturing the ghostly strings that still tried to connect the shapes above the different pieces. The snap of the breaking magic was audible, like the plucking of a taut violin string.

For each isolated shard, he began to weave. He reshaped the ash and gold above each piece, tying the loose ends back onto themselves, creating four self-contained loops of magic.

He lowered his wand. The cloud of ash and gold dust glowed with a sudden heat, then rained down, melting into the glass surface.

At that moment, the surface of the mirrors rippled. Grim picked up one shard, holding it close to his face. Instantly, the image of his eye — magnified and inquiring — appeared not in the piece he held, but on the surface of the three shards still lying on the table.

Grim nodded, satisfied. He went to place the shard back down, but his thumb grazed a jagged edge.

“Ouch.”

A bead of bright red blood welled on his finger. Grim frowned at it, pressed his wand tip briefly to the cut — sealing it — and wiped the smear of blood from the glass with his sleeve before it could settle into the enchantment.

He turned back to the drawer. Two metallic filaments floated out — one of reddish copper, the other of dull tin. Under the heat of his silent will, portions of the metals liquified, swirling together in mid-air to fuse into a glowing, golden-brown bronze.

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The alloy stretched out like taffy, forming a thin, flat bar. Grim sliced the bar into four sections. With delicate care, he wrapped the warm bronze around the jagged perimeter of the first shard, the metal cooling and hardening instantly to form a protective rim. He repeated this for the other three.

The work was not done. With the tip of his wand, he carved into the cooling bronze, etching tiny, intricate petals and vines. He levitated a final thread of silver, melting it into the grooves he had just carved. The silver shone stark and beautiful against the bronze.

Grim stepped back and flicked his wand over the finished pieces.

*“Desiste.”*

The reflections on the mirrors vanished, returning to normal glass.

He flicked his wand again. *“Reflecte.”*

The surface shimmered, and once again, the shards linked, each reflecting the view of the others.

Professor Grim gathered the four artifacts and turned to the students. His expression was serious, the earlier flash of pain forgotten.

“As is often the case with magical artifacts,” he said, his voice dropping to a lecture tone, “especially the complex ones, the original vessel could not be fixed. The enchantment that bound it is severed.”

He held out the pieces.

“However,” he continued, “just because something is broken, it doesn’t mean its parts can’t be repurposed. A shattered whole may yet birth new instruments.”

He placed the four framed mirrors into Celine’s hands.

Celine looked down at them. They were no longer a single window to her home, but something new. Something shared.

She kept one for herself. She handed the second to Cecile. She turned and pressed the third into Philippa’s hand. Finally, she stepped toward Colum and offered him the last one.

Colum took it, his thumb brushing the silver-inlaid bronze, the glass cool

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against his palm.

Professor Grim dusted the remaining ash from his palms and glanced toward the heavy hourglass sitting amidst the clutter of his desk. The sand was running dangerously low.

“Now,” he said, his tone shifting from that of an artisan back to a master of the school. “We had best secure those and make haste to the Great Hall. The Sorting Ceremony is imminent, and it would not do to be absent before the proceedings even commence.”

He ushered them toward the door, extinguishing the oil lamps with a sweeping wave of his hand as they passed, plunging the room back into shadows.

“Come,” he commanded, opening the door for them.

## The Sorting Hat

The hall was quieter than Thomas had expected. It was not a void of sound, but a heavy, expectant restraint, as if the severe stone walls were leaning in to listen. Above, the ceiling whispered faintly with the drift of candle-smoke and the low thrum of magic.

Professor Magnus Grim stood beside the three-legged stool, utterly still, his long dark coat falling to the stone floor. As the Head of Gryffindor, he held the weathered Hat with a quiet reverence, his sharp eyes scanning the rows of new faces.

One by one, names were called.

“Celine Fournier,” professor Grim called, nailing the French pronunciation, Celine observed.

Celine walked forward with a small, hesitant step. There was an unmistakable innocence in the way she looked at the Great Hall — a trusting curiosity that seemed untouched by the cynicism of the older students. As she climbed onto the stool, Professor Grim lowered the Hat over her eyes. It slipped low, almost touching the bridge of her nose.

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“Ah,” a voice whispered in her mind, gentle and resonant. “So open. A heart that expects the best of the world, isn’t it? Such a rare, trusting thing.”

Celine stiffened, but she did not pull away.

“Kindness first,” the Hat murmured. “Always kindness. A heart that would rather be hurt than become hard. . .”

A pause stretched out.

“Hufflepuff would keep you safe. It would cherish that innocence. But you would not stay safe, even if I asked you to. When the time comes, your trust will become your shield, and you will step forward while others hide. Yes. . . I see it now. Not boldness — but bravery.”

“GRYFFINDOR!”

The table erupted. Celine slid off the stool, dazed and smiling, and Cecile’s hands were already on her shoulders as she reached the bench.

Other names were called. Some were met with roaring cheers, others with polite applause, each student finding their table and their place.

“Philippa Laskaris.”

Philippa sat with a perfect, icy composure. She didn’t look at the Hat; she looked at the people. She mapped the faces of the professors and the cliques forming at the tables, already gauging the social architecture of the school. Philippa might not have known every secret of the castle yet, but she already knew exactly who to watch to find them. Professor Grim placed the Hat upon her head.

“Oh, you see the strings, don’t you?” the Hat hummed thoughtfully. “It is not just about what is known, but who knows it. You are a weaver of connections. You know who speaks to whom, and exactly which hand to hold to open a locked door.”

Philippa’s chin lifted slightly.

“Ravenclaw would value your mind, but you do not care for books as much as you care for the people who write them. Slytherin would teach you to rule those connections. But there is a fire in you that refuses to remain in the

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shadows. You want the world to see your work.”

“GRYFFINDOR!”

Philippa smiled — a sharp, knowing expression — as if she had already decided this was the most advantageous outcome.

The ceremony continued — name after name, the Hat deliberating briefly with some, longer with others, the four tables filling steadily.

“Hector Hawthorne.”

When Hector’s name was called, he walked to the stool with a swagger. Professor Grim’s expression remained unreadable as he lowered the Hat.

“Pride of lineage and a sharp eye for leverage,” the Hat said with cold clarity. “You seek the high ground, Hawthorne. You seek the company of those who understand that power is a currency and everything is transactional.”

Hector’s jaw tightened. He didn’t look afraid; he looked hungry.

“You will find your kin among those who sharpen themselves against the world.”

“SLYTHERIN!”

Hector stood and headed for the green-draped table, where several older students nodded to him with narrow-eyed approval.

More names followed. The list was long — students from every corner of the British Isles and beyond — and the hall settled into the rhythm of the ceremony, each sorting met with its own brief eruption before the quiet returned.

“Thomas Blackwood.”

When Thomas took his seat, Professor Grim lowered the Hat. Then, everything stopped.

The Hat did not speak. It did not shout. It began to mutter, a low, rhythmic grumble that only Thomas could truly hear, though the entire hall could see

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the brim twitching and folding.

One minute passed. Then two. The restless shifting of the students began to die down, replaced by a heavy, confused silence.

“Cecile? Why is it taking so long? Is something wrong?” Celine leaned closer to her sister, her voice a tiny whisper.

Cecile was staring at Thomas, her eyes wide with a mixture of awe and fear. “It’s a Hatstall,” she breathed, her voice trembling. “I heard about this... it’s very, very rare. Once in a generation. It happens when the Hat finds a mind so complex that it cannot choose.”

Five minutes passed. Thomas sat like a statue, his knuckles white where he gripped the stool. The Hat’s murmuring grew louder, a frantic, debating sound.

“Difficult... so very difficult. There is power here — raw, instinctive, undisciplined. With discipline you could command things. You could shatter them too, boy.”

Thomas did not move. He did not want to command anything. He just wanted the Hat to finish.

“Slytherin would give that power a purpose. It would hone that instinct into a weapon. You could be great — recognised across the kingdoms.” The Hat groaned, the leather twisting. “But you... you do not want the glory, do you? You don’t seek the applause. You just do what is right, simply because it is right. A dangerous, unyielding honesty.”

Eight minutes. Ten. The silence in the hall was now absolute, broken only by the flickering of the candles. Even Professor Grim’s expression had tightened.

“Power like yours belongs in Slytherin to be mastered,” the Hat whispered, sounding almost exhausted. “But a soul like yours... it belongs to the fight. You would rather be a shield than a crown.”

Finally, the Hat’s brim opened wide.

“GRYFFINDOR!”

The roar that followed was less like a cheer and more like a release of built-up pressure. Thomas stood up slowly, his face still a mask of neutrality, though

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his heart was racing. He caught Professor Grim's eye; the Professor gave a single, almost imperceptible nod of respect.

The ceremony resumed. After the extraordinary length of Thomas's sorting, each subsequent name felt brisk by comparison — the Hat settling quickly, the tables responding, the list steadily shortening.

"Edmund Varre."

A boy rose from the benches and walked to the stool with a measured, unhurried stride. His appearance was immaculate — an overcoat of dark wool, elegantly cut and cinched tight at the waist, falling over perfectly ironed trousers and shoes polished to a mirror shine. He sat, crossed one ankle behind the other, and folded his hands in his lap. Professor Grim lowered the Hat.

It barely touched his head.

"Easy... so very easy. There is only one house your heart ever considered. SLYTHERIN!"

Edmund stood, and in a single, rehearsed motion, unbuttoned his overcoat. Beneath it, he was already wearing the full Slytherin uniform — the emerald and silver pressed and immaculate, as though he had dressed for the portrait before the painter had arrived.

The Slytherin table erupted. Applause, whistles, older students stamping their feet against the stone floor. Edmund walked toward them without hurry, his chin level, his expression one of quiet satisfaction. Hector Hawthorne shifted on the bench to make room, and Edmund sat beside him as though the seat had been reserved.

"Colum Douglas."

Colum stood. His legs were not entirely steady. He walked to the stool and sat. Professor Grim lowered the Hat — and as the brim touched his head, Colum's eyes found Cecile at the Hufflepuff table — a fraction of a second, no more — but long enough for him to remember the kiss on his cheek.

The Hat laughed aloud — a deep, delighted laugh that echoed against the

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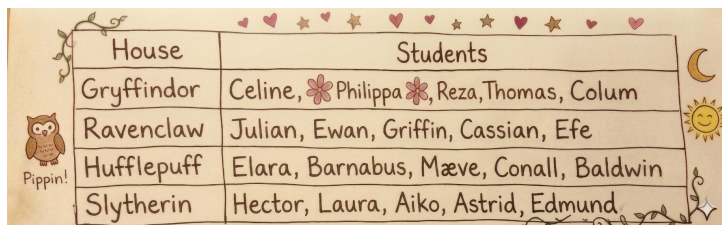
stone.

“No debate here. None at all.”

“GRYFFINDOR — DEFINITELY GRYFFINDOR!”

The Gryffindor table erupted in thunderous applause and cheers, the older students banging their goblets on the oak, while Colum, his face turning a brilliant scarlet, grinned sheepishly as he walked toward them and sat down beside Thomas, Celine, and Philippa.

Across the table, Philippa was writing in a small notebook — new, its spine uncracked, the paper a pale, warm cream. She added a final name to a table she had been filling throughout the ceremony, set down her quill, and turned back to watch the last of the sorting. Colum glanced down at the open page.



A hand-drawn table with two columns: 'House' and 'Students'. The table is decorated with hearts and stars at the top. On the left side, there is a drawing of an owl with the text 'Pippin!' below it. On the right side, there is a drawing of a sun and a moon. The table lists the following students for each house:

| House      | Students                               |
|------------|----------------------------------------|
| Gryffindor | Celine, Philippa, Reza, Thomas, Colum  |
| Ravenclaw  | Julian, Ewan, Griffin, Cassian, Efe    |
| Hufflepuff | Elara, Barnabus, Mæve, Conall, Baldwin |
| Slytherin  | Hector, Laura, Aiko, Astrid, Edmund    |

## The Feast

Professor Hepburn pressed the tip of his wand to his throat.

“Attention!” His amplified voice rolled across the Great Hall like a warm, heavy wave, filling every corner, silencing the last pockets of excited chatter and nervous laughter. The echoes died against the high stone walls, and a hundred faces turned toward him.

The Headmaster waited until the silence was complete. Then he smiled — a broad, genuine, deeply satisfied smile that creased his entire face.

“Now then,” he said, his tone dropping to a conversational warmth that somehow carried just as far. “Now that every last one of you has been sorted into your respective houses — and I trust the Hat has made no grievous errors this evening, though I confess it has surprised me once or twice —” a ripple of laughter crossed the hall, “— we may proceed to the part of this



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night that I suspect you have all been waiting for with considerably more enthusiasm than the Sorting itself.”

He paused, letting the anticipation build, his large hands resting on the edge of the high table.

“The feast.” He said the word with the reverence of a man who meant it. “And I will confess freely that no one in this hall has been longing for it more than I have. Ten days of ship’s biscuits and the galley’s best attempts at stew will do that to a man.”

He drew his wand again, gave it a broad, theatrical sweep toward the far end of the hall, and the Great Hall’s heavy oak doors swung open with a deep, resonant groan.

Four large rolls of linen entered first. They moved of their own accord, drifting through the open doors in a stately procession, hovering at the height of a man’s chest. They were thick and tightly wound, and as each one reached its designated table, it began to unroll — slowly, deliberately — the fabric cascading down the length of the oak in a single, continuous motion, the leading edge smoothing itself flat as it advanced.

The tablecloths were extraordinary. Each was minutely embroidered with scenes depicting the history of Hogwarts — from the four founders laying the first stones to what appeared to be recent events of the current era — in a style reminiscent of the Bayeux Tapestry<sup>1</sup> : figures in profile, towers rendered in sharp, flat perspective, battles and ceremonies and feasts stitched in fine, coloured thread against a cream ground. Around and between the scenes, geometric borders and ornamental flourishes carried the colours of each house: green and silver for Slytherin, blue and bronze for Ravenclaw, yellow and black for Hufflepuff, and red and gold for Gryffindor. The stitching was so fine and so densely worked that the linen seemed less like cloth and more like illuminated manuscript laid flat.

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<sup>1</sup>An embroidered linen cloth, nearly 70 m long and 0.5 m wide, depicting the Norman conquest of England in 1066.



Professors Agnes Ravenclaw, Hugh Ligier, and Magnus Grim stood and drew their wands, joining Headmaster Hepburn — the four heads of house, one for each table. What followed was a piece of choreography so tightly rehearsed that it was impossible to tell where one professor's magic ended and another's began. They moved in perfect synchrony — four wands tracing arcs and flicks in a continuous, interlocking sequence, the gestures small and precise, the coordination absolute.

Four towering columns of coarse earthenware plates entered through the open doors, stacked impossibly high, each tower leaning at a worrying angle as it drifted across the threshold. A collective intake of breath ran through the first-years. Before a single plate could fall, the towers began to deal. The plates peeled from the bottom of each stack one by one, spinning outward in flat, rapid arcs and settling before each seat like cards being dealt by a croupier — a sharp, dry click of ceramic on wood, perfectly spaced, perfectly timed.

Then the silverware, the cups, and the chalices — all distributed with geometric exactness, each piece finding its position in the same instant across all four tables. Ceramic beakers for the spiced ale. Tin chalices for the mulled wine, polished but plain, catching the candlelight in dull, warm flashes. Knives, forks, and spoons followed in neat, glinting lines, dropping into place

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with a series of rapid, percussive clicks that sounded, for a moment, like applause.

Headmaster Hepburn moved a step forward, and he was smiling. He gave his wand a gentle, looping flick — a gesture that was almost lazy — and from beyond the doors came a fluttering, rustling cloud. Napkins. Hundreds of them, folded into the shapes of small birds — collared doves, by the look of them — their linen wings held in mid-beat by a stiffening charm. They swept into the hall in a great, wheeling mass, climbing toward the enchanted ceiling before diving toward the tables in playful, spiralling descents.

Thomas saw his coming and raised his hand instinctively to bat it away. The napkin banked sharply, dodged his fingers, looped behind his head, and came at him again from the opposite side. He caught it mid-flight, or thought he did; it wriggled free, fluttered once around his wrist, and tucked itself firmly into his collar with a decisive little flourish. Around the hall, similar small battles were being lost. Colum had given up entirely and sat with his arms crossed, waiting with a look of exasperated dignity as his dove circled him twice before settling. Philippa, who had watched two boys ahead of her fail, simply tilted her chin up and let hers land without resistance; it nestled into place with a satisfied ruffle. A senior student two seats down — a third-year girl who had not looked up from her cup — said, without turning, “Just let them do their job.”

Then the food came.

Great trays entered through the doors in a slow, ponderous procession, each one heavy enough that the magic carrying it seemed to labour under the weight. They settled onto the dressed tables with a deep, wooden exhale.

The centrepiece of each table was a haggis — split open and steaming, its coarse, peppery smell rising in a thick, savoury column. The filling was dark and crumbled, dense with oats and offal and sharp with the bite of onion and black pepper. Beside each sat a broad, shallow bowl of mashed neeps, pale gold and glistening with butter.

Next came the Scotch broth — a thick, heavy pottage of pearl barley, mutton, and root vegetables served in deep earthenware bowls. The surface shimmered with fat, and the smell was ancient, elemental — slow-cooked bone and leek and turnip, the kind of broth that had warmed the Highlands since before the castle’s first stone was laid.

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Finally, the venison. Whole haunches, roasted dark and lacquered with a glaze of honey and rosemary, the meat pulling apart where the carving knife had already begun its work. The fat had rendered to a thin, crisp bark along the edges, and the juices pooled on the trenchers beneath, soaking into thick rounds of oat bread that served as both plate and sponge.

Behind the food came the drinks. Two sets of tall, narrow-necked jars arranged themselves along the tables. The first set were plain — unadorned clay, evenly distributed along the full length of each table. The second set, marked with a band of red glaze around the neck, drifted toward the high table where the professors and staff sat, and toward the upper ends of each house table where most of the senior students had gathered.

At the Hufflepuff table, Cecile turned on the bench and caught her sister's eye across the gap between the tables. "The red jars are for professors, staff, and senior students only," she said, her voice carrying just enough to reach Celine and Philippa. She held the look for a beat — the firm, unambiguous gaze of an older sister who did not intend to repeat herself — then turned back to her own table. Celine reached for the nearest plain jar without comment. Philippa did the same.

The feast began. The noise of the hall rose — the particular, dense sound of a hundred conversations conducted simultaneously over the scrape of knives and the heavy pouring of drink. The enchanted ceiling above shifted to mirror the sky outside, a deep, clear indigo scattered with early stars.

At the Hufflepuff table, Barnabus Finch set down his beaker of spiced ale and produced a burp of startling resonance. It was not quiet. It carried. Several heads turned. Two Ravenclaw girls covered their mouths. From the Slytherin table, the Bloody Baron's voice cut across the gap like a blade on glass.

"Mind your manners, boy."

Barnabus went very still, his rosy cheeks deepening to a shade that might have been mistaken for sunburn. He did not burp again.

A small, ghostly, cackling shape streaked across the hall at speed, barely visible against the tall stonework. It paused — just long enough — above a second-year boy at the Ravenclaw table, and a fine dusting of salt rained into his cup. The boy drank, choked, and spat in surprise, his face contorting. "Peeves!" he sputtered, wiping his mouth furiously. A gleeful laugh echoed off the vaulted ceiling as the shape rocketed toward the far wall and vanished

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through it. The boy's tablemates offered no sympathy whatsoever; the girl beside him was already laughing so hard that her own drink was in jeopardy.

The feast continued. The trays were emptied and refilled, the broth bowls scraped clean, the venison carved down to the bone. Conversation settled into the easy, lulling rhythm of well-fed contentment. At the Gryffindor table, Celine was explaining something to Colum with animated hand gestures, her earlier nervousness entirely forgotten. Thomas listened with half an ear, his gaze drifting across the hall — to the green-lit end of the Slytherin table where Laura Orwell sat in silence, to the Ravenclaw bench where Griffin Ollivander appeared to be examining his fork with the same intensity other students reserved for their wands.

As the last of the plates were cleared and the enchanted ceiling deepened toward true night, Headmaster Hepburn rose from his seat. He did not amplify his voice this time. He did not need to; the hall quieted on its own, the conversations thinning and dying like embers.

"You have eaten well, I hope," he said, his tone warm and unhurried. "You have been sorted. You have found your tables and, I hope, begun to find your friends." He paused, letting his gaze move slowly across the four long tables. "Now it is time to find your beds." He clapped his large hands together once, the sound sharp and final against the stone. "Prefects, lead your houses. First-years, follow closely. The castle is old, and it does not always agree with itself about where the corridors go." A few tired laughs. "Sleep well."

The benches scraped back. The four tables emptied in four directions — the Gryffindors toward the grand staircase, the Hufflepuffs toward the lower corridors, the Ravenclaws toward the west tower, the Slytherins toward the dungeons. For the first time since the Thames, the group that had formed in Cabin Eleven and grown with every port of call was no longer together. Thomas caught a last glimpse of Cecile's brown hair disappearing down a corridor to the left, of Cassian's tall frame turning right with the Ravenclaws, of Aiko's straight back descending toward the green-lit passage below.

Then they were gone, and the castle had them.

## 12 First Day

Philippa Laskaris was dreaming of Alexandria.

She was standing on the harbour wall in the late afternoon, the sun behind her, watching the long shadow of the Pharos stretch across the water like a dark finger pointing toward open sea. Her father was beside her, explaining something about currents and shipping lanes, but his voice had acquired a strange, metallic quality — resonant and rhythmic, growing louder with each word, until the harbour and the lighthouse and the warm Egyptian air dissolved entirely, and there was only the sound.

*Bong.*

She opened one eye.

*Bong.*

The dormitory ceiling came into focus — high, vaulted stone, crossed by heavy oak beams from which the faded crimson-and-gold banners of Gryffindor hung in long, still drapes. Grey morning light pressed through the tall, narrow windows and lay in pale rectangles across the stone floor.

*Bong.*

The castle bell. She began to count.

*Bong.*

Four.

*Bong.*

Five.

*Bong.*

Six. She pulled the heavy woollen blanket higher, her body making a compelling, well-reasoned argument for remaining exactly where it was. The stone walls held the cold of the night like a cellar, and the warmth beneath

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the covers was the only civilised temperature in the room.

*Bong.*

Seven.

*Bong.*

Eight.

Eight.

Philippa sat bolt upright, the blanket falling to her waist. Eight bells. Eight bells meant it was almost Terce<sup>1</sup>, which meant the morning meal was already half-finished, which meant —

“*Merde.* We are late.”

Her voice cut across the dormitory with the flat, unequivocal authority of a girl who had grown up aboard merchant vessels where lateness was measured in lost cargo and strained alliances. She was already swinging her legs over the side of the bed, her bare feet meeting the cold stone with a shock that finished the work the bells had started.

The only other bed in the room was still very much occupied.

Celine Fournier lay on her side, curled beneath her blanket with the total, unreachable commitment of a girl in the deepest trench of sleep. Her dark hair fanned across the pillow in a tangle. One arm hung over the edge of the mattress, her fingers trailing the stone floor. Her breathing was slow, even, and entirely undisturbed by the eight bells, by Philippa’s exclamation, or by any sense of urgency the morning might reasonably expect to impose upon a first-year student on her first day of lessons.

Philippa crossed the room in four quick strides and placed a hand on Celine’s shoulder.

“Celine.”

Nothing.

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<sup>1</sup>Canonical hours was the medieval system of dividing the day, marked by the number of hours after sunrise. Prime (early morning), Terce (mid-morning), Sext (midday), None (mid-afternoon), Vespers (evening), and Compline (nightfall).

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“Celine. Wake up.”

The girl’s breathing did not change. She did not stir, did not shift, did not give any indication that the hand on her shoulder or the voice above her head occupied any part of her consciousness. She slept the way a stone sits at the bottom of a river — settled, heavy, and profoundly uninterested in the surface.

Philippa shook her, harder this time. “Celine. It is eight bells. We have missed breakfast. We are going to be late for the first lesson. *Celine.*”

A sound emerged from beneath the hair — not a word, not quite a groan, but something from the same family. It was the sound of a mind being dragged, against its explicit wishes, toward the waking world.

“Mmmnhh.”

“That is not a word. Get up.”

Celine’s eyes opened — slowly, reluctantly, as though the lids themselves were negotiating the terms of their cooperation. She blinked twice at the stone ceiling. Then she turned her head and looked at Philippa, her expression carrying the particular, unfocused bewilderment of a person who has been woken from a dream and has not yet fully accepted the reality she has been returned to.

“What time is it?” she murmured.

“Late,” Philippa said, already pulling her robes from the hook on the wall. “Very, considerably, unacceptably late.”

Celine sat up with visible effort, rubbing her eyes with the heels of her hands. The dormitory came into focus around her. Empty beds. Grey light. Philippa already half-dressed and moving with the controlled urgency of a person who refused to panic but also refused to waste a single second.

Celine pushed the blanket aside and swung her feet to the floor. She reached for her shoes — placed, as she always placed them, side by side at the foot of her bed.

The left shoe was there. The right shoe was not.

She stared at the empty space for a moment, her still-waking mind processing



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the absence with the slow, grinding effort of a millstone turning its first revolution of the day. She leaned over the far side of the bed and looked down. Nothing. She ducked her head beneath the bed frame, peering into the dusty shadow between the stone floor and the wooden slats. Nothing. She straightened, frowning, and cast her eye across the floor around the neighbouring beds — perhaps she had kicked it in her sleep, or it had been nudged aside by one of the other girls on their way out.

It was then that she looked toward the door.

A small, ghostly figure lay across the threshold.

It was a dog — a terrier, small to medium in build, with the semi-transparent, faintly luminous quality of all Hogwarts spectres. His coat was white, or had been white, rendered now in the pale, pearlescent silver of the dead. He had a scruffy, whiskered muzzle that gave him the appearance of a small gentleman who had neglected to shave, and his ears — soft and floppy, folded forward at the tips — framed his face with an expression of guileless, unrepentant mischief. A single black spot marked the left ear, and a second darkened the tip of his tail, the only points of true colour on his otherwise spectral form.

He was lying with his head resting comfortably on Celine's right shoe.

"Hey, you," Celine said.

Tawe's tail moved first — a slow, exploratory wag, as though testing whether the situation warranted the full production. Then his ears lifted, and his dark eyes fixed on hers with the particular, bright intensity of a creature who has been waiting for exactly this moment and is thoroughly delighted that it has arrived.

He rose to his feet. The shoe came with him, clamped gently but firmly in his jaws. He stood in the doorway, holding the shoe with the dignified composure of a retriever presenting a duck, and looked at her.

"Give me my shoe, please," Celine said, in the reasonable tone of a girl addressing an unreasonable animal.

Tawe's response was immediate, ancient, and unmistakable. He dropped his front paws flat to the stone, his chest low, his haunches high, his tail beating the air behind him in rapid, joyful arcs. The play bow — the oldest invitation in the oldest language between the oldest companions. *Chase me.*

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*Come and take it. I dare you.*

Celine took a step forward.

Tawe did not wait. He sprang upright, pivoted with a speed that his small frame made almost comical, and bolted directly at the wall. There was no hesitation, no slowing — he hit the stone at full tilt and passed through it as though it were smoke, the spectral shimmer of his body dissolving into the grey masonry without resistance.

The shoe, which was not a ghost, dropped to the floor with a soft, solid *thud* and lay on the cold stone where the wall met the threshold, very much left behind.

Celine stood still for a moment, looking at the wall. A faint, muffled yip echoed from the other side — distant already, and self-satisfied.

She picked up the shoe. The leather was still faintly warm where his spectral head had rested on it — not living warmth, not quite, but a gentle residual heat, like a stone that has sat in the sun and remembers it.

“Did you see that?” Celine said, pulling the shoe on. A genuine, unhurried smile — the first of the morning — spread across her face. “The little rascal.”

“You can like him later,” Philippa replied, fastening the clasp of her cloak. “Move.”

## Bread and Grape Juice

They moved.

The corridors of Hogwarts in the early morning were not the corridors of Hogwarts at night. The torches burned low in their iron brackets, their flames modest and workmanlike, casting a steady, amber light that lacked the theatrical drama of the evening illumination. The staircases — which, Cecile had warned them, did not always agree with each other about where they led — were cooperative at this hour, the stone steps holding their positions with the resigned stillness of structures that had used up their mischief during the night and were now resting.

Philippa set the pace. She moved through the castle with the particular,

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purposeful stride of a girl who had visited Hogwarts twice before and had committed its principal routes to memory on both occasions — not from scholarly diligence, but from the practical understanding that knowing where you are going is the first and most important form of power. She took the main staircase down three flights, cut through a tapestried corridor that saved a full minute over the longer route, and descended a final set of wide, shallow steps that opened directly into the entrance hall.

The doors to the Great Hall stood open.

Inside, the four long house tables were still dressed with the remains of the morning meal. Most of the students had already gone — the benches were largely empty, the conversation reduced to a few scattered clusters of older students lingering over their cups. The enchanted ceiling showed a pale, clean sky streaked with thin cloud, the light falling evenly across the hall, catching the last of the steam rising from the serving vessels.

Philippa's eyes swept the Gryffindor table. The bread baskets were depleted but not empty. The butter crocks had been scraped thin. The fruit — fresh apples and pears, the last of the shore provisions — was almost gone entirely, replaced by the honeyed preserves that would carry them through the term. At the far end of the table, a tall clay pitcher of grape juice sat beside a shorter one of barley water, both still a quarter full.

They did not sit down.

Celine reached the table, seized a wooden cup from the nearest stack, and poured the grape juice with the efficient, one-handed motion of a girl who had spent years helping her father serve customers in a bakery where standing still meant falling behind. She drank the cup in three long swallows, standing, her free hand already reaching for a round of dark bread from the basket. The juice was cool and faintly tart, pressed from late-summer grapes, and it cut through the fog of her interrupted sleep with a clarity that no amount of Philippa's shaking had managed.

Philippa moved to the far end of the table, where a clay pitcher of milk still held a few inches. She poured a cup, drank it standing in three measured swallows, and then reached into the fruit bowl. Her fingers closed around a single pear — the last one, small and slightly bruised on one side but firm — sitting alone at the bottom of the dish. She took it without comment, the way a merchant's daughter takes the last of anything: quickly, and without

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drawing attention to the scarcity.

“Done?” Philippa asked.

Celine tore a large piece from the bread, stuffed it into her cheek, and nodded.

They left the Great Hall at a pace that was not quite a run — Philippa would not run through the entrance hall; it lacked dignity and attracted attention — but was close enough to one that the distinction was largely theoretical. Through the entrance hall, past the heavy oak doors, and out onto the broad stone steps that led down to the castle grounds.

## The Lake

The morning hit them like a door opening onto a different world.

The air was cold — properly, unmistakably cold, the kind of Highland autumn air that did not negotiate with clothing but simply went through it. The sky above was enormous, a pale, washed blue that stretched unbroken from the dark line of the mountains in the west to the towers of the castle behind them. The sun was up but still low, casting long shadows across the grass and catching the dew in a million points of white light that made the lawns glitter as though scattered with crushed glass.

Before them, the grounds of Hogwarts opened up in a long, gentle slope that ran down toward the lake. The grass was thick and wet, dark green where the shadow still held and bright where the sun had reached it. To the left, the edge of the Forbidden Forest stood like a wall — dense, dark, and abruptly vertical, the trees pressing together so tightly that the interior was invisible from even a few metres away. To the right, the land rose slightly toward the broom circuit and the distant oval of the arena, whose timber grandstands caught the morning light along their upper edges.

But it was the lake that commanded the eye.

It filled the lower ground entirely — a vast, dark, still expanse of water that seemed to absorb the sky rather than reflect it. The surface was black near the centre, where the depth was greatest, and softened to a deep, peaty brown near the margins, where the shallows ran over sand and gravel. The far shore was distant enough that the trees along its edge blurred into a

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single, continuous line of dark green, and beyond them the mountains rose in long, sweeping ridges, their summits already touched with the first pale dusting of early snow.

The group of first-year students was visible halfway down the slope, a loose, colourful cluster of black robes and cloaks moving together toward the water's edge. Philippa and Celine quickened their pace, the wet grass soaking through their shoes as they cut diagonally across the lawn to intercept them.

Thomas saw them first. He was walking near the front of the group beside Colum, his broom — the *Wayfarer*, its dark wood freshly oiled — resting across his right shoulder. He turned at the sound of their footsteps on the grass and gave them a look that was not quite a smile but occupied the same territory.

"Alive, then," he said.

"Barely," Philippa replied, falling into step beside him without breaking stride. "What did we miss?"

"Porridge. Brown bread. A remarkably aggressive pot of honey that Barnabus nearly dropped into his lap." Thomas shifted the broom on his shoulder. "And the announcement that the first flying lesson is by the lake."

Celine, still chewing her bread, looked around the group as they walked. Several of the first-years carried brooms — new ones, conspicuously so, their handles gleaming with fresh varnish. Laura Orwell carried one as well — not new, the varnish worn to a smooth, satiny finish along the grip, the stirrup design more refined than the standard student models. It was, Celine guessed, Professor Ligier's.

Most of the other students carried nothing.

Mæve Medici fell into step beside Celine and Philippa. "We are going to the lake," Mæve said. Her tone was informational rather than conversational — she was reporting a fact, not making small talk. "The lesson today is by the water. I don't know why. I asked Professor da Senna's assistant, who said only that we should wear clothes we do not mind getting wet." She paused, considering her own statement. "I mind getting wet."

"When did you talk to da Senna's assistant?" Philippa asked.

"At breakfast. He was collecting brooms from the storage shed near the arena.

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He was carrying a very unusual broom. It was larger than a normal one. It appeared to be built for two riders.”

Philippa filed this away without comment. Her eyes had already moved ahead, past the group of students, to the edge of the lake, where the lesson was being assembled.

## The Pier

Professor Afonso da Senna stood at the water’s margin. He was smaller than Thomas had expected — shorter than most of the older students, lean and angular, with the tightly wound physique of a person who carried no weight that did not serve a purpose. His dark hair was thick and curly, falling loosely around his face in a way that suggested indifference to grooming rather than neglect. He wore a plain linen shirt beneath a fitted leather jerkin, practical trousers tucked into low boots, and no cloak despite the cold. There was a quality to his stillness that was not relaxation. It was the stillness of a drawn bowstring. The stillness of a man who could move very, very fast and was, at present, choosing not to.

Behind him, four older students — sixth or seventh-years, by the look of them. One of them stood slightly apart, holding between herself and another student a broom unlike any Celine had seen — significantly longer than a standard model, with doubled foot-supports and a wider, more densely bound tail, built for stability rather than speed. A tandem broom, designed for two riders.

To the left of the professor, a wooden rack held perhaps two dozen brooms standing upright in slots. They were not new — the handles showed the particular, even wear of instruments used by many hands over many terms — but they were good brooms, well maintained, built to teach properly.

But it was the structure on the lake that stopped the group.

A wooden pier extended from the shore out over the dark water — low, solid, and built from heavy, tarred timber. It ran straight for perhaps a hundred metres, its pylons visible through the clear shallows near the bank and vanishing into blackness further out.

At the far end, the pier broadened into a wide platform, open on all sides,

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sitting a foot above the waterline. And on its far edge, a short set of stairs led up to a second, smaller platform — barely large enough for one person — from which a single wooden plank projected outward over the open water, unsupported, like a diving board. The plank was perhaps three metres long and it ended abruptly over water deep enough that the bottom was no longer visible.

Celine looked at the plank. She looked at the water beneath it. She looked at the brooms on the rack.

She looked at Philippa.

Philippa was already looking at the plank, and the expression on her face — the particular, calculating stillness of a girl weighing the available evidence and arriving at a conclusion she did not entirely enjoy — confirmed that they were both thinking the same thing.

Mæve, who had been reading her book throughout the entire walk and had only now looked up to take in the scene, closed the volume with a slow, deliberate motion.

“I mind getting wet,” she said again, very quietly.

## First Flight

Da Senna let them arrive. He did not call out, did not wave them over, did not hurry the stragglers. He simply waited, hands at his sides, until the group had gathered in a loose, uncertain semicircle around him at the water’s edge, and then he smiled — a brief, warm thing that softened the brooding architecture of his face entirely — and said, “Good morning.”

His Latin was crisp and lightly accented, carrying the rounded vowels of Portuguese beneath the formal grammar.

“Those of you who brought your own brooms, keep them. The rest of you — take one from the rack.”

Students selected brooms with varying degrees of confidence — some lifting them from the rack with practised ease, others holding them at arm’s length as though they might bite.

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Da Senna picked up his own broom — a lean, dark instrument that seemed to resent any gram of unnecessary weight — and nodded toward the pier. “Follow me.”

They walked the length of it in a loose procession, the wooden planking solid and wide beneath their feet, the loch opening up around them as they moved further from the shore. The water below darkened steadily, turning black and depthless by the time they reached the broad platform at the pier’s end.

When they had assembled, da Senna held his broom in front of him.

“Place the broom between your legs,” he said. He demonstrated, tucking the shaft beneath him. “Your body should sit as close as possible to the broom’s centre — the point where the weight of the handle ahead of you and the weight of the tail behind you are in balance. You will feel it. When you are in the right position, the broom will feel light.”

He watched as twenty-odd first-years arranged themselves. Philippa found her balance quickly. Mæve did not. Julian looked down at himself and seemed more concerned with whether the position looked right than whether it was.

“Your hands,” da Senna continued. He placed his right hand forward on the shaft, his left behind it, both grips firm but not white-knuckled. “Right hand leads. It controls the inclination of the nose — tip it down to accelerate, tip it up to slow or climb. Your left hand steadies and firms the position. Hold it firm. Do not squeeze, there’s no need.”

He paused. “For those of you who are left-handed, reverse the grip. Left leads, right steadies.”

Thomas adjusted. Across the platform, Laura Orwell had already done so.

“Now — the legs.” Da Senna pressed his calves inward against the shaft. “The broom is not a chair. You do not sit upon it. You hold it with the whole of your lower body — thighs, knees, calves. The tighter your legs, the more control you have in turns. But for now, just feel the position. Walk with it. Let your body learn where the broom wants to be.”

He stepped off the platform and walked a short loop along the pier, the broom tucked between his legs as naturally as a sword in a scabbard. The students followed, a procession of slightly bow-legged first-years shuffling



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along the wooden planking with their brooms clamped beneath them, looking — Thomas thought — considerably less glamorous than any of them had pictured themselves.

When they had returned to the platform, da Senna mounted a small wooden box that one of his assistants had placed near the edge. He was still holding the broom between his legs, his posture unchanged.

“The nose,” he said, tilting the front of the broom upward with his right hand. “Fifteen degrees above level — this is your departure angle. It gives you lift and forward motion together. From a standstill, this is how you begin.” He adjusted. “Flatten the angle and you go faster. Steepen it and you slow down, or climb. If you want to stop — pull up until the broom is level or slightly above, and let the speed bleed away.”

He looked at them. “The best way I can describe what you are about to do is this: flying a broom is like falling forward and never reaching the ground. You keep a slight upward inclination so that you are, at the same time, rising and falling — the two cancel each other, and the result is a straight line through the air.” He let that settle. “It sounds complicated. It is not. Your body will understand it faster than your mind will. Trust the fall.”

And then, without ceremony, he stepped off the edge of the box.

The broom caught him. He rose perhaps a metre above the platform, drifted forward over the dark water, banked left in a turn so sharp and clean that the tail of the broom drew a visible line in the morning mist, and came back. He dismounted onto the platform with unhurried precision.

The whole thing had taken perhaps five seconds.

“Now,” he said, and his smile returned. “The fun part.”

He walked along the line of students, making small adjustments as he went — a hand repositioned here, a grip loosened there, a broom shifted an inch forward on a boy who had been sitting too far back. His corrections were quick and physical, a touch on the wrist, a tap on the knee, rarely more than a word or two. When he reached Hector Hawthorne, who was holding his ash-handled broom with absolute confidence, da Senna stopped. He looked at the boy’s grip, his posture, the angle of the shaft — all of it held with unshakeable certainty. Da Senna reached forward, moved Hector’s right hand two inches down the shaft, pressed his left elbow inward, and shifted the

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broom's position against his legs. Hector's expression tightened, but he said nothing.

When he was satisfied, he directed them toward the stairs of the elevated platform. "Form a line. One at a time. Walk to the end of the plank, set your angle, and jump."

He pointed toward the water, where a wooden buoy floated roughly a hundred and fifty metres from the platform, painted bright red and bobbing gently on the still surface. "Your target is the buoy. Fly to it, circle it, and return here. You will not reach it on your first attempt. That is expected." He gestured toward the two older students who now sat mounted on the tandem broom, hovering just off the edge of the platform with the unhurried competence of a pair who had done this dozens of times. A third assistant hovered nearby on a single broom. "When you fall — and you will fall — they will collect you. The water is cold but you will not be cold for long."

He looked at the fourth assistant — a young blonde Gryffindor who stood on the main platform holding her wand. "Miss Ashworth will take care of that."

She nodded.

Da Senna stepped aside.

For a moment, nobody moved. Twenty-odd first-years looked at the plank, looked at the water beneath it — black, still, and entirely indifferent to their feelings about the situation — and then looked at each other.

Ewan MacIntyre broke the silence by walking to the front of the line with a determined stride — hesitation was a problem best solved by not engaging in it.

He climbed the five stairs. The elevated platform was small — barely enough room for one person and a broom — and from up here the perspective changed. The main deck below looked further away than it should have. The pier stretched back toward the distant shore like a long, thin arm. And ahead, the plank extended over nothing, its rough surface ending in open air above water that was very deep and very dark.

Ewan walked to the end of the plank. It flexed slightly beneath his weight. Below him, the loch waited still.

He set the angle of his broom. Fifteen degrees.

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He jumped.

The broom caught the air and surged forward — faster than he had expected, the acceleration immediate and startling, the wind pressing against his face and chest with a force that made his eyes water. The platform fell away behind him. The water rushed beneath, dark and close, the surface blurring with speed. For perhaps half a second he was flying — genuinely, unambiguously flying — the broom humming beneath him, the loch enormous and glittering and impossibly open.

Then the nose dipped.

The descent was not dramatic. It was the gentle, inevitable surrender of a broom whose rider did not yet know how to sustain the angle — a slow forward tilt, the tail rising, the water coming up to meet him with a calm that felt almost polite. Ewan had enough time to think *well, that was more than I expected* before the surface hit him, a shocking, full-body cold that drove the breath from his lungs and filled his ears with a muffled roar.

He surfaced, gasping, his hair plastered flat, his broom floating beside him.

Twenty metres. It was, as first flights go, a very respectable distance.

The tandem broom was beside him within seconds, one of the pilots leaning sideways with a practised, extended arm. “Grab the shaft — like a branch. Both hands. Up you come.”

The solo flyer retrieved Ewan’s broom from the water and carried it back to the platform. Ewan arrived a moment later, dripping copiously, his grin suggesting that the cold had not remotely dampened his enthusiasm.

Gale Ashworth was already waiting. She raised her wand.

“*Calefacio.*”

The cold left him like a retreating tide — the chill in his bones, the ache in his fingers, the sharp bite in his chest — all of it replaced by a spreading, deeply pleasant warmth that started at his core and moved outward until even his soaking shoes felt comfortable. Small plumes of vapour rose from his robes.

“*Exsicca vestimenta!*”

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The water vanished from his clothes in a matter of seconds, the fabric going from dark and heavy to light and dry with a speed that felt faintly miraculous. Ewan looked down at himself, entirely dry, entirely warm, and let out a laugh.

“That,” he said to no one in particular, “was brilliant.”

Philippa was next. She set her angle with care, jumped cleanly, held the line for a long, promising stretch, and then over-corrected a slight drift to the left, the broom rolling sideways and depositing her in the loch with a splash that was, by the standards of the morning, almost graceful. Eighteen metres.

Celine followed. She stood at the end of the plank for longer than Philippa had, looking not at the water but at the sky above it, and when she jumped her face held an expression of pure, reckless delight that lasted precisely until the broom began to descend, at which point it was replaced by an expression of pure, reckless alarm. Twelve metres. She came back to the platform laughing so hard that Gale had to wait for her to hold still before casting the drying charm.

Thomas’s first attempt was short and violent. He launched well — the broom leapt from the plank with a force that drew a murmur from the students watching — but his grip was too tight, his correction too sharp, and the *Wayfarer* pitched sideways and dumped him after barely ten metres. He surfaced, shook the water from his hair, and said nothing. On his second attempt, he made twenty-five.

Cassian Sterling jumped while looking up. It was not clear whether this was deliberate or simply the natural consequence of being Cassian Sterling, but the result was a surprisingly stable flight — eyes on the horizon rather than the water beneath — that carried him a respectable distance before ending in the usual manner. He emerged from the loch with perfect calm, as though the experience were an interesting data point rather than a personal failure.

The rounds continued. Each attempt was longer than the last — not always for the same student, but collectively, the average crept upward. Brooms stayed airborne for five seconds, then eight, then twelve. The falls became less dramatic, the corrections less wild. A rhythm established itself: the climb, the walk, the jump, the flight, the splash, the rescue, the warmth. The *Calefacio* charm began to feel less like first aid and more like a small, earned comfort — the warm handshake at the end of an honest effort.

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Ashworth, who had begun the morning performing the spells with brisk, professional efficiency, was smiling by the tenth student. By the twentieth, she was applauding with the rest of them.

Edmund Varre, on his third attempt, reached the buoy.

The platform went quiet as he approached it, his broom steady, his angle good, the red-painted wood growing larger in front of him. He passed it on the left side, began the turn — and the broom's tail swung wide, the radius too tight, his weight shifting to the outside of the curve. The correction came too late. He slashed sideways across the surface, throwing a spectacular arc of spray, and his wand flew from his hand and landed in the loch a good twenty metres from where he surfaced.

He came back to the platform without the wand. One of the solo flyers retrieved it a minute later, dripping. Edmund accepted it, wrung the water from his sleeve, and said, with quiet dignity, "The turn needs work."

Barnabus Finch was, in most respects, an unlikely candidate for the first completed circuit. The round-faced boy was not particularly athletic, and his first two attempts had ended in splashes that were enthusiastic in their volume if modest in their distance. But on his fourth try, something settled. His grip was easy, his angle steady, and when the buoy came he took it wide — a gentle, sweeping arc rather than a sharp turn, the broom banking smoothly, the tail holding its line.

He came around the far side. The broom straightened. He was heading back.

The platform went silent. Not the held-breath silence of tension, but the watching silence of a group that has just realised something is about to happen.

Barnabus crossed the distance in a clean, unwavering line. His speed was modest — he was not fast, and did not try to be — but the flight was steady, balanced, and entirely under control. The platform grew larger ahead of him. The faces of his classmates grew distinct.

He landed on the wooden deck with a soft thud, both feet finding the planks, the broom still humming beneath him.

Dry.

For a single, suspended moment, nobody moved.

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Then the platform erupted. The sound was enormous — cheers, whistles, stamping feet that made the wooden structure shake — and Barnabus stood in the middle of it looking slightly stunned, as though he had not entirely decided whether to be proud or embarrassed and had settled, for the moment, on a combination of both that manifested as a very wide, very red-faced grin.

Da Senna, standing at the edge of the platform, brought his hands together three times — quiet, measured claps that carried no less warmth for their restraint.

Cassian Sterling completed the circuit shortly after, his line steady and his gaze, characteristically, fixed on a point somewhat above the practical horizon. After that, the thing that had been impossible became merely difficult, and then achievable, and then — one by one, round by round — achieved. Each returning student was met with cheers that grew louder and less surprised and more purely joyful as the morning wore on, the applause of a group that had discovered it was capable of something it had not been capable of an hour ago.

Colum made it look easy when his turn came — his flight clean and grounded, his turn around the buoy taken at a sensible radius, his landing on the platform accompanied by a modest nod that drew, inevitably, the loudest cheer of the morning, which turned his face the colour of a ripe apple.

Thomas's fifth attempt was the one that worked. The *Wayfarer* moved differently when he stopped fighting it — the dark wood responsive and alive beneath his hands, the broom's natural balance finding his own. He took the buoy at speed, the turn sharper than Barnabus's but controlled, the loch blurring beneath him, and returned to the platform with his pale hair — he had not noticed the shift — catching the late morning sun.

"Well done," da Senna said. "Very well done, everyone."

He waited for the last of the cheers to subside, then raised his voice. "But anyone can fly forward. More tricky is to hover still."

He mounted his broom, rose a metre from the deck, and held his position — perfectly, absolutely motionless — as though the air beneath him had solidified into glass. The broom did not drift. He did not sway. He simply hung there, still and patient, the loch stretching out behind him.

"Hovering," he said, from his position in the air, "is what happens when you

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fly forward slower and slower until you stop. You keep the balance. You keep the slight inclination. But you let the speed fall away until there is none, and then — you stay.”

He descended and looked at the class. “Who would like to be first?”

Twenty voices answered at once, a chorus of high-pitched, eager shouts that collided in the cold air and became a single, indistinguishable noise of enthusiasm. Da Senna’s expression suggested he had expected precisely this.

He pointed at Barnabus. “Mr. Finch. Fly toward the buoy. Halfway there, begin to raise the nose — gently, slowly — and let yourself decelerate until you are still.”

What followed was, by any objective measure, a catastrophe — but it was a catastrophe conducted in excellent spirits.

Barnabus launched well, pulled up too sharply, and the broom reared beneath him like a startled horse, tipping him backward into the water. Philippa attempted a gradual slowdown and drifted sideways off the broom instead, describing a slow, almost peaceful arc into the loch. Thomas, overcompensating again, sent the *Wayfarer* shooting forward out from under him when he pulled up — the broom sailed nearly to the buoy before one of the assistants caught it, while Thomas dropped vertically into the water with a directness that at least had the merit of efficiency.

Cassian stalled beautifully but forgot about lateral drift and tipped sideways. Julian achieved something close to a hover for two full seconds before a gust of wind — barely enough to stir a flag — dislodged him with a yelp. Celine decelerated smoothly, stopped, hung in the air for one radiant, astonished heartbeat, and then burst out laughing, which broke her concentration entirely and dropped her straight down.

The *Calefacio* charm flowed like wine. Gale’s wand arm must have ached, but her smile did not falter.

Da Senna watched from the platform with his arms folded, quietly satisfied — everything was unfolding exactly as he had expected. The older student assistants, who had spent the morning in professional, efficient silence, had by now abandoned all pretence of detachment and were cheering alongside the first-years after every attempt.

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Laura Orwell was the first to hold it.

She flew out, decelerated in a smooth, continuous curve, and stopped. The broom hung motionless above the dark water, Laura's body perfectly still, her balance absolute. She held the position for five seconds, then ten, the only movement the faint stirring of her dark hair in the wind off the loch. Then she turned, flew back, and landed on the platform without a word.

Elara succeeded not long after, her hover slightly lower and slightly less steady than Laura's but held with a calm, focused stillness that seemed to come from the same place as her art — a patience for the thing in front of her, a willingness to wait until it was right. Celine followed, finding the balance she had lost to laughter on her previous attempt, and this time she did not laugh — she simply hovered, her face bright with a quiet, private wonder, and the cheers that met her return were warm and real.

After that, the dam broke. One by one, the first-years found the stillness — some quickly, some after five or six more rounds of trying — and each success was met with the same noise, the same stamping and clapping and whistling that shook the wooden platform and carried out across the still surface of the loch.

The sun sat higher in the sky by the time da Senna raised his hand.

“That is enough for today.”

The cheering subsided, though the energy did not — it hummed in the group like a plucked string, the residual excitement of a morning that had delivered more than any of them had expected.

Da Senna called the first-years to gather around him. He stood with his broom held loosely at his side, his expression warm but not effusive — genuinely pleased and seeing no reason to exaggerate the fact.

“You have done very well,” he said. “All of you. A very good first class.”

He let the compliment land, then continued. “I have instructed one of my assistants to be present by the lake each day between prime and terce. If you wish to practise your flight outside of class hours, I encourage you to do so.” His expression sharpened, just slightly. “But flying over the lake without supervision is strictly forbidden for all first-years. This is not a suggestion.”

He looked at them — twenty-odd flushed, wind-bitten, slightly damp faces



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looking back at him with the bright, undivided attention of children who had just discovered something extraordinary about the world and about themselves.

“There are more than wands in the wizarding world,” he said.

He picked up his broom, tucked it under his arm, and walked back down the pier toward the shore, his assistants falling into step behind him.

The group dispersed slowly, in the way that groups do when no one quite wants the thing to be over. Some lingered on the platform, talking in twos and threes, replaying their flights with the breathless, overlapping narration of the recently amazed. Others started the long walk back up the slope toward the castle, their brooms over their shoulders or dragged along the grass behind them.

Celine walked beside Philippa, her shoes squelching faintly and her face still carrying the afterglow of the morning. She tilted her head back and looked at the sky, pale and enormous above the mountains, and smiled at nothing in particular.

“I want to go again,” she said.

## The Gambeson

The message arrived during lunch — a folded slip of parchment, passed down the Gryffindor table by a prefect who had received it from a second-year who had received it from a house-elf who had received it from nobody could say. The instruction was brief: all first-year students were to report to the Defence Against the Dark Arts classroom on the third floor immediately following the meal. No further explanation was given.

“That’s odd,” Reza said, reading over Thomas’s shoulder. “Defence isn’t until None.”

“So why do they want us there early?” Colum said.

“I suppose we’ll find out,” Philippa said, folding her napkin with unhurried composure.

They climbed the stairs to the third floor in a loose, mixed procession —

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Gryffindors, Hufflepuffs and Ravenclaws converging from different staircases, a few Slytherins already ahead of them, moving with the wary curiosity of students summoned without context. The corridor was wide and well-lit by tall, narrow windows that let in the pale afternoon light and a persistent draught.

The Defence Against the Dark Arts classroom was large — larger than Thomas had expected, and sparer. The ceiling was high and vaulted, crossed by heavy stone ribs, and the walls were bare grey masonry broken only by the windows and a series of iron sconces holding unlit torches. There was very little decoration. A row of padded training dummies stood against the far wall, their surfaces scarred and scorched from years of spell practice. Beside them, a set of anatomical diagrams — detailed, clinical illustrations of spell damage to human tissue — hung from iron hooks, their parchment yellowed but their content unpleasantly vivid. Two heavy oak desks sat at the front of the room, and the student benches were arranged in a wide semicircle facing them. It was not a room that believed in comfort. The things taught here were not comfortable, and pretending otherwise would be a disservice to the children who needed to learn them.

Professor Ligier was not in it.

Instead, standing behind the oak desks with a knotted cord of measuring rope around his neck and a leather roll of tools spread open before him, was a man in his fifties — tall, with the rolled sleeves and chalk-dusted fingers of a working tradesman. Beside him stood a young woman, perhaps twenty, who shared his blunt features and the same measuring rope around her own neck. Between them, a charmed quill floated above each of two open notebooks, poised and ready.

“Come in, come in,” the man said, beckoning the students forward. “Don’t linger in the doorway. Find a place to stand. My name is William Taylor, and this is my daughter Catherine. We are here to take your measurements.”

The students filed in, exchanging glances. A tailor. They had climbed three flights of stairs to meet a tailor.

“Arms out to the sides, please,” Taylor said. “Chin level. One at a time, starting from the left.”

He did not wait for questions. The moment the first student — Ewan, who had positioned himself at the front of the line because hesitation was never

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his preferred approach — extended his arms, the two measuring ropes leapt from their owners' necks and flew. They moved with startling speed and independence, one snaking around Ewan's shoulders and chest while the other dropped to his waist and hips, cinching and releasing in rapid succession. Behind the Taylors, both quills scratched furiously, recording numbers onto the floating notebooks in a quick, dense hand.

The ropes moved to the next student, and the next. The process was fast — barely a minute per person — and the tapes brooked no resistance. When Celine flinched as the rope whipped around her ribs, Catherine Taylor said, without looking up, "Breathe normally. It knows what it's doing."

"Does it have to know so aggressively?" Celine muttered, holding still.

When the last student had been measured, William Taylor gathered both ropes with a practised flick of his wrist. They coiled themselves neatly around his forearm.

"Your house uniforms — shirts, trousers, dresses, robes, cloaks, hoods and greatcoats, in your respective house colours — will be ready in approximately one week," he announced. "Until then, your plain black uniforms will suffice."

"Now," he said. "The fun part, if you please, Catherine."

Miss Taylor stepped to the side of the room, where four large trunks sat on a heavy table. Each trunk was marked with a distinct emblem — the lion of Gryffindor, the serpent of Slytherin, the eagle of Ravenclaw, the badger of Hufflepuff — and when she unlatched them one by one, the lids swung open to reveal dense, carefully folded stacks of gambesons. Several colour combinations sat within each trunk, all following the palette of their respective house, the quilted fabric thick and professional.

"One each," Miss Taylor said. "Find your house trunk and select your preference."

The students moved forward. Thomas reached into the Gryffindor trunk and lifted out a gambeson. He held it up by the shoulders.

It was enormous.

The sleeves hung a full two feet past his fingertips. The hem would have reached his shins. The shoulders were broad enough for a grown man, and the padded bulk of the thing made it look less like a garment and more like

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a piece of furniture.

Around the room, the same realisation was spreading. Philippa held hers at arm's length and looked at it the way a merchant inspects goods she suspects are defective. Conall turned his over in his hands with quiet confusion. At the Hufflepuff trunk, Barnabus had unfolded his fully, and it pooled on the floor around his feet like a collapsed tent.

"This could fit my father," Barnabus said, looking down at the vast expanse of quilted fabric. He considered. "If my father was really fat."

"Put it on," William Taylor said.

Barnabus looked at him. Taylor's expression did not change.

Barnabus shrugged, gathered the enormous garment, and pulled it over his head.

For a moment he was gone — entirely swallowed, a boy-shaped lump inside a man-sized quilted coat, the hem puddling on the flagstones, the sleeves hanging empty and boneless like the arms of a scarecrow. His voice came from somewhere inside the collar, muffled and indignant: "I can't see any—"

The fabric moved.

It drew inward, smoothly and continuously, the quilted panels tightening across his chest and back, the shoulders narrowing, the sleeves climbing his arms, the hem rising from the floor. The adjustment was not instantaneous — it took perhaps three or four seconds — but it was fluid and seamless, the garment reshaping itself around his body as though it had done this thousands of times. When it finished, Barnabus Finch was standing in a fitted, close-cut gambeson that sat against his frame as though it had been made for him that morning.

He looked down at himself.

"Oh," he said.

No further encouragement was needed. Twenty students pulled their gambesons on simultaneously, and the room filled with the soft, continuous whisper of adjusting fabric — panels contracting, seams realigning, collars finding the precise circumference of each neck. The effect, multiplied across the room, was quietly remarkable.

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“Brilliant,” Griffin said, already running his fingers along the interior stitching, trying to understand the mechanism.

“A gambeson is of no practical use if it does not fit the body’s dimensions exactly,” Taylor said. “The enchantment reads the wearer and adjusts to their precise measurements. Weight, proportion, coverage — all of it scales accordingly. It will continue to adjust as you grow.” He folded the measuring rope over his forearm. “In theory, a gambeson of this quality will last a lifetime.”

He paused.

“In practice, they often don’t last that long.”

He moved on before the silence could settle.

“I’ve heard about these,” Baldwin said, pressing the quilted padding between his fingers. He had read about adaptive gambesons and was now touching one for the first time, and the reverence was visible. “They’re extremely difficult to make. The adaptive enchantment alone takes weeks of layered spellwork. And they’re equally expensive.”

Barnabus, who had been admiring his own reflection in a brass scone, turned sharply. “How expensive?”

Baldwin opened his mouth to answer, but caught himself. He glanced around the room. The question had landed differently than Barnabus intended. Reza, standing near the window in his scarlet-and-gold gambeson, looked at Barnabus without saying a word — but his expression carried everything that needed carrying. He questioned himself whether the cost of the garment they were all wearing so casually was, for his family, an impossible sum. Other students shared the same quiet look — a brief, uncomfortable recognition that the enchanted fabric sitting so perfectly against their bodies represented a quantity of gold that some of their families would never see in a year.

“The uniforms and the gambesons,” William Taylor said, his voice cutting cleanly across the room, “have been paid for in full by the school’s patrons. You owe nothing.”

The relief in the room was palpable — not dramatic, not spoken, but present in the way several pairs of shoulders dropped a fraction of an inch.

“The gambesons in particular,” Taylor continued, packing his shears into

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their leather roll, “were specifically requested by Professor Hugh Ligier.” He glanced up. “The younger,” he added — he had known both. “And generously provided by a Mr. Fox.”

Thomas adjusted the collar of his gambeson. His hands were steady, his face neutral. Beside him, Efe Adeyemi’s expression shifted — a small, private warmth — and his eyes met Thomas’s for a fraction of a second. Neither spoke. Neither needed to.

Miss Taylor stepped forward, carrying a canvas bag that clinked softly with metal fittings. She upended it onto the nearest desk. Out tumbled a collection of leather belts — some brown, some black — each fitted with a simple, sturdy loop designed to hold a wand at the hip.

“One each,” she said. “Your choice of colour.”

Conall was the first to move. He selected a black belt without hesitation, threaded it through the loops of his gambeson, and buckled it. Thomas chose a brown one. He turned it over in his hands, considering, and then fitted it upside down — the wand loop sitting on his left hip, angled so that his left hand could draw cleanly. He tested the motion once, his fingers finding the loop and pulling an invisible wand free, and nodded to himself.

Griffin was already holding his belt at arm’s length, squinting at the stitching, working out how to fit three or four wand loops onto the leather.

Julian put his gambeson on, fastened his belt, and crossed the room to the mirror that hung in the corner. He turned once, checked the line of the shoulders, adjusted the collar a fraction, and appeared satisfied with the result. Colum watched him do this and said nothing, but the corner of his mouth moved.

When the last belt had been claimed, William Taylor gathered his tools and nodded to his daughter. Catherine collected the floating notebooks — now dense with measurements — and tucked them under her arm. They moved toward the door without hurry. The work was done.

At the threshold, Taylor turned back.

“Professor Ligier will be with you at None. I suggest you keep the gambesons on.” He paused. “You’ll also want to keep them on afterwards, for the wanded banquet.”

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The room stirred.

“The wanded banquet?” Conall asked.

Taylor allowed himself a small, knowing expression that was not quite a smile but occupied the same territory. “You’ll see,” he said. “It’s quite a Hogwarts tradition, I’ve heard.”

He left. The door closed behind him.

The room was quiet for a moment — the particular quiet of twenty children standing in armour they hadn’t expected to receive, in a classroom whose scarred training dummies and clinical diagrams of spell damage suddenly seemed more relevant than they had five minutes ago.

Then conversation returned, cautiously at first, then with gathering warmth. Students compared their house colours, tested the range of movement in the quilted sleeves, drew and re-holstered their wands from the new belt loops. Philippa was already examining the construction of the wand loop, her expression suggesting she intended to understand exactly how much force it could withstand. Mæve was reading the anatomical diagrams on the wall, her expression caught between fascination and horror — the work illustrated on those parchments was exactly the kind of damage she intended learning to mend.

In the corner of the room, where the afternoon light from the tall windows fell in long, pale rectangles across the stone floor, Elara O’Connell sat down on the end of a bench. She opened her sketchbook on her knee and laid out her materials beside her — a stick of charcoal, a nub of white chalk, a small ceramic dish holding ground ochre, and a folded paper of powdered azurite, blue as a summer sky. She uncorked a tiny bottle of binding medium, its smell sharp and clean.

She looked at the room. The gambesons. The belts. The house colours catching the window light. The training dummies behind them, patient and scarred. The children standing straighter than they had ten minutes ago, not because anyone had told them to, but because the weight of the quilted fabric on their shoulders had done something to the way they held themselves — something small, something they probably hadn’t noticed yet.

She began to draw.



## Feather

Professor Ligier arrived at None precisely.

He entered through the side door — not the main entrance the students had used — and crossed the room without greeting them. He was tall and lean, and he moved with a controlled, unhurried economy — every gesture deliberate, nothing wasted, the habits of dangerous places worn into the body. His gambeson was a worn, creamy white with green edging along the front opening, collar, and cuffs, and a small Slytherin crest embroidered over the left breast. A wand sat at his left hip. A second — shorter, thicker — was strapped to his right forearm beneath the sleeve, visible only as a faint ridge against the quilted fabric.

He set a canvas satchel on the front desk and began unpacking it. Out came a wooden box the size of a bread loaf, a cloth bundle that clinked softly, a leather pouch, a small ceramic pot of black ink, a sheaf of parchment, and — one by one, laid in a neat row — a collection of long white feathers. He



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counted them without looking at the students, his lips moving slightly.

When the desk was arranged to his satisfaction, he picked up the feathers and walked the semicircle, placing one on the bench in front of each student. The feathers were goose quills, white, their shafts straight and their barbs undisturbed.

He returned to the front of the room and stood with his hands at his sides.

“The only spell you will need today,” he said, “is *Wingardium Leviosa*.”

His Latin was precise, clipped, and carried beneath it the low vowels of Norman French.

A murmur ran through the class. Several students exchanged looks of unmistakable relief — a charm they had already practised, a spell with no sharp edges. Others, Aiko among them, looked faintly disappointed, their expectations of the Defence Against the Dark Arts classroom recalibrating downward with visible reluctance.

Ligier watched the murmur pass through the room and did not react to it.

“Trust me,” he said. “It will be more than enough for the first class.”

He drew his wand from his hip and held it over the feather he had kept for himself. He made the movements slowly, deliberately, exaggerating each component: the swish broad and theatrical, the flick sharp and high, the syllables drawn out so that every student in the room could hear the precise shape of each vowel.

“*Win-GAR-dium Levi-O-sa*.”

The feather rose. It climbed smoothly from the desk, rotating once on its axis, and hung in the air at the level of Ligier’s chest — motionless, perfectly still, as though the air around it had thickened into glass.

He held it there for a moment. Then he lowered his wand and the feather drifted back down, as though it had nowhere else to be.

“Now you.”

The room filled with the sound of twenty wands being drawn from twenty new belt loops with varying degrees of confidence. Swishes cut the air. The syllables rose in an overlapping, slightly ragged chorus — *Wingardium*

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*Leviosa, Wingardium Leviosa* — and across the semicircle, feathers began to move.

Six rose on the first attempt — perhaps seven, depending on whether one counted Cassian's, which lifted two inches, drifted sideways, and settled back down gently. Laura Orwell's feather climbed without hesitation, as steady and controlled as Ligier's demonstration, and hung in the air at precisely the same height. Julian's rose with a fluid elegance that suggested the wand movement had been practised in front of a mirror.

Thomas's feather shot to the ceiling.

It left the desk like a crossbow bolt — a white blur that covered the distance to the vaulted stone above in less than a second and struck the masonry with a faint, pathetic *tick* before tumbling back down, spinning end over end, and landing on the floor three benches away from where it had started.

Nobody laughed. Several students glanced at Thomas, then at Ligier, then back at their own feathers.

Thomas retrieved the quill. He set it on the bench in front of him, adjusted his grip on his wand, and tried again.

The feather flew sideways. It crossed the width of the classroom in a flat, horizontal streak, passing over the heads of two Ravenclaws who ducked instinctively, and struck the far wall with a soft tap before drifting to the floor.

Thomas said nothing. His jaw tightened, very slightly, in a way that only Colum — sitting beside him — was close enough to notice.

By the time the rest of the class had achieved a stable levitation, Thomas was on his fourth attempt. The feather rose — not gently, not smoothly, but it rose, and it held, trembling faintly in the air like a thing that was being restrained rather than lifted. It was not elegant. It was not still. But it was, by the definitions that mattered, levitating.

Ligier watched from the front of the room. His expression did not change.

“Good,” he said, when the last feather was airborne. “Now — put your wands down.”

The feathers descended, one by one, as the students lowered their arms and

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placed their wands on the benches in front of them. The room went quiet, waiting for what came next.

“The same spell,” Ligier said. “Without the wand.”

The silence deepened. Twenty students looked at their hands, then at their feathers, then at Ligier, then back at their hands.

Thomas raised his left hand. He did not think about it, precisely — the motion was older than thought, something the body knew before the mind had time to interfere. He felt for the spell the way a musician feels for a note — not by searching, but by knowing where it already was. His fingers opened, palm upward, and the feather rose.

It climbed smoothly, silently, and stopped. It did not tremble. It did not drift. It hung in the air above his palm with a stillness so absolute that it looked painted there — more controlled, more certain, more completely *his* than anything the wand had produced.

The room turned to look at him.

“Very good, Mr. Blackwood,” Ligier said. His tone was level, unimpressed in the way that suggested he had expected precisely this result and was merely confirming it. “The rest of you — try.”

What followed was a slow, uneven accumulation of small successes. Colum’s feather twitched. Astrid’s rose an inch, hung for a heartbeat, and fell. Reza’s drifted upward in a lazy, spiralling ascent that seemed to surprise him more than anyone. Celine managed a brief, wobbling hover that drew a gasp from herself and a quiet smile from Philippa, who had not yet moved her own feather at all but was observing everyone else’s attempts with a cataloguing attention.

One by one, student after student, the feathers began to rise — haltingly, briefly, without the clean authority of Thomas’s effortless display, but rising nonetheless. Each success drew a small reaction from the students nearby — a nod, a whispered word of encouragement, a grin.

Laura was the last.

She sat very still, her pale hands open in front of her, the feather resting on the bench undisturbed. Around her, feathers floated at various heights and with various degrees of stability, and her classmates were beginning to relax

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into the novelty of the thing. Laura's jaw was set, her blue eyes fixed on the quill with an intensity that was almost physical in its weight. She was not struggling visibly — she was simply not succeeding, and for Laura Orwell, the distinction was meaningless.

The feather stirred. It rocked once on its shaft, then lifted — barely, perhaps a finger's width above the wood — and held. Her hands were rigid, her shoulders taut, and the effort was visible in a way it had not been with the wand. But it was done.

Ligier waited until she had held it for a full three seconds before he spoke.

“Good,” he said. The word carried no particular warmth, but neither did it carry pity, which was — from Ligier — perhaps the greater kindness.

He returned to the front desk and opened the wooden box.

Inside, arranged in cloth-lined compartments, were small geometric shapes — cubes, spheres, triangles, cylinders — carved from pale wood and polished smooth. He lifted out a second object: a flat board, roughly the size of a serving platter, into which matching holes had been cut. A cube-shaped hole, a round hole, a triangular slot, a cylindrical channel. The shapes and their corresponding openings were sized for small hands — clearly, unmistakably, a children's toy.

He held it up.

“Using your wands,” he said, “place each shape through its corresponding hole.”

The reaction was immediate and unfavourable. A ripple of indignation passed through the class — the particular offence of eleven-year-olds who have just been issued armour and belt-holstered wands being asked to play with an infant's puzzle. Hector's expression tightened with aristocratic disdain. Ewan opened his mouth to make a comment, reconsidered, and closed it again.

Ligier distributed the sets without acknowledging the mood. One box and one board per student. He waited until the last set had been placed, and then stepped back.

“Begin.”

Laura's wand moved with surgical precision. The first shape — the cube —

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rose from its compartment, rotated to align with the square opening, and dropped through with a clean, soft *clack*. The sphere followed. Then the triangle, the cylinder, and the rest — each one lifted, turned, and placed with speed and precision. The entire sequence took perhaps thirty seconds. She set her wand down and folded her hands in her lap.

It had looked almost easy.

Julian followed her — his wand movements fluid and exact, the shapes rotating with a dancer's control. One by one, the rest of the class engaged with the task, and the indignation evaporated as they discovered that the children's toy was, in fact, considerably more difficult than it appeared. Levitating a feather required lifting a nearly weightless object straight up. Levitating a wooden cube, rotating it to the correct angle, and guiding it into a hole that was only slightly larger than the shape itself required something altogether different — a continuous, three-dimensional awareness of the object's position, its orientation, and the precise amount of force being applied in each direction simultaneously.

Shapes clattered against boards, bounced off edges, and rolled across benches. Barnabus sent a sphere ricocheting off his board and into Mæve's lap. Celine's triangle refused to rotate and hung stubbornly in the air at the wrong angle, vibrating with the intensity of her focus.

Thomas destroyed the first box, and the second.

The cube lifted cleanly enough, but the force behind it was — as with the feather — disproportionate to the task. It struck the board at speed, punched through the square hole, split the wood beneath it, and embedded itself in the bench. Thomas looked at the damage, exhaled slowly, and raised his hand to request a replacement. The new board lasted longer. He managed the cube and the sphere before a misdirected cylinder cracked the board along the grain and sent two pieces spinning to the floor.

On the third set, he completed the task. It was not elegant. Several of the shapes bore the marks of impacts with the board's edges, and the final cylinder went through its hole with more force than finesse. But it was done.

When the last student had finished, Ligier collected his wand.

“Wandless.”

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Thomas's hands moved before the word had finished settling. The cube rose from the box, turned in the air, and dropped through its hole with a precision that bordered on the mechanical. The sphere followed. Then the triangle, the cylinder, the rest — each shape lifted, aligned, and placed with the same effortless fluency, his fingers making small, economical gestures that guided the objects as naturally as if he were touching them directly. The whole sequence was nearly as fast as doing it by hand.

He set his palms on the bench and waited.

Around him, the wandless attempts began. The results were — predictably — worse. Shapes drifted, wobbled, refused to rotate.

Laura's jaw was set again. The cube rose, slowly, unsteadily — the control she commanded with a wand entirely absent from her bare hands. She guided it toward the board, overcorrected, and the cube veered left. She brought it back. It reached the opening, rotated — too far — and struck the edge. She tried again. The cube clipped the corner of the board and tumbled onto the bench.

She retrieved it with a sharp flick of her fingers and started over. This time, the triangle escaped her grip entirely and flew across the room in a flat arc, striking Ewan in the shoulder. The gambeson absorbed the impact without complaint. Ewan glanced down at his arm, then at Laura, and wisely said nothing.

More shapes flew. A cylinder bounced off Griffin's bench. A sphere rolled across the floor between Philippa's feet.

Laura finished last again. The final shape — the cylinder — dropped through its hole with a force that cracked the board's edge, and she sat back with an expression that dared anyone in the room to comment.

Nobody did.

Ligier walked to the front desk and opened the cloth bundle. Inside were needles — long, sturdy sewing needles, each the length of a finger — and spools of coarse thread. He laid them out in pairs.

Then he reached beneath the desk and produced a wooden crate. He opened it and lifted out a set of goggles — heavy leather frames fitted with thick, clear glass lenses, the kind that a broom flyer might wear. He held them up.

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“Put these on before you begin.”

The students took their goggles and fitted them over their eyes. The leather was stiff and smelled of tallow, and the lenses made the room slightly amber.

“Thread the needle,” Ligier said. “With your wand.”

The task was straightforward in description and excruciating in practice. The thread had to be lifted, straightened, guided through a hole barely wider than itself, and pulled through — all at a distance of three feet, using only a wand. The margin for error was functionally zero.

Laura completed it on her first attempt. The thread rose from the spool, straightened into a rigid line, passed through the eye of the needle, and — before anyone had quite registered what was happening — looped back and tied itself into a small, neat knot. She set the needle down.

Thomas’s thread hit the needle on the first attempt. Not the eye — the shaft. The needle spun off the desk, flew point-first toward Griffin’s bench, and struck the glass of his goggles with a sharp, bright *ping* that drew a yelp of surprise and a very rapid reassessment of Ligier’s decision to provide eye protection.

“Bloody hell,” Griffin said, touching the unscratched lens.

More needles flew. The room filled with the sound of small metallic impacts — *ping, tick, clink* — as threads missed their targets and needles were launched from desks by misdirected force. Astrid’s went straight up and stuck in the ceiling, where it remained for the rest of the lesson, glinting in the torchlight like a tiny stalactite.

The goggles earned their keep many times over.

When the wandless round came, the room had already accepted the pattern. Thomas threaded the needle on his first attempt — the thread rising from the spool and passing through the eye with the same effortless, almost meditative control that characterised all his wandless work. Laura’s thread refused to straighten. It curled, sagged, drifted sideways, approached the eye and missed, approached again and missed again. On her sixth attempt, it passed through, and she pulled it taut with a sharp, victorious motion that suggested the thread had been personally offensive to her.

The final task was a quill and ink.

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Ligier placed a sheet of paper, a fresh quill, and a small ceramic pot of black ink in front of each student. The instruction was simple: dip the quill in the ink and write your name. With your wand.

The quill presented a new problem. Unlike the feather, which merely needed to rise, or the shapes, which merely needed to be placed, the quill required *continuous, fine manipulation* — a sustained, moving grip that had to lift, dip, and then trace letters with legible precision. It was, Thomas realised, as if Ligier had designed the entire afternoon as a single escalating argument: *you think you can control this spell, and you cannot, and I will keep proving it until you believe me.*

Laura wrote her name in a clean, upright hand that could have passed for work done by her own fingers.

Thomas's first attempt sent the ink pot spinning across the desk. A plume of black ink erupted from the ceramic rim and arced through the air in a long, spectacular ribbon that caught the light from the windows beautifully before landing across the front of Barnabus's gambeson. The ink struck the quilted fabric and — to the surprise of everyone except, presumably, William Taylor — slid off it entirely, pooling on the bench beneath as though the surface of the gambeson were made of glass rather than cloth. The fabric remained perfectly, impossibly clean.

“Good gambesons resist dirt, these must be of the best quality” Philippa observed, looking down at the dark puddle on the bench with quiet satisfaction — her earlier close examination of the garment vindicated.

More ink flew. The room became a study in aerodynamic chaos — black droplets sailing in unpredictable arcs, quills dipping too deep and emerging trailing dark comets, parchments smeared beyond legibility. Barnabus dipped his quill, lifted it, and the entire contents of the ink pot followed — a black, wobbling sphere of ink that hung in the air for one suspended, horrified moment before collapsing onto his paper, his bench, and his lap. The gambeson refused every drop.

Thomas wrote his name on the fourth attempt. The letters were legible, though a calligrapher would have had strong opinions about them.

The wandless round followed. Thomas wrote *Thomas Blackwood* in a hand that was — if not beautiful — perfectly steady and entirely controlled. Laura's quill skittered across the parchment, leaving a trail that resembled



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a seismograph more than a signature. She finished, eventually. The *L* was identifiable. The rest required good faith.

When the last student had completed the final task, Ligier returned the materials to the front desk with the same unhurried precision with which he had laid them out. The room was quiet — not the nervous quiet of the lesson's beginning, but the settled quiet of twenty students who had been thoroughly, methodically humbled and were not entirely sure what to make of it.

Ligier stood at the front and looked at them.

"Before I can teach you Defence Against the Dark Arts," he said, "I need you to be completely comfortable with your wands. Not competent. Not adequate. *Comfortable*. I want the wand to feel as natural in your hand as a quill — more natural, eventually. Most wizards cast spells the way most people write letters: with enough skill to be understood, but without any real mastery of the instrument. That is sufficient for most purposes."

He paused.

"It is not sufficient for mine."

He let the words settle. The anatomical diagrams on the wall — the clinical illustrations of spell damage to human tissue — seemed, in the silence, to grow slightly more vivid.

"I also want you to try the same spells without your wands," he continued. "Most wizards are entirely defenceless the moment they are disarmed. I do not intend for that to be the case with my students."

He folded his arms.

"But make no mistake — a tool is always preferred to no tool. A wand is a precision instrument. It focuses, it channels, it multiplies. A wizard who can cast wandless is resourceful. A wizard who *relies* on wandless magic when a wand is available is a fool."

Thomas had the distinct sensation that Ligier was looking at him while making this remark. He kept his eyes forward and his expression neutral.

"Now," Ligier said. "The fun part."

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Philippa, who had heard the phrase for the third time that day, thought privately that Hogwarts could be more creative with its catchphrases.

“From this moment forward,” Ligier said, “I want your wands in your hands. Not on your belts. Not on your desks. In your hands. The wand should be the last thing you hold before you fall asleep at night and the first thing you reach for when you wake in the morning. You will not, however, sleep with it — not in your hand, not under your pillow. Nightmares and wands are a poor combination, and the castle has lost enough furniture over the centuries. You will eat with your wands. You will dress with your wands. You will open doors, carry books, and pour water with your wands. If a task can be done with magic, I want you to do it with magic. If it cannot — hold the wand anyway.”

He looked at them — twenty faces in amber-tinted goggles, ink-stained parchment in front of them, the residue of the afternoon’s disasters still pooling on the benches beneath gambesons that had refused to absorb a single drop.

“You are dismissed, but keep your gambesons”.

Benches scraped. Students rose, stretched, compared their parchments, examined each other’s gambesons for ink damage that did not exist. The mood was lighter than the lesson’s content perhaps warranted — the particular lightness that follows something demanding, when everyone has come out the other side with a story to tell.

Ligier’s voice cut through the movement.

“Miss Orwell. Mr. Blackwood. Stay.”

The room emptied around them. Colum glanced at Thomas on his way out — a look that carried a question and an offer simultaneously — but Thomas shook his head, very slightly, and Colum went. Laura had not moved from her bench. She sat with her hands folded in her lap and her expression perfectly unreadable.

When the door had closed, Ligier crossed the room and stood in front of his daughter.

“Your wand,” he said.

Laura drew it and held it out. Ligier shook his head.

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“Secure it on your belt.”

She slid the wand into the loop at her hip. Ligier reached into his satchel and produced a strip of linen cloth, pale and clean. He took Laura’s right hand — her wand hand — and wrapped the cloth around her palm and fingers with practised efficiency — quick, firm, the muscle memory of field dressings. When the hand was covered, he touched the cloth with his wand, and the linen stiffened, binding itself to her hand in a way that was clearly enchanted and clearly not coming off without the counter-spell.

Laura looked at her wrapped hand and said nothing. Her expression did not change, but something behind her eyes shifted — a recognition, perhaps, that this was not punishment but something more complicated.

“Now you, Mr. Blackwood.”

Thomas stepped forward. Ligier nodded toward his wand.

“Draw it. Hold it in your left hand.”

Thomas drew his wand — the dark, dense wood warm and familiar against his fingers. Ligier took another strip of linen and wrapped it around Thomas’s hand and the wand together, binding the two into a single unit. The spell followed, and the cloth tightened. Thomas flexed his fingers experimentally. The wand was fixed in his grip — not painfully, but absolutely. He could not release it without the charm being lifted.

Ligier stepped back and looked at Thomas.

“Wandless spells come naturally to you,” he said. His tone was not congratulatory. It was diagnostic — the voice of a man identifying a condition. “That is unusual and it is valuable. But it is also, at this moment, a hindrance. Your wand work is poor because your instincts bypass it. Your body does not believe it needs the instrument, and so it fights the instrument, and you produce—” He gestured, vaguely, toward the ceiling, where Astrid’s needle still glinted. “*That.*”

Thomas said nothing. There was nothing to say.

Ligier turned to Laura.

“And you,” he said. His voice did not soften, exactly, but it lowered — the slight modulation of a man speaking to his daughter while trying very hard to

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He spoke to his student. “I underestimated the effect of growing up at Hogwarts. You have spent eleven years surrounded by wands, watching wands, learning from wands. Your magic lives in the instrument. Without it—” He glanced at her wrapped hand. “Without it, you are starting from the beginning.”

Laura met his eyes. The blue of hers against the dark of his held for a moment — the particular, loaded silence between a parent and child who understood each other well enough to argue without speaking.

“Unlike your classmates,” Ligier said, looking at both of them now, “you will not practise both wanded and wandless magic. Miss Orwell — you will perform only wandless spells until I remove that binding. Mr. Blackwood — you will perform only wanded spells until I remove yours.”

He paused.

“And I want you to teach each other.”

Laura looked at Thomas. Thomas looked at Laura. They wore the identical disapproval expressions of teenagers who has just smelled a fart — a slow, involuntary horror that began at the nose and spread outward until it occupied the entire face.

Ligier, to his credit, did not smile. But the corner of his mouth moved — once, briefly — before settling back into its customary line.

“I am confident in your ability to do so,” he said. “You may go.”

They went. Laura turned left in the corridor. Thomas turned right. Neither looked back.

“Bye Love.” Said professor Ligier to his daughter.

“Bye daddy.” Said Laura to her father.

## Wanded Banquet

The castle bell struck six times, the deep, bronze voice of it rolling down through the stone corridors and settling into the bones of the building. Vespers. The sound reached the Defence Against the Dark Arts classroom through two feet of masonry and arrived diminished but unmistakable, cutting

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through the last of the post-lesson conversation like a blade through cloth.

Thomas flexed his left hand — or tried to. The wand was still there, bound tight against his palm and fingers by Ligier's linen strip, the enchanted fabric warm and immovable. Across the corridor, Laura emerged from the classroom with her right hand held slightly away from her body, the wrapped fist carried with the careful, self-conscious rigidity. They did not speak. They walked in the same direction because the Great Hall was in the same direction, and for no other reason that either of them would have admitted to.

The first thing Thomas noticed, as they descended the main staircase with the general flow of students heading toward supper, was the goggles.

A group of fourth-years was crossing the entrance hall ahead of them, and every one of them was wearing heavy leather-and-glass goggles pushed up onto their foreheads. They were laughing — the warm, knowing laughter of people heading into something they remembered very well. One of them caught Thomas's eye, glanced at his gambeson, and grinned in a way that was equal parts welcome and condolence.

Then Thomas saw the armour.

A sixth-year boy was descending the opposite staircase in a full suit of plate armour — breastplate, pauldrons, vambraces, greaves, the works — polished to a theatrical shine and worn over what appeared to be his school robes. His visor was up. He was eating an apple. Beside him, a girl in a gambeson and goggles was shaking her head slowly, but she was smiling. Further along the corridor, two more older students clanked past in mismatched pieces of armour — one wearing a single gauntlet on his left hand and nothing else of note, the other in a full chainmail hauberk that reached his knees and produced a continuous, silvery rustling as he walked.

"Is that —" Laura began.

"I think so," Thomas said.

They entered the Great Hall.

The four long house tables were dressed in their usual arrangement — bare oak, no tablecloths, the wood dark and scarred from centuries of use. Tablecloths, as every student learned in their first week, were reserved for ceremonial occasions: the Sorting Feast, the end-of-year banquet, and certain holidays.

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Ordinary meals were served on the naked wood, and the wood bore the evidence of it.

But the seating was not ordinary.

At the near end of the hall, a full section of one of the long tables had been set apart — separated from the nearest older students by a good thirty metres of empty bench — twenty places had been laid. Not Gryffindor places, not Hufflepuff places, not Ravenclaw or Slytherin places. Twenty places, together, for twenty first-years.

No house colours marked the section. No banners hung above it. It was simply a stretch of table with plates and cups and the implicit understanding that whoever sat there belonged to each other before they belonged to their houses.

The first-years arrived in ones and twos and small, mixed clusters — Gryffindors walking with Ravenclaws, Hufflepuffs beside Slytherins, the house boundaries that had been drawn the night before already softened by a single day of shared classes. Colum and Thomas reached the table together and sat near the centre. Celine slid onto the bench across from them, Philippa beside her. Baldwin appeared at Colum's shoulder, spectacles slightly askew behind the goggles. Barnabus arrived eating something he had apparently obtained between the third floor and the ground floor by means that remained unclear.

Laura, after a moment's hesitation that was brief enough to be almost invisible, took the place on the bench to Thomas's left.

They were still wearing their gambesons and goggles. Everyone was.

Colum looked at the reserved section — the twenty places, all houses together, the empty gap between them and the older students. He looked at the older students in their armour and goggles, thirty metres away, laughing. He looked at the quantity of food that was being laid out in front of them.

"Thomas," he said quietly.

"I see it."

The platters arriving at the first-year section were enormous. Meat pies — whole ones, their crusts golden and steaming — were set down in a row that stretched the full length of the reserved section. Behind them came trenchers of roasted root vegetables, baskets of bread, bowls of thick gravy, crocks

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of butter, wheels of cheese, dishes of honeyed fruits, and — conspicuously, almost aggressively — a towering arrangement of cakes, tarts, and pastries that occupied the centre of the table like a sugary fortress. Thomas counted the platters. He looked at the twenty first-years around him. He looked back at the food. The ratio was absurd — three times what the older students had received at their distant end of the hall, perhaps more.

An hour past Vespers, the plates, glasses, and silverware had been distributed and the last of the serving platters had found their positions. At the far end of the tables, the older students had begun eating with the unhurried composure of people who knew what was coming and were in no particular rush to begin it. Several of them had turned in their seats to watch the first-year section with undisguised anticipation. A second-year girl in a Ravenclaw gambeson was whispering urgently to the boy beside her, both of them grinning.

At the high table, Headmaster Hepburn rose. He did not amplify his voice. He did not need to — the hall had gone quiet on its own, the particular expectant silence of a room that knows it is about to be given permission.

Hepburn smiled. It was the smile of a man who had presided over this moment for more years than most of the students had been alive, and who had not tired of it.

He drew his wand, pointed it at a single sheet of paper on the table before him, and tapped it once. The paper shivered, split, and multiplied — one became two, two became four, four became eight, the sheets dividing with the quiet, urgency of a thing that had somewhere to be. Twenty small squares of paper now sat in a neat stack. Hepburn tapped the stack again, and each square folded itself — rapidly, precisely — into the shape of a small owl. Twenty paper owls sat on the high table, their creased wings held at angles that suggested flight was imminent and patience was not their strong suit.

Hepburn flicked his wand. The owls launched.

They crossed the hall in a wheeling, rustling flock, banked sharply over the Ravenclaw table — drawing a collective flinch from two second-years who remembered their own year too well — and descended upon the first-year section. Each owl found its target, landing on the bench or the table or, in Barnabus's case, directly on top of his head, and then tore itself apart with a decisive rip that left the message exposed and the delivery mechanism in small, fluttering pieces.

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Thomas picked up his fragment of paper. The handwriting was Hepburn's — large, round, and warm, the script wrote the way he spoke.

*The wanded banquet: for you to eat using your wands. It is, though, an excellent opportunity — and excuse — to throw, by mistake of course, a cake in the face of an esteemed colleague who needs more sugar in his life. Let the food wars begin.*

The hall held its breath for exactly one second.

Then Barnabus Finch, who had not finished reading the note but had already identified the nearest meat pie, drew his wand and bellowed “*Wingardium Leviosa!*” with the full-throated conviction of a boy who had been waiting his entire life for official permission to throw food.

The pie rose. It did not rise well — it wobbled, tilted, and shed a quantity of gravy onto the table — but it rose, and the sight of it airborne was all the catalyst the room required.

Nineteen wands came out. The air filled with incantations, with the crack of levitation charms and the wet, heavy sound of food in unpredictable motion. A bread roll sailed past Philippa's ear. A wedge of cheese described a slow, tumbling arc and struck Baldwin squarely in the chest, leaving a yellow smear across his gambeson that the fabric refused to absorb. From down the table, a tart rose with impressive stability and deposited itself — with what could only be described as gentle precision — on the top of Julian Beauchamp's perfectly arranged hair.

At the far end of the hall, the older students erupted in cheers.

Thomas looked at the chaos. He looked at the meat pie in front of him. He looked at the wand bound to his left hand.

He raised the wand, focused on a wedge of pie, and spoke the incantation carefully. “*Wingardium Leviosa.*”

The wedge of pie left the plate like a stone from a catapult. It crossed thirty metres of open hall in a flat, screaming trajectory, trailing gravy and pastry fragments, and struck the invisible barrier of a *Protego* charm with a wet, percussive *thwack* that silenced the nearest tables. A fourth-year student — tall, dark-haired, wand raised — stood behind the shimmering shield, pie



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debris sliding slowly down its surface.

“Good arm,” the fourth-year called out, lowering his shield. “Terrible aim.”

Laura, sitting beside Thomas, had watched the entire sequence with her wrapped right hand resting on the table and an expression that was working its way through disbelief toward something closer to clinical fascination.

“How,” she said, slowly, “can someone be so adept at wandless spells and so completely useless with a wand?”

Thomas set his bound wand hand on the table. “You try, then.”

Laura looked at him. She looked at the pie. She raised her left hand — her unbound hand, the one that had never carried a wand, the one that Ligier had left free precisely because it had never been her instrument — and focused.

A second wedge of meat pie rose from the plate. It wobbled. It drifted. It made a valiant attempt at a controlled trajectory toward the older students. Then the control slipped, the wedge accelerated, and it sailed across the hall in a long, curving arc that bore no resemblance to its intended flight path and struck the same fourth-year squarely on the shoulder.

“*Protego*,” the boy said, far too late. He looked down at his shoulder. He picked up the piece of pie that had landed on his gambeson, examined it with a thoughtful expression, took a bite, and announced to the hall at large: “Not bad. Not bad at all.”

Laura lowered her hand. Her jaw was tight, but there was a flicker in her blue eyes that might, in better light, have been the beginning of a reluctant smile.

She turned to Thomas. “Using a wand,” she said, “is like writing with a quill. Or eating a pudding with a spoon. You could do both with your bare hands, but it would be a mess, wouldn’t it?”

Thomas considered this. “And wandless magic,” he said, “is like eating a chicken leg with bare hands. You could do it with a fork and a knife, but it would be a mess, wouldn’t it?”

Laura looked at him for a long moment. The corner of her mouth moved — once, briefly — before settling back into its customary line.

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“Fair,” she said.

Something shifted between them. Not warmth, exactly — neither of them was built for easy warmth with strangers — but the particular, grudging clarity that comes when two people who are very good at different things recognise that the other’s skill is not an insult to their own but a mirror of their own deficit, held up without malice, in language that left nothing to be misunderstood.

“Show me your grip,” Laura said, nodding toward his bound hand.

Thomas raised his left hand, the wand fixed in its linen binding. Laura studied it with the focused, assessing gaze of a girl who had held a wand since she could walk and understood its mechanics the way a carpenter understands the grain of wood.

“You’re holding it like a weapon,” she said. “You’re bracing against it. It’s not fighting you — you’re fighting it. The shaft should rest here —” she indicated the base of his fingers with her free hand — “and the pressure comes from here, the thumb pad. Not the fist. The wand is not a hammer, Thomas. It is a quill.”

Thomas adjusted. The difference was small — a fraction of an inch in the pressure, a slight loosening in the grip — but when he pointed the wand at a bread roll and spoke the incantation, the roll rose from the plate with a smoothness that was, by the standards of the evening, almost graceful. It wobbled. It drifted slightly left. But it did not rocket across the hall like a siege projectile, and when he set it down on the table, it landed rather than crashed.

“Better,” Laura said. She did not elaborate. From Laura, the absence of criticism was the compliment.

“Your turn,” Thomas said. “Open your hand. Not like a claw — flat. The magic doesn’t need to be gripped. It needs to be directed. Think of it like pointing at something. You don’t grab the air between you and the thing; you just —” he extended his right hand, fingers straight, palm down — “indicate.”

Laura uncurled her left hand. She held it over a small pastry, fingers extended, and focused. The pastry trembled. It rose — barely, an inch perhaps — and hung in the air with a concentration of effort that was visible in the tendons of Laura’s wrist. Then it fell.

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“Again,” Thomas said. “Flatter hand. Less force. You’re pushing the spell out like a shove. It needs to be a breath.”

Laura tried again. The pastry rose higher this time — three inches, then four — and held. It was not steady. It was not elegant. But it was sustained, and when she lowered her hand, the pastry descended rather than dropped.

“A breath,” she repeated, turning the word over.

Thomas nodded. “With a wand, you’re writing each letter of the spell. Without one, you’re saying the whole word at once. You don’t need to pronounce each sound — you just need to mean it.”

The food war continued around them, but they had drifted to the edge of it — two students sitting side by side amid the cheerful carnage, passing food back and forth, each attempt a lesson. Laura would say something precise about wrist angle or follow-through, and Thomas’s next charm would be marginally less violent. Thomas would describe the feeling of wandless casting in terms that were intuitive rather than technical — weight, temperature, direction — and Laura’s next attempt would hold a fraction of a second longer.

There were mistakes. Thomas sent a gravy boat spinning across the table and into Mæve’s lap. Laura’s attempt to levitate a bread roll produced a sharp sideways lurch that deposited it in Cassian’s cup, which Cassian accepted with the equanimity of a boy who had seen stranger things fall from the sky tonight.

And there were *mistakes* — the kind that arrived with suspicious frequency and unerring accuracy at the exact position of Julian Beauchamp’s hair. A dollop of custard, launched by Thomas in what was ostensibly an exercise in controlled trajectory. A fragment of fruit tart, directed by Laura in what she described, with perfect composure, as “a calibration attempt.” A small, beautifully aimed sphere of mashed turnip that neither of them claimed responsibility for and that landed with a soft, definitive *plop* on the crown of Julian’s head, where it sat like a pale, savoury beret.

“His hair,” Laura observed, with the clinical detachment of a naturalist documenting a species under stress, “is remarkably absorbent.”

“It’s a gift,” Thomas agreed.

Elsewhere along the table, the banquet had found its rhythm. Colum and

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Ewan, the two Scots, had enlisted the French — Celine and Philippa — against the English: Hector, Griffin, Cassian, and Efe — who protested but was deemed English enough.

Aiko, further along the bench, was levitating a single grape with surgical focus — waiting, motionless, for the precise moment when her target opened his mouth to speak, and then launching it. She had a hit rate that was, by the end of the evening, genuinely alarming. Griffin had laid three different wands on the table beside an assortment of food and was conducting what appeared to be a systematic trial of which wand threw which food best, a project that produced inconsistent results and a great deal of collateral damage.

At the high table, Headmaster Hepburn had produced his own plate of food and was eating with the serene contentment of a man surveying a battlefield that was going exactly as planned. Beside him, Professor Ravenclaw sat in perfect, untouched stillness, her robes immaculate, her expression suggesting that she had opinions about the proceedings that she was choosing, with considerable restraint, not to share. Professor Grim was watching the first-year section with quiet attention, his eyes moving from student to student, cataloguing. Professor Ligier was not present; his chair was empty. Professor Millan was present but had apparently decided that the floor was a better vantage point than the table — she was sitting cross-legged on the flagstones near the end of the high table, eating a bread roll and watching the food fly with the bright, appreciative eyes of a woman who fundamentally approved of chaos conducted in good spirits.

The evening deepened. The enchanted ceiling shifted from the pale amber of late afternoon through the long, slow graduation of dusk — indigo creeping in from the edges, the first stars appearing, the golden constellations beginning their nightly transit across the painted heavens.

Gradually, the food war ebbed. The ammunition diminished. The trajectories grew lazier, the impacts softer, the laughter quieter. The gambesons, which had taken the full brunt of the evening without complaint, were spotted and streaked with the evidence of a hundred direct hits — gravy, custard, honey, cheese, fruit, and at least one substance that defied identification — and yet the fabric beneath was clean, the quilted surface shedding every drop and stain as though the mess were happening to someone else. The goggles, which had seemed excessive at the start of the evening, had earned their keep many

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times over; Thomas counted at least four occasions on which his lenses had intercepted something that would otherwise have required medical attention.

In the quiet that followed the last of the flying food, Thomas sat with his bound hand resting on the oak table and looked at the wand. Three hours ago, every spell he cast with it had been a small explosion — too much force, too little control, the magic surging through the wood like water through a pipe that was too narrow for the pressure behind it. Now, the last bread roll he had levitated had risen smoothly, traveled in a controlled arc, and landed — more or less — where he had intended it to land. The improvement was not dramatic. It was not mastery. But it was real, and he could feel the difference in his wrist and his fingers — a looseness that had not been there before, a willingness to let the wand lead rather than forcing it to follow.

Beside him, Laura was turning a small apple over in the air above her open left palm. It rotated slowly, steadily, the wandless magic sustaining it with a patience that would have been impossible at the start of the evening. Her face was tight with concentration, but the effort was no longer the clenched, whole-body strain it had been during Ligier's lesson. Something had unlocked. The apple hung in the air like a thing that belonged there.

She set it down on the table, gently.

Neither of them said anything about the improvement. Neither of them needed to.

The castle bell struck nine times — Compline — and the sound was quieter than it had been in the morning, somehow, as though the bell itself had softened with the hour, its bronze voice muffled by the weight of the night above. The enchanted ceiling had long since settled into its fullest darkness, the golden constellations of Orion and Cassiopeia sliding slowly across the heavens, the silver faint and steady.

From the high table, Hepburn rose. He looked out across the hall — the older students at their distant end, the twenty first-years in their single, shared section, the whole room sticky and satisfied and thoroughly, completely happy — and he smiled the smile of a man who had seen this same scene play out for decades and had not once grown tired of it.

“Clean yourselves up,” he said. “The prefects’ baths have been prepared — all seven of them — steam already rising, for those who wish to rid their hair of blueberry, custard, or worse before bed.” He paused, his gaze drifting,

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with the faintest suggestion of intent, toward Julian. “Sleep well.”

They went. But not immediately, and not by house. They went the way the ship had taught them to go — together at first, lingering in the entrance hall, reluctant to split into four directions when they had just spent an evening being one thing. Celine was still laughing about something Barnabus had said. Colum’s ears were still red from a direct hit with a custard tart that Ewan had landed from an improbable distance. Philippa walked beside Mæve, the two of them discussing something in low, serious voices that were entirely at odds with the gravy stains on their gambesons. Cassian was looking up at the real sky through the open doors, comparing it to the enchanted ceiling he had just left. Elara’s sketchbook was tucked under her arm, and even in the torchlight of the entrance hall, Thomas could see that the page she had been working on was full — figures in gambesons, flying food, the warm chaos of the evening rendered in charcoal and ochre.

Eventually, the group began to thin—but not in the way it usually did. Instead of turning off toward their respective houses, they drifted together through the corridors and up the staircases, following a shared, unspoken direction, until they reached the door that led to the prefects’ baths.

Someone murmured the password. The door yielded.

Inside, warmth and steam spilled out to meet them. Beyond lay not a single chamber, but a succession of bathing rooms, each already prepared—water drawn, taps gleaming faintly in the haze, the air thick with heat.

For a moment, they lingered at the threshold, as though uncertain how to undo the evening’s strange unity.

Then, gradually, they arranged themselves—not by house, but by simple necessity: by gender, by space, by who fit where. Conversations continued, split and softened by walls and steam, but not entirely broken.

The evening loosened its grip, little by little, as laughter gave way to quieter voices and the work of washing away blueberry, custard, and the rest.

On his shoulder, an owl-shaped piece of parchment—one of Hepburn’s enchanted notes, slightly crumpled, slightly gravy-stained—fluttered once in the warm air, as though remembering that it had once known how to fly, and then was still.

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Eventually, the group began to form again. Cecile touched Celine's shoulder — a brief, gentle gesture — and headed toward the Hufflepuff corridor, Baldwin and Barnabus falling into step beside her. Cassian and Ewan turned toward the Ravenclaw tower, still arguing amicably about something. Aiko descended the steps toward the dungeons without a word, her posture immaculate, her gambeson spotless.

Thomas reached the foot of the grand staircase. Laura was heading in the opposite direction, toward the Slytherin common room. At the point where their paths diverged, she stopped.

“At Terce tomorrow?” she said, without turning around.

Thomas paused on the first step. “The breakfast?”

“The practice.”

He looked at her — the wrapped hand, the dark hair, the straight back, the absolute refusal to frame the request as anything other than a practical arrangement between two people who had something the other needed.

“At Terce” he said.